



PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025

The House met at the Chamber,

Parliament House, at 12:54 p.m.

[HON SECOND DEPUTY SPEAKER,
MR ANDREW ASIAMAHO AMOAKO,
IN THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to the item numbered 5—Correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We would begin with the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 2nd December, 2025.

Page 1...10. Yes, Hon Member for South Dayi and the Majority Chief Whip.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the item numbered 8(a), on the page numbered 9 of the *Votes and Proceedings*. I laid the Paper on behalf of Mr Mahama Ayariga, who is the Chairperson of the Committee on

Independent Constitutional Bodies. Because of research and such other things, it is important that we indicate who the Chairpersons of these Committees are.

As part of our recent orientation, we indicated that we should be more particular about some of these things.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: As part of what?

Mr Dafeamekpor: The orientation we had recently for Leadership of Committees— Some complained that they appear to be buried in some of these things, so we agreed that we would be more particular about their role.

I am humbly proposing that, we insert this “...on behalf of Hon Mahama Ayariga, the Chairman of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies.”

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Well, I was thinking all these details would be captured in the *Official Report*.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, yes, in fact, that is the protocol. But when we had the retreat two weeks ago for Leadership of Committees, they raised some of these things and we need to respond to the concerns that they raised.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Yes, Hon Minority Chief Whip.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, there are no issues with the observation made by the Majority Chief Whip. But on the same page, I recall the Majority Chief Whip also laid a Paper for and on behalf of the Minister for Education. That was the University of Engineering and Agricultural Science Bill.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, we turn to the page numbered 10.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, consequentially on the page numbered 10, the item numbered (b), the Chairperson for Committee on Parliamentary Affairs is Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah. So, if the Table can give the indication. So, it should read, "...by the Hon Majority Chief Whip, on behalf of Hon Kwamena Okyere Darko-Mensah, the Chairman of the Committee on Parliamentary Affairs."

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Table, kindly acknowledge that particular correction.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, then consequentially, the item (c) would read "...on behalf of Mr Isaac Adjei Mensah, the Chairman of the Committee on Roads and Transportation". Then, the item (d) would read "...on behalf of the Hon Vincent Oppong Asamoah, the Chairman of the Committee on Works and Housing".

Consequentially, I can provide the Table with the names—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Table, kindly acknowledge those names.

Page 11...14—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, on the page numbered 12, the item (i), the Report was taken by the Ms Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, First Deputy Whip, on behalf of the Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso. So, I would provide the details for the Table.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Table, all that the Majority Chief Whip seeks to bring to the fore is that, you should not just give the title, but let the names of the people holding those titles also appear.

So, by the Hon Comfort Doyoe Cudjoe, First Deputy Majority Whip.

Majority Chief Whip, I think that is what you wanted to portray.

1:04 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, she did it on behalf of the Chairperson, Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso. So, Rev Helen Adjoa Ntoso's name should also appear.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, what I am getting from you is that the names should appear.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, the names should appear.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We turn to page 16...23 —

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie? If I did not see you on your feet, then probably, we would not be reviewing the *Votes and Proceedings*.

Mr Frank Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. May I draw attention respectfully to item number xviii on page 23. The Director-General for Ghana Health Service, he is titled; he is a medical doctor and a professor as well. So, if the Clerks-at-the-Table could take note and do the needful accordingly.

Again, xx, Mr Peter Kwame Yeboah, who is the Executive Director, Christian Health Association of Ghana. He is also a doctor. So, if that could also be corrected.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, the titles—Table, kindly acknowledge those corrections.

Page 24—

Yes, Hon Member for Afadjato South?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, again, just a minor one. At xxxii, that is 32. The health coordinator for the hospital at Kasei, the name is “Kasei”, that is St. Luke Hospital. Over here, it is spelled “Kesei” It should be Kasei.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, kindly acknowledge it.

Page 25...34?

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 2nd December, 2025, is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, I have in my hands the *Official Report* of Friday, 21st November, 2025. Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

Mr Afriyie: Mr Speaker, thank you. May I kindly invite you to column 9, the very last paragraph. Mr Elvis Osei Mensah Dapaah, the name of the Constituency is Ahafo Ano South West. If my pronunciation is not correct, pardon me. So over here, it is written “Aha Ano South West”; it should be Ahafo Ano South West.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Some people are very detailed. So, Hon Member for Afadjato South, I commend you. Before you came to this Chamber, it used to be Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa then Hon Prof Kingsley Nyarko took over and now you have joined, keep it up.

Hon Members, in the absence of any further corrections, the *Official Report* of 21st November, 2025 is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, before we zoom into Public Business, let me acknowledge, at the Public Gallery, some visitors. The first group is Ashesi University. They are

being led by Dr Hassan Wahab, who is the Head of Department and the school is located in the Akuapem South Constituency. You are welcome.

We again have Lovely Arms Montessori School. They are also here being led by Julius Kudzo Ashinyo, the Headteacher and the school is located in the Tema West Constituency. You are welcome.

The last group is Overcomers Remedial Centre. They are being led by Bismark Kwame Acquah, who is the Headteacher, and the school is located in the Anyaa- Sowutuom Constituency. We do not have the Members here. The Hon Member for Tema West is here. Hon Member, I hope you would take care of them. You have to do so.

[Students of Ashesi University were acknowledged.]

[Pupils of Lovely Arms Montessori School were acknowledged.]

[Students of Overcomers Remedial Centre were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Majority Chief Whip, let me come to you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may we vary the Order of Business so that we can take the item numbered 7.

We have one important urgent Statement standing in the name of the Hon Deputy Minister for Finance, Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem.

1:14 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. I will allow him to read, and I would limit the comments because we have a whole lot of Business to conduct today.

So, Hon Minister, you have the floor.

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are not objecting to the Hon Minister reading his Statement. Unfortunately, we have been urged to respect the Orders, and the provisions of Order 93(8) make it imperative that the Clerk should make copies of such admitted Statements to Hon Members. But, in the spirit of eastern solidarity, and also the fact that he is a Friend of this Chamber—He is a Friend to the House; aside from that, these days, he has not been visiting the Speaker. The Speaker says he used to be a good boy. This is *pro bono*. Mr Speaker, his visitation to the office of the Speaker must be regularised, especially the Chief Whips; it has been a long time since they visited our offices.

Mr Speaker, we will stage a compromise for him to do it, but he should take a cue; we are watching him with an eagle eye.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, have you seen how this particular Statement —

Hon Minister, let us hear you.

STATEMENT

December in Akosombo and Beyond: Strengthening Tourism for Local Economic Development

Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem (NDC — Asuogyaman): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make this brief Statement. I rise today, not only as a Member of Parliament for Asuogyaman, but also as the voice of a district standing at the centre of Ghana's next big tourism leap. Akosombo and Asuogyaman districts are no longer just “where the Dam is”; it is fast becoming the hub of domestic tourism, investment, culture and creative enterprise.

My purpose is twofold:

- i. to highlight the emergence of Akosombo and Asuogyaman as a preferred tourism and travel destination;
- ii. to invite Hon Members of this House and Ghanaians on a journey to unlock this potential, starting with our “December in Akosombo” initiative.

Mr Speaker, Akosombo is where Ghana proved to the world that we could dream boldly and build even bolder. The Akosombo Dam created Lake Volta, the largest man-made lake on earth. The Dam became the backbone of Ghana's electricity generation. It powered our factories, lit our homes, strengthened regional cooperation and opened the door to new economic sectors, fisheries, logistics, water transport and now, a booming tourism economy.

Mr Speaker, with major attractions such as the Adomi Bridge, Dodi Island, the Dodi Princess Cruise and a cluster of iconic hotels, the Royal Senchi, the Peninsula Hotel, the Bridgeview, Volta Hotel among others, Akosombo continues to assert itself as a thriving travel and tourism enclave. We know that Ghana is experiencing a tourism renaissance. International arrivals have surged back past the one million mark. Domestic tourism has exploded with over a million Ghanaians travelling nationwide since 2023.

Mr Speaker, with inflation down today at 6.3 per cent, the lowest in more than a decade, with the dollar down, and with fuel prices down, we can expect a boom in domestic tourism this December and beyond. We also know that the modern traveller is changing. They want nature, serenity, open skies and restorative cultural experiences.

Mr Speaker, the traveller Ghana has today is exactly the traveller Akosombo and Asuogyaman was built for. This December, we are responding with a bold, district-wide initiative: “The Asuogyaman, Tourism and Arts Festival”, to showcase culture, talent and creative experience. Launched last month at the iconic Bridgeview Hotel in Atimpoku, the festival signals a renewed partnership between the Asuogyaman District Assembly, private sector actors and local creatives to consolidate the district as a leading domestic tourism destination.

Mr Speaker, allow me to briefly outline the key activities that make up the festival calendar. As part of the ensuing

activities, the Miss Asuogyaman pageant will take place on 7th December, to promote culture, confidence and creativity among young women in the district. Our young men and indeed any daring young woman will also display their athletic prowess in the Asuogyaman Strongest Competition, a sporting event designed to encourage fitness, discipline and healthy competition.

In addition, a special Railway Tour Package has been curated for tourists featuring a unique train journey from Tema Harbour Station to the Adomi Station. This package includes guided visits to the Akosombo Dam, the Akwamu Museum and the iconic Adomi Bridge from 4th to 7th December. The main festival week will feature an exciting lineup of activities, including street floats, water sports, regatta, a cultural derby, candlelight procession and fireworks display, alongside trade exhibitions, live band performances and other enticing attractions.

Mr Speaker, flowing from these activities, the flagship event for this festive season is the Akosombo Street Carnival (ASC), 2025, scheduled for 19th to 21st December. The carnival will transform Akosombo into a corridor of music, colour, culture and commerce. Live stages, cultural exhibitions, dance groups and street fashion will showcase the diversity of Ghanaian creativity, while numerous food stands will serve local and contemporary meals. Workshops, mentorship sessions, talent showcases and career guidance will connect young creatives to industry

leaders, while boosting local businesses and enhancing Akosombo's profile as a cultural hotspot.

Mr Speaker, the Akosombo Street Carnival complements other December activities in the area to position Akosombo as a “Detty December by the Lake” destination. On 21st December 2025, there will be a grand Akwasidae Festival at the forecourt of the Bogyawe Palace at Akwamufie, where the Akwamuhene Odineho Kwarfo III, Nana Afrakoma II, one of the longest serving Queen Mothers, who has been on the throne for more than 50 years, will display the Akan Akwamu culture.

Mr Speaker, new hotels, resorts, restaurants and event venues continue to emerge and attract corporate travels, weddings, family vacations and conferences. From multi-star rated hotels to budget-friendly guest houses, Asuogyaman offers diverse options for travellers and holidaymakers.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, working with the regional and district security committees, we continue to prioritise the safety and security of all residents and visitors. As can be expected, they will beef up security during this festive season and enhance patrols to ensure safe driving to and within Asuogyaman.

Mr Speaker, Akosombo holds a special place in Ghana's history. It is where our ambitions for industrialisation first took visible concrete form. It is where the Volta River was tamed to power our homes and industries. And

today, it is where energy, tourism and culture are converging to create inclusive local economic development.

1:24 p.m.

Mr Speaker, as a proud Member of Parliament for the area, I wish to extend a warm invitation to Ghanaians and our brothers and sisters in the diaspora to make Akosombo the holiday destination of choice in December and indeed, a year-round travel destination.

Mr Speaker, Akosombo can and must move from being known only as where the Dam is to being recognised as a leading tourism and culture destination. Thank you for the opportunity as we work to unlock the full economic potential of Akosombo and the Asuogyaman District. Welcome to Asuogyaman.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will take two comments each, including Leadership. Yes, Hon Member for Bosome Freho. Your place is also full of tourism.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, having realised how important the Statement is, we want to pray you to take two from each Side, then the Leadership will conclude.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: After this Statement, I will be taking another one. So, bear with me, I will take one from each Side, and then come to Leadership.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Mr Speaker, thank you.

Let me first and foremost commend the maker of the Statement, Hon Thomas Nyarko Ampem. There is a certain nostalgic feeling in commenting on, hearing or reading this Statement. I was born, raised and schooled in Akosombo. In fact, at one point, he was my teacher. So, I want to commend him.

Mr Speaker, this Statement is long overdue. This process of putting Akosombo on the map is long overdue. It is not just a destination; it is a whole Hollywood, Bollywood, whatever one can imagine and think of. We have culture, streetism and “Gen Z-ism”, everything put together in Akosombo.

Mr Speaker, along the banks, we have packages for those who are middle class, high class and the local class — the hotels he mentioned like Continental, Bridgeview, the Peninsula and the Volta Hotel. Those days, when we were young, Akosombo was one of the areas where, if one wanted to enjoy good music at the Volta Hotel, popularly known as “Happy Hour”, one would go to enjoy the Happy Hour, and after 10 o’clock, move to the Adowa Nightclub, the popular Adowa Nightclub of those days. Now it has been turned from Adowa Nightclub to the Sankofa Nightclub, and it is still popping and hitting.

Mr Speaker, from Atimpoku along the Adomi Bridge, throughout the night, it is like Oxford Street in the United Kingdom; very busy, entertaining and welcoming. So, I think that the Hon

Member must and should, in all his capacity, ensure that this area, full of natural resources, culture and everything I mentioned, becomes one of the areas for entertainment and tourism that people would move to. Mr Speaker, Akosombo is not far from Accra; it is about an hour and 30-minutes' drive from Accra. I believe strongly that if one really wants to have fun, enjoy, be entertained and relax, it is not in Accra. One can move about one hour, 30 minutes from Accra, hit the Afienya Road and get to Akosombo.

So, Mr Speaker, I commend him, and the part that I am so enthused about is the streetism and “Gen Z-ism” blend with culture. The Akosombo area is largely ruled by the Akwamus, and when one gets to Akosombo, one can see how the Member of Parliament and organisers are integrating the traditional leaders and their culture into the fun pack. I want to commend them again and say that it is not just the continental and the hotel dishes. There is *Aboolo*, *One Mouth Thousand*, *Akpɔhe*, *Abobi*, *Tsofi* and everything. There is a package for one's pocket.

Mr Speaker, I want to, with these few words, commend the maker of the Statement for bringing out this very important initiative that needs to be encouraged in the Akosombo area. Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It appears you have made the Statement your own. Are you going to be there?

Mr Ayeh: Mr Speaker, I will be in Ankaase, Lake Bosomtwe, for Christmas. We also have some packages there. But because it is my place, I can feel it. So, I will pass through maybe during January. But for Christmas, I will be with my people.

Thank you very much.

Prof Titus Kofi Beyuo (NDC—Lambussie): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity.

Let me commend the maker of the Statement. I think he has done justice to marketing his constituency, and we really welcome such initiative. I think the “Detty December” concept that he has localised to Akosombo, and for anyone who knows there, would indeed agree with him that it is one of the best tourism destinations. Its proximity to the capital city makes it even more convenient, and it is not an expensive place. There are a full range of hotel activities that one can participate in. I think one of the limitations to us visiting that place and having a very good time has been the poor road network.

I want to commend the visionary leadership of H.E John Dramani Mahama for bringing the Big Push agenda to ensure that the next time they celebrate this festival, people can quickly just drive there, have fun, and come back. One of the interesting parts of the road trip to Akosombo, and I go there quite often—We usually want to stop by and enjoy the scenery, especially when we get to where the monkeys are, and our kids are happy to see them. The monkeys

come very close and are very friendly. And when one gets to Akosombo itself, the Adomi Bridge is an iconic thing that everybody in Ghana who has not been there will want to see.

I am very excited to hear about the celebration of culture. And the Queen Mother, Nana Afrakoma II, who has been on the throne for more than 50 years—I think this is worth celebrating. And I will implore the Hon Member that after this celebration, he should try and bring another Statement here for us to celebrate the good work of this Queen Mother, so that she can be an example to other women leaders and traditional leaders in this country.

In wrapping up, I want to say that December is a very busy month in the country, and the Minister for Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts has been busy launching various activities to attract people from the diaspora to join us to spend time and celebrate our culture. I know various constituencies have similar programmes. I was planning to be at the Masquerade Festival in Takoradi, but now I am being tempted to see if I can visit Akosombo. *[Laughter]*

I intend to celebrate the new year in my constituency, so I have the Christmas period to visit other constituencies.

1:34 p.m.

During the New Year period, we have a very huge festival in the Lambussie Traditional Area called the Mifele-Gbero Festival where we celebrate our new grain with our chiefs. There is a rich

display of culture. So, while I join colleagues, I would also use the opportunity to invite people to visit Lambussie. When you are at Lambussie, you are close to the boarder. You can cross over the Burkina Faso, come back and have a good time.

Thank you so much for the opportunity, and I commend the maker of the Statement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He has also taken advantage to invite people.

Yes, let me go the My senior, the Hon Member for Takoradi.

Mr Kwabena Okyere Darko-Mensah (NPP — Takoradi): Mr Speaker, I am very happy to contribute to this Statement. In fact, I have known Mr Ampem since he was the District Chief Executive for Asuogyaman District. From then, I have recognised his effort in promoting his district. I have actually risen up to support him for one particular reason. We know that I come from Amansie. We know that when we talk about the Akwamu history, its origins started from Amansie, Asantemanso, all the way to Twifo Praso, to Asamankese to the mountains. I see it as a contribution and support for a Brother. I know that now that they are starting something new, there will be challenges. For me, the most important thing is how to sustain it going forward, when Mr Ampem is no more the Member of Parliament and no longer the Deputy Minister for Finance. I believe that this is the beginning. In December, everybody knows that the Christmas city of Ghana

is Takoradi. But for this purpose, we want to give the Hon Member an advice so that he will be able to sustain this going forward because they are closer to Accra. Even though we can use 25 minutes to get to Takoradi, he has to use an hour or an hour and thirty minutes. The key issue, I believe is that everybody knows Akosombo, and we should be able to attract especially now, visitors into Accra to not just do a lot of things in Accra but to also see Akosombo as an alternative to Accra. One of the key issues is that Akosombo, because it is farther away from Accra, will give a lot of customers and clients the peace of mind to enjoy themselves while they are at Akosombo.

Secondly, I also do believe that in getting the youth involved, we should also let them understand that we have to move from social mobilisation to economic mobilisation as part of this new programming. Sponsorship is one of the major difficulties we tend to have when we are organising a lot of these programmes. If we are able to lock in that now, we should be able to consistently deliver this programme over a long period of time.

Thirdly, I also believe that now that the chiefs have got involved, we should centre all these things around them. In fact, it will make a lot of the culture popular, and the youth will easily connect with it. Most of the time when it is pure tradition, they find it very difficult to connect. Now education is on the internet, they are thinking more about abroad, things that people do outside this country, and they sometimes think that

the traditions that they participate in are “colo”. Meanwhile, they have been in existence for a very long time, and they have survived the test of time. I believe that if we are able to revolve it around the chiefs, they will also make sure that apart from their own traditional activities that they do, they will be able to bring this on board. I remember some time ago, the Juabenhene was dancing *Azonto*, and it made *Azonto* very popular. If we are able to get our chiefs to also acquaint themselves with the new things we want to do now, a lot of the young people will feel the stamp of recognition, and they will easily connect and make sure that they are part and parcel of this programme now and going forward.

Mr Speaker, I have seen that you are holding your microphone. I would like to conclude. In conclusion, I would say that Mr Ampem has done a very good job. We need to support him to succeed, and I believe that if the programme is extended, maybe after Christmas, we can also pass through Akosombo one day before we go to the village.

Thank you very much.

Mr Frank Afriyie (NDC — Afadjato South): Mr Speaker, let me use the opportunity to also thank the maker of this very important Statement. Without doubt, the Statement is as important as the personality. Indeed, I will add that we do not waste time in giving the Deputy Minister his bill for the free adverts he has done for his constituency in the Chamber.

It is important to add my voice to the statement made, that the Asuogyaman Constituency is indeed one of the most important ones when it comes to domestic tourism, culture, and commerce. Indeed, this same constituency houses very iconic national infrastructure such as the Akosombo Dam and the Adomi Bridge for those of us who are from the Volta Region, Oti Region and part of the northern enclave. Indeed, the day the MP and his constituents decide to block the Adomi Bridge is the last day we will be able to go to our various constituencies. Clearly, it is very important that all of us support this very Statement in making the Asuogyaman Constituency a very important one more than this.

Mr Speaker, the decision to organise a cultural festival this December in order to add value to their ecotourist facilities and to enhance them, I think, is in the right direction, because it creates lots of jobs for our teeming youth and women. If you get to Atimpoku, particularly on Fridays and weekends, the number of youth and women who sell by the roadside are not only from that constituency, but most of them have even migrated from very faraway constituencies in order to make livelihoods in selling at the bridge. Indeed, a festival of this nature can only bring many customers to them.

I wish to also highlight the importance of preserving nature and investing in nature. Today, one of the most important issues of national security dimension is the alarming rates of the *galamsey* menace. So, when a

constituency like Asuogyaman decides to invest in nature, preserve nature, preserve the serenity of nature, we can only be grateful to them and support them. Through such preservation, I believe we will be able to generate very sustainable jobs for our youth, our women, and at the same time, preserve the integrity of the ecological system. With these few words, may I also use the opportunity once again to thank the maker of the Statement. Thank you so much.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompseh): Mr Speaker, Colleagues who have spoken earlier have all commended our Friend, but we must single Mr Speaker out and commend him, because the admission of the Statement is in the bosom of the Speaker. If it had not been Mr Speaker, he would not be receiving all these commendations.

However, I must emphasise that our Colleague has set the tone for a certain renewed effort towards the promotion of tourism generally in this country, and he has also told us in plain words that as Members of Parliament, there are roles we have to play. It cannot only be at the doorstep of the mandated Ministry. We can act as the voice of various municipalities and districts in rallying around stakeholders towards the call for a change in the promotion of tourism. So, our Friend, we are grateful. It also goes beyond Akosombo; it cannot just be Akosombo. I see the Hon Member's Statement as nudging this House to have the necessary consciousness in terms of tourism promotion. Akosombo is just a platform that he is using.

1:44 p.m.

Interestingly, my children grew up at Akosombo. I used to visit Akosombo many times with the Hon Member for Bosome Freho, Hon Asafo-Adjei, so I know Akosombo quite well. My worry now is beyond the Statement —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which names did you mention? I am interested in the names of that the people you moved with. *[Laughter]*

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I move with many more people, especially my friend. Many of our Colleagues do not know, but maybe I should do a full declaration. Hon Rockson and I have been friends since two decades ago, at Casely Hayford (Casford) Hall at the University of Cape Coast, when he was seeking to become the Hall President—I am a full and a proud “Casfordian”. Unfortunately, he could not win but he is the Hall President we never had; solid Rockson.

My worry beyond the Statement is that we should sustain this conversation into the night, and also agree to the point that it cannot be limited to Akosombo only. In the over 200 districts that we have in this country, every district has a certain unique nature-based artefact, and it is our responsibility as a country to project these unique artefacts; that is what we have been failing to do.

Clearly, Hon Ampem is taking absolute control of Asuogyaman but now he is running faster than I can imagine. He is clearly telling his competitors to stay away. Anyway, this is just by the

way. Again, it is limiting for me when he limits himself to December. It cannot just be December. I think it should just be an all-year-round advocacy. We should rally – it should not be partisan – I know he is not that type. He should get all the stakeholders like the assemblies to the drawing table. Thankfully, his good self has been a District Chief Executive before, so he should reach out to all the people who matter.

Tourism promotion should go beyond hotels and beyond brick and mortar. I am concerned that beyond the hotels, what is it that is unique about Akosombo? He knows it, and that is where the focus should be. I am only saddened that he did not talk about climate concerns, this is because we have the biggest man-made lake in his Constituency. We need to protect flora and fauna. When we stand across the Volta River, there is a huge forest. We should be thinking about how we can protect that forest, because there is an interface between the forest and the river body, that is the Volta Lake. His Statement did not touch on it.

I have seen a number of programmes he has itemised. Asuogyaman’s strongest competition, the railway tour package along the Mpakadan, and the Asuogyaman Tourism and Art Festival. We should be concerned about it because all these festivals would happen on the soil; flora and fauna. How do we protect this? For me that is the crux of the matter. I want to commend him. This is also a wake-up call to all of us.

Interestingly, Nsawam is closer to Accra than Asuogyaman and he knows

it. So, he has rather exposed me today, that we have been a sleeping giant. At least we have Nsawam bread, Nsawam *tsofi* and all that we can think about. So, I take a cue from the direction our Colleague has provided and probably we should hold our hands, and work together with the Ministry of Tourism, Culture and Creative Arts to promote tourism and this consciousness in our various districts. Having said that, I commend him. I now understand why he called me about this Statement.

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson E.K. Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, let me commend my Brother. When he called me about it, I asked the Hon Ampem what Statement has he brought at this time of the year when we are considering his Instruments and Estimates. When he gave me the Statement, I saw the real importance and relevance given the times.

Mr Speaker our duty as the elected representatives of the people is to occasionally advocate for the interest of the people we represent. I believe this festival is very key to the community in Asuogyaman. Asuogyaman and South Dayi are contiguous; we share the eastern and the volta boundary, not only on land but through the mighty Volta, but people do not know that. In fact, more than half of the Dodi Island is in my constituency, so the things we share are common, including the people, families and all.

Now I am particularly happy he has brought this to the Floor, because when we go to Dar es Salaam, and we want to

travel to Zanzibar which is by the sea, we go by boat. They use luxury boats for the passengers. The bigger ones take one and a half hours, but what they call the water taxis take 45 minutes and we pay more. So, in Asuogyaman at Akosombo, we have the Volta Lake Transport Company. I think we considered their Estimates yesterday. We need to look at the opportunity of this House allocating some funding for the Volta Lake Transport Company to acquire these water taxis; they are not too expensive. If we have about four or five that dock at Akosombo, we can do a lake tour all the way to Yeji and back. People can spend money and we can have transit quarters built along Dzememi, Kpando, Torkor, Agordeke and Abotoase.

Like the Hon Annoh-Dompreh said, this cannot be reserved for only December. It must be a yearlong activity that must be properly packaged. We can attract people from the sub-region. Look at the Nigerian population, they are looking for something to visit Ghana and spend. The multiplied effect of what they will come and do here will be huge. So, we want to thank him for bringing this to the attention of the House.

We want to encourage Members to identify things like this in their constituencies and bring it to the Floor for our attention. I thank you Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much Hon Members. We will take another Statement. But before then, allow me to also acknowledge some international visitors, our Colleagues

from the Ugandan Parliament who are here on a study visit. They have been here since Monday. They are: Mr James Mukaga who is the Assistant Director, Mr Paul W. Terugulwa who is the Principal Clerk, Ms Christine Kyomuhendo who is the Principal Clerk, Mr John Jones Ssentumbwe who is the Senior Clerk Assistant, Ms Brenda Laura Kayitesi—Did I not pronounce the name well? How do you pronounce it? Mr Guma Warren Stuart, Ms Diana Amero, Ms Ben Opus, and last but not least, we have Modesto Jawuyambe.

1:54 p.m.

You are all welcome. We wish you a pleasant stay in Ghana. Ghanaians are naturally very accommodating, so feel free and feel at home. You are once again welcome.

[Visitors from the Parliament of Uganda were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Again, in the Public Gallery, we have Labone Senior High School. They are led by Stanley Abban, who is a teacher, and the school is located in Dadekotopon Constituency. You are also welcome.

[Students of Labone Senior High School were acknowledged.]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me invite Hon Member for Berekum West, Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah, to quickly read his Statement. I am just giving you a few minutes, because we have a lot of programmes today. I would be unfair if I did not give you the opportunity to read your Statement. You have the floor now.

STATEMENTS

Increasing Spate of Armed Robbery on the Jinijini-Drobo Road

Mr Dickson Kyere-Duah (NDC — Berekum West): Mr Speaker, thank you very much, for the opportunity to deliver this urgent Statement on the issue that continues to endanger the safety, peace, and economic stability of the good people of Berekum West and Jaman South Municipalities. The matter before us today is the escalating number of armed robbery attacks along the Jinijini-Drobo section of the Berekum-Sampa Road, a situation made worse by the poor condition of the road.

Mr Speaker, the Jinijini-Drobo Road is one of the most important corridors in the Bono Region. It connects two significantly populated municipalities, that is Berekum West and Jaman South, and links to the Sampa Border enclave, which serves as a major route for cross-border trade between Ghana and Cote d'Ivoire. The road facilitates economic activities, transportation of agricultural products, movement of goods and services, and serves as a key educational and administrative link.

Mr Speaker, unfortunately, this critical stretch of road has deteriorated into a near-death trap, with deep potholes, uneven spaces, poor drainage, and severely eroded portions. Motorists are forced to slow down drastically or swerve in dangerous patterns, creating ideal conditions for armed robbers to pounce.

Mr Speaker, in the last few months, there have been multiple cases of violent robberies, some occurring in broad daylight. Several passengers have been brutalised and their personal belongings and millions of cash have been stolen. Some of these incidents have left others severely injured, psychologically traumatised, and fearful of using this once vibrant route.

Mr Speaker, public transport drivers, traders, teachers, health workers, and farmers who ply this route on a daily basis are now living in fear. Some have even resorted to avoiding the route altogether. The Bono Regional Command, in collaboration with the Berekum Divisional Police, is doing their best with the limited logistics at its disposal.

Mr Speaker, some of the major challenges against the fight of this menace are inadequate personnel and the lack of dedicated patrol vehicles on the stretch. It is also clear that the terrain created by the deplorable state of the road makes policing extremely difficult. Criminals exploit the bad portions of the route and attack their victims. Mr Speaker, let me emphasise that this situation is not merely a security challenge. It is also a direct consequence of the poor nature of the Jinijini-Drobo Road, which has created fertile ground for these criminals to operate.

Mr Speaker, the stretch in question is part of the Jinijini-Sampa Road, which, fortunately, has now been listed under the Government's Big Push infrastructure initiative. I am very grateful to the Hon

Minister for Roads and Highways for his dedication to ensuring the completion of this project. Mr Speaker, the ramifications of this matter are broad, as these developments threaten not only the livelihoods of the people but also the peace and stability of the Region.

Mr Speaker, given the urgency of the matter, I respectfully call for the following interventions: Deployment of enhanced police visibility by providing the Berekum Divisional Command with additional personnel, patrol vehicles, and logistics to intensify day and night patrols on the stretch, and fast-tracking the full construction of the Jinijini-Sampa Road by ensuring that the contractor mobilises fully to the site as soon as possible.

Mr Speaker, the people of Jinijini-Drobo and surrounding communities are hard-working Ghanaians who seek safety, dignity, and the freedom to move without fear. This esteemed House has the responsibility to oversee and protect the welfare of its citizens.

I respectfully encourage Parliament to pay close attention to this issue and support efforts to speed up security and road infrastructure improvements. As representatives of the people, we have a solemn duty to act.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for indulging me. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I would only take one comment from each Side. Please bear with me; we have so many Reports to take.

Hon Member for Effia—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me pray that you rather take Leadership, then we can yield to anybody who wants to make that comment.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Whichever way.

Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko (NPP — Effia): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to comment on the urgent Statement made by the Hon Member for Berekum West. Inasmuch as it is affecting his constituency, it is still a national issue for this House to join hands with him and see how best the problem can be resolved.

Mr Speaker, this is a Statement talking about the rampant armed robbery occurrences within the stretch of Jinijini, Berekum, and Sampa. According to the maker of the Statement, the armed robbery is being facilitated by the poor and devastating nature of the road. Coupled with it is the fact that people who trade within that particular stretch have their lives at stake because armed robbery can happen to anybody. It is not only those who live within the Berekum area who trade between the Jinijini and Sampa routes. We have people coming all the way from Accra, Kumasi, Takoradi, and the rest who go to those areas and buy products for their markets.

Mr Speaker, the road, according to the maker of the Statement, has now been captured under the Big Push initiative. But the difficulty, I have always said, is that yes, roads are being

captured under the Big Push initiative, *na sika no wo hen* to construct the roads. So, it is good that it has been identified. But if we delay in the execution of the road projects, as we have seen over this year, when less allocation was made in the area of road infrastructural development, then this matter will be of concern to the good people of Berekum and Jinijini.

2:04 p.m.

Mr Speaker, we still have concerns about police visibility and patrol on that particular stretch. I do not know whether this issue has come to the attention of the Inspector General of Police (IGP), because when it comes to security matters, if it goes beyond the capacity of the divisional command and the regional command, then importantly, national headquarters would have to take up the issue for consideration. I will use this platform to call on the IGP, since this has been raised in this august House, to pay particular attention to the security concern, the presence of the police, to protect lives and property along that stretch.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I want to urge this House, as a matter of urgency, to call on the Minister for Roads and Highways to pay attention to all road infrastructure in this country. The Big Push should not be just talk. It should be work. And I am praying that in the year 2026, money will be released. We have seen in this Budget that Government has not released money for the construction of roads. So, I sympathise with my Brother from Jinijini. I hope that through

the Big Push, based on this conversation, the road will be constructed.

Mr Speaker, without more, I want to thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Member for Sawla/Tuna/Kalba?

Mr Andrew Dari Chiwitey (NDC — Sawla/ Tuna/ Kalba): Thank you so much, Mr Speaker, for giving me the opportunity to comment on the Statement, ably delivered by the Hon Member for Berekum West.

Mr Speaker, his Statement is one that is waking all Ghanaians up. I travelled on the stretch of road that the Hon Member spoke about a number of times when I was a teacher in Sunyani. I had a family friend in Sampa, so I used that road very often. That road is not a mere road. It is an international road that links Ghana to the Ivory Coast. You can travel from Drobo through Suma-Ahenkro to Sampa, and then you can cross to Bondoukou in Ivory Coast. So, it is an international road that needs a lot of attention.

Mr Speaker, in his delivery, he made us aware that armed robbers have taken over the road and are troubling the people who travel on that road. I do not intend to generate debate, but it is a fact that for the past eight or nine years, Ghana witnessed a lot of challenges as far as work on our roads are concerned. In my debate on the Budget, I raised the

issue of the past government declaring twice “the year of roads”, but we never saw the quality roads. The people of Jinijini, Drobo, Suma-Ahenkro, and Sampa are struggling and suffering on that bad road because we never saw good works done on our roads during the administration of the past government.

But good news has come. My Brother who just spoke, let me remind him that as for the NDC Government, we are people who speak and deliver. So, like I said, I do not intend to generate debate, but he should rest assured that the Big Push is not going to be a mere talk. We are going to walk our talk. We have already started seeing the signs.

Another assurance that I would want to give my Brother on the other Side is that the Road Fund has come to stay. Government is putting in place the board of directors, and very soon we will have some funds from the Road Fund to work on similar roads. So, the people of Jinijini and Berekum West in general, should rest assured that the solution is coming.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity. We will continue to work to serve our people better.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Hon Members, I said this Statement was the last one, but incidentally, today is the International Day for Persons with Disabilities. So, we have three Statements to that effect, all of them commemorating the day. So, I am

inclined to invite only one person to read the Statement, and the other two will corroborate. Are you with me?

Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, with respect, we also have a number of Statements from our Side. When we went to Conclave, the understanding was that we will take one Statement that stood in the name of Hon Nyarko Ampem. My Members are worried because they also have Statements that have been admitted: Hon Onyina-Acheampong, a number of them. It makes the work difficult for Leadership.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Forgive us, but because today is a day for people with disability, I am inclined to take that Statement, but I will let just one person read. I am not going to take all the three Statements. I will just let one person to read, and the other two will comment. I hope you are with me?

Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

Mr Mahama Ayariga: Mr Speaker, it is very easy. The three have written Statements. So, allow one person to read. The “apor” that the other two have, they will use it to comment. *[Laughter]*

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I share in the concerns of the Hon Minority Chief Whip. It appears that all the Statements incidentally emanate from our Side, but it was not deliberate. The first one, we agreed; the second one was from Speakership, but the third one, we all glossed over it. Today is World

Disability Day, and sometimes you lead the charge when you were here, so, it being that important, we are proposing that the Member only presents it within five minutes, then we will take a comment from the Minority Side, and we end it.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I am not a difficult person; I cooperate. But as an appeal, since we have taken three from your Side today, let us come to an understanding that tomorrow, we will take at least, two from our Side.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Well noted.

So, we have two gentlemen and a lady, so, I am inclined to give the slot to the lady. Hon Member for Ablekuma North, Ewurabena Aubynn, I will give you the floor to read your Statement.

Statement on the International Day of Persons with Disabilities

Ms Ewurabena Aubynn (NDC — Ablekuma North): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I am grateful for the opportunity to make this Statement on the 2025 International Day of Persons with Disabilities, being commemorated globally on the theme, *Fostering Disability: Inclusive Societies for Advancing Social Progress*. The theme calls on all nations to strengthen the systems and policies that guarantee full inclusion and equal participation of persons with disabilities (PWDs) in national development.

Mr Speaker, today's commemoration is historic for Ghana, as we mark the first year of the Free Tertiary Education for Persons with Disabilities Policy launched on 25th October, 2025. This initiative, implemented through the Students' Loan Trust Fund with support from Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund), absolves tuition for all persons with disabilities admitted to accredited public tertiary institutions. Mr Speaker, this is not an act of charity. It is constitutional justice, rooted in Article 25 of the 1992 Constitution and the Persons with Disabilities Act, 2006 (Act 715), which guarantees equal access to education.

Mr Speaker, according to the 2021 Population and Housing Census, 2.1 million Ghanaians, representing about 8 per cent of the population live with disability. Disability prevalence is higher among females, more pronounced in rural communities, and visual impairment remains the most common disability type. Among the elderly, 38 per cent live with at least one disability, increasing vulnerability to exclusion.

2:14 p.m.

Mr Speaker, these statistics reflect significant socio-economic disparities. Unemployment among PWDs is nearly double the national average, and only a quarter progress beyond basic education, and fewer than 5 per cent reach tertiary level. The barriers include inaccessible buildings, mobility challenges, high cost of assistive devices, and persistent stigma.

Mr Speaker, the Free Tertiary Education Initiative is a bold step forward, but its success depends heavily on accessibility. The Ghana Building Code, G.S. 1207-2018, developed by the Ghana Standards Authority, mandates that all public buildings must incorporate accessibility features for persons with disabilities. These include ramps, elevators, tactile indicators, accessible washrooms, disability-friendly pathways and designated parking spaces. Yet, many public tertiary institutions and public buildings remain non-compliant.

Mr Speaker, to give full effect to this year's theme, I respectfully propose the following:

One, sustainable financing to ensure predictable funding to the Students' Loan Trust Fund and GETFund to support fee absorption for all eligible persons with disabilities. Two, strict enforcement of the Ghana Building Code, G.S. 1207-2018, through mandatory compliance audits. Three, provision of assistive technologies such as sign-language interpreters, the braille materials, audio resources, and inclusive digital learning platforms.

Four, mobility and welfare support, including transport stipends or dedicated shuttle services. Five, improved data and monitoring systems to guide targeted interventions. Six, public sensitisation to reduce stigma and promote respect, dignity, and inclusion. Seven, employment pathways through internships and fair recruitment for graduates with disabilities.

Mr Speaker, as we observe the 2025 International Day of Persons with Disabilities, Ghana stands at an important turning point. Free Tertiary Education Programme for Persons with Disabilities is a bold and progressive intervention. Its impact, however, will depend on full enforcement of accessibility standards, sustained policy reforms, and a national commitment ensuring that disability does not limit opportunity. Our collective responsibility is to build a society where every Ghanaian, irrespective of their physical, sensory, intellectual, or psychosocial disability, has the environment, support and opportunity to thrive.

Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity once again. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

So, I would invite, Mr Felix Akwetey Okle, Member of Parliament for Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro). You also wrote a Statement, so I would give you the floor to make a comment—*[Interruption]*—No, I would come back to you. There are three people who make Statements, so I just want to acknowledge them, then I would back to you.

I know your Constituency is full of—

Yes, Hon Member, let us hear you.

Mr Felix Akwetey Okle (NDC — Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro): Thank you, Mr Speaker. I would like to

associate myself with the Statement made on the International Day of Disability.

Mr Speaker, in my Constituency, Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro, we continue to engage with disability groups to understand their needs and support them in practical ways. But, Constituency-level interventions alone are not enough. We need a national approach that is inclusive, adequately funded and driven by the principles of fairness and equal opportunity.

Mr Speaker, let this year's International Day of Persons with Disability, remind us that inclusivity is not charity, it is justice. It is the foundation of a sustainable development and a measure of a truly democratic society.

I therefore call on this House to continue championing policies to empower persons with disabilities to live with independence, dignity and with respect.

Mr Speaker, I take the opportunity to salute the people of Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro.

Thank you, Mr Speaker. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Hon Mahama, would you also make a Statement? Anyway, I think he has checked out of the Chamber. So, let me go to go on to the Member of

Parliament for Akuapem North, then I would come to the Hon Minister.

Mr Samuel Awuku (NPP — Akuapem North): Mr Speaker, I believe, as we commemorate today, our friends and brothers who are persons with disability are not asking for pity or empathy from us. They are asking us to show them the same respect and support that we continue to show ourselves.

The Parliament of Ghana has played host to School for the Deaf from Mampong. Again, I am also happy to note that the Hon Minister for Education, just about three weeks ago, was also a special guest of honour for the School for the Blind in Akropong, both in my Constituency. There, the Hon Minister also did indicate that as part of the issues bedeviling this institution, Government is also going to make some allocation for them to employ many more hands to cater for these young people.

Mr Speaker, I have stated on this Floor on countless occasions that the issues of disability, the very act and our posture towards inclusion, respectfully as a nation, has not received the needed attention. Sometimes, when they are in trouble, they appear at police stations, and there is nobody to even interpret what they are saying. Sometimes they are accused wrongly in my Constituency, and they have no means of even extricating themselves from the very accusations levelled against them.

As we all seek to ask for support across the world, I believe that as a society, Parliament, and as a country, we

have to stand up for them as well. In my Constituency alone, I play host to three special needs schools: School for the Blind in Akropong, School for the Deaf in Mampong and School for the Deaf Technical School.

Today as we commemorate the World Disability Day, another interesting matter that I would like to also put before Government is that the School for the Deaf, thus the basic school and that of the technical school, are separated by a road.

Unfortunately, these are brothers have a shortcoming when it comes to their ability to hear. On numerous occasions, they are being knocked down by vehicles and we have complained time and over again. I believe that today, it should not just be another lip service as we commemorate the day, but concrete actions being taken by all of us to help show them that needed respect.

On this note, I stand shoulder to shoulder in support of the maker of the Statement as we commemorate the World Disability Day.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minister for Education?

Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu) (MP): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity to commend the maker of the Statement, Ms Ewurabena Aubynn, for celebrating persons with disability and reminding this House of our international

commitment to the observation of the International Day of Persons with Disability, which was declared by the United Nations (UN) far back 1981 through to 1992.

Mr Speaker, there was a meeting in Doha, the World Summit on Social Development, where these issues were further discussed.

Mr Speaker, what we need is a just, inclusive and equitable world. Even in Ghana, persons with disability still face significant challenges and obstacles. It is commendable that she has recognised what President John Dramani Mahama has done for persons with disability at least to have access to free tertiary education.

2:24 p.m.

I was in Akuapem three weeks ago where we visited the special needs school for visually impaired persons and I am happy to note that from 1st January, 2026, President Mahama will make a formal declaration of free education for all persons with special needs in Ghana and would want that to be an enduring legacy and to reach out to them as very marginalised and deprived people. Currently, those of them in the schools—We refer to them as integrated and special needs. There are about 39 of them spread across the country, particularly in Ashanti and Volta Regions and other parts of the country. They live on GH¢8.00 a day and Government is increasing that to GH¢15.00.

Mr Speaker, I am here with an amendment to the GETFund Act and part of the amendment is to declare special needs education free in Ghana. Every other year, the GETFund would be obliged through Parliament to make a minimum allocation of GH¢65 million to GH¢100 million dedicated to their feeding. What is significant will be assistive devices. Elsewhere in the world, for those who are unable to hear, there are devices that can aid hearing. We will also provide that for them.

I want to commend the maker of the Statement. I am also aware that the President has directed that the District Assemblies Common Fund allocation for persons with disability be increased from 3 per cent to 5 per cent and that this money must be spent at the local level. Also, accessibility to the Fund must be from the Federation of Disabled People as part of his determination to reach out to persons with disability.

Mr Speaker, we need to do more even as a Parliament. There are many institutions in Ghana which are still disability unfriendly. They have not been able to adjust their institutional infrastructure probably, including Parliament. How does a disabled person climb the stairs up here?

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

Second Deputy Minority Whip (Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib): Mr Speaker, thank you very much for this opportunity. I thought my Hon Friend from Bortianor-Ngleshie Amanfro had a

similar Statement and same has been admitted. So, are we going to take that?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Statements were three. We just gave the opportunity to one person and asked other two to comment. So, the Hon Member commented and before I called the other Member, he had stepped out from the Chamber.

Mr Shaib: Mr Speaker, thank you. I want to commend the makers of this Statement and to reiterate a few situations. International Day of Persons with Disabilities was established on 3rd December, 1992 and the purpose is to provide people with disabilities accessibility to help promote their activities and to let people understand that disability is not an inability. Today, we have this platform and in Ghana, we have about 2.1 million people who are persons living with various disabilities. In the world, we have about 2 billion people living with disabilities.

Mr Speaker, what are we doing as a Parliament to help resolve some of the problems these people are facing. If we look at the Persons with Disability Act 2006(Act 715), Mr Speaker, it remains largely unenforced. Why am I saying so? This is because even in our social provisions, we are not responsive to providing infrastructure for people with disabilities. We are not doing what is expected of us. Even in this Parliament, if we have friends with disabilities who want to visit us, apart from the lift, how are they going to reach out to us? When we go to a lot of toilet facilities in Ghana, they are only meant for people who do

not have any form of disability. Our parking spaces, public spaces, public infrastructure and most of these allocations or arrangements are not made for disabled people. So we only come and make all the noise and laws but we leave the vitals. We do not take care of these people.

Mr Speaker, as we celebrate their day, the clarion call is to make room and provisions for them in our infrastructure, education, homes, schools, businesses and even in sports. Whenever the Paralympics airs, we barely see people from Ghana participating. We see many swimmers who are persons living with disabilities and they do massively well than people who are abled men and women. This is the time for us to pay attention to them. They did not ask to be disabled, but unfortunately, this is a situation they have to deal with. What are we doing for them?

My respective Leaders who have also made Statements on this, this would be a clarion call on all of us to pay attention to persons living with disabilities so that we can say that we have done our part for them and for mother Ghana.

Mr Speaker, thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you. Majority Leadership, who is taking the opportunity to contribute to the Statement?

Yes, Hon Rita Naa Odoley Sowah, MP for Dadekotopon?

Deputy Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (Ms Rita Naa Odoley Sowah):

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement ably made by my Hon Colleague, Ewurabena Aubynn.

Mr Speaker, we celebrate with the persons with disability on this day, 3rd December, 2025 under the theme, “Fostering disability inclusive societies for advancing social progress”. Before I go on, I wish to commend His Excellency the President of Ghana, John Dramani Mahama for taking the initiative to increase their part of the District Assemblies Common Fund from 3 per cent to 5 per cent.

Mr Speaker, most of the time, some of the persons with disability have issues assessing this Fund and on this day that we celebrate persons with disability, I wish to encourage all of us as Members of Parliament to be concerned and participate in the distribution and allocation of their percentage to them. There are committees in the various assemblies that oversee the disbursement of these funds. How are they disbursing the funds? We should ensure that they disburse it well. There should not be discrimination where somebody would always have the opportunity and others would not. His Excellency the President has also made tertiary education free for persons with disability and we want to congratulate him on that.

Mr Speaker, we have different forms of persons with disability and per the Statement ably made by my Hon

Colleague, we have 2.1 million people who live with some form of disability. Mr Speaker, it will interest you to note that most people are not born with their disabilities. But as they grow, through accidents and various means, people become visually impaired and physically challenged among others. The rate of discrimination is too high in our nation. We need to come together and not look down on persons with disability because they are disabled through no fault of theirs.

2:34 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I would want to talk about accessibility. We go to most of our government institutions, and people with disability are not able to have access to where they really want to go. Sometimes, the leaders have to come down to meet them downstairs. There are some people here, such as Mr Gilbert Ayeibeng and his team, who are here today in Parliament. He is visually impaired, so how did he get into Parliament? These are issues that we have to look at and take a critical consideration of to ensure that they have access to wherever they want to go.

Mr Speaker, we give opportunities to persons with disability to work in our various assemblies, and sometimes they are transferred out of where they live, and that is another worry for them, in terms of having to look for accommodation, among others.

I also want to talk about the sign language interpreters. We do not have enough, and I pray that we will train more of them to ensure that we will be able to help our persons with disability.

Mr Speaker, I also want to take this opportunity to encourage parents who have children with disabilities to ensure that they educate them. People with disability have so much in them, but because of discrimination and stigmatisation, most parents hide their children. On this day, as we celebrate persons with disability, bring your children out so that we can work with them; we will educate them to ensure that they are part of our society and they are part of Ghana.

On this day, I wish all of them well wherever they are across the nation, in my Constituency, La Dade Kotopon, Mr Adaakwa, Mr Gilbert, and all of them. I wish you a happy celebration.

Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we bring the Statement to a close. We thank all the makers of the Statement and all of you who have contributed to the Statement. We will now begin with Public Business.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we can start with the item numbered 8(b). We can lay some outstanding Papers.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we do not have a problem with the application made by the Majority Chief Whip. However, I may suggest to him that he should give us an idea of what the plan is. I know he has a number of businesses, and this is one of the businesses he is seeking to prosecute this afternoon. So, maybe he should mention

all the items he wants to lay, and then we can all be carried along. Once we are done with the laying, then we can look at the Motions based on the availability of the Reports, but I agree with him that we start with the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Alhaji Ahmed is in the House, except that we have not been seeing him. He only comes and goes.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I agree with my counterpart. So, we will take the items numbered 8(b) - (m). We would lay them respectively.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, come with me to page 8, the item numbered 8(b), Presentation of Papers, by the Chairperson of the Local Government and Rural Development, Chieftaincy and Cultural Religious Affairs Committee.

PAPERS

By the Chairperson of the Committee

Report of the Joint Committee on Local Government & Rural Development, and Chieftaincy, Culture & Religious Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we turn to the item numbered 8(c), by the Chairperson of the Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions. Who is the Chairperson?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Chairperson has just stepped out, so may I seek your leave to do this on his behalf?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Minority Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Front bench can feel the cooperation from this Side of the House; we have no objection.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We can get the cooperation from the Leader himself, right? *[Laughter]*

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

- i. Report of the Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Labour, Jobs and Employment for the year ending 31st December, 2026.
- ii. Report of the Committee on Employment, Labour Relations and Pensions on the Annual Budget Estimates of the National Labour Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we move to the item numbered 8(d), by the Chairperson of the Committee on Youth and Sports.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we laid the Paper for the Committee on Youth and Sports yesterday, it was the Report that we could not take because the Minister indicated that he wanted to be here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Table, is that the case? While they are looking at it, let us move to the item numbered 8 (e) —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am guided. We can take the item numbered 8(d). The Chairperson was here a while ago.

Mr Speaker, let me seek your leave to do this on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Well noted.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Youth and Sports on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we move to the item numbered 8(e), the Chairperson of the Committee on Information and Communication.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I seek your leave to do this on his behalf?

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Information and Communications on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Right to

Information Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us move to the item numbered 8(f).

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Vice- Chairperson of the Committee is here, so he would lay the report on behalf of the Chairperson.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

The Vice-Chairperson of the Committee should learn how to bow well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I was trying to catch your attention. I was wondering whether it was because of the hat he was wearing or not; he must bow properly.

Mr Richard Acheampong: Mr Speaker, well noted.

By the Vice Chairperson on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

Report of the Finance Committee on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Finance for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we move to the item numbered 8(e).

2:44 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Chairperson is unavoidably absent, but

the Second Deputy Whip is a Member of the Committee, so I pray he does this on his behalf.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We want to be further magnanimous and to make the work easy, we are all seeking to help so we can navigate. The Majority Chief Whip should take responsibility. We know some of these Chairpersons and Ranking Members are engaged in one way or another. So, he should seek your leave and lay all the Reports from items numbered 8(f) to (m). He can take a single bow, and the Table Office can read the headings, so we move fast. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Do we have the Chairpersons of the Committees on Foreign Affairs, Trade, Industry and Tourism, Independent Constitutional Bodies, Lands and Natural Resources, and that of Economy?

All right. Hon Majority Chief Whip, you can do that.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I seek your leave to lay the Reports on behalf of the Committees featured in item numbered 8 (h) (i) (j) (k) (l) and (m).

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Trade, Industry and Tourism on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Trade, Agribusiness and Industry for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice (CHRAJ) for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Lands and Natural Resources on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Economy and Development on the Annual Budget Estimates of the National Development Planning Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson—

Report of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry

of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the Reports that have been read to us from the item numbered 8(g), (h), (i), (j), (k), (l) and (m) which have all been dully read to us be distributed to Hon Members.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we have just discovered that item numbered 8(e), the Annual Estimates of the Right to Information Commission, has been inadvertently placed under the Committee on Information and Communications. It should be Constitutional and Legal Affairs. This is a clerical error.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me invite the Chairperson to bow, then we take it afresh.

By the Chairperson of the Committee—

Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Right to Information Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray that we move to the Motion numbered 14. It is the Right to Information Commission Report.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we have no objection; however, even those of us in Leadership do not have copies of the Report. So, while we are preparing to take that, can the Table

Office make copies? It is on the console, yes, but we need a few hard copies.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, in fact, we brought a lot of hard copies, because even though we are going paperless, the facility of debating with paper in hand is always the best. So, we brought a lot of copies. I want to urge the National Service personnel to hurry up with their distribution.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, the Motion numbered 14, by the Minister of State in charge of Government Communications.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Right to Information Commission is under the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Did you say 14?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, the Motion numbered 14. It is the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs that considered it.

Mr Speaker, the Motion numbered 14 stands in the name of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, but inadvertently, it has been captured as standing in the name of the Minister of State in charge of Government Communication. So that error should be corrected.

We want to seek your leave to permit the Hon Minister for Transport to do so on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, also in the spirit of cooperation, we have no protest. However, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice has been absent for a long time. Even yesterday, he was supposed to be here to lay his Bill but he was nowhere to be found.

Mr Speaker, we will cooperate with them on all fronts, but for this particular one, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice must come. Does he want his budget to be approved or not? We have been cooperating with them. Committee Chairmen are not here, and we agreed that someone else would lay the Papers instead. But for this particular one, no, we would not agree.

The Majority Chief Whip should step outside and call the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, or the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice should come and do it. I have cooperated with them. So, I beg them. They should call him to come and do it. Does he want his budget to be approved? As for this, we are opposed. They should get him or his deputy here.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, indulge me. Let us go for a five-minute suspension.

2:54 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

2:56 p.m. — *Sitting resumed*

Mr Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, welcome back. Just to rehash my point, we will cooperate. In fact, we have been cooperating.

Mr Speaker, let me commend the Majority Chief Whip. Since yesterday, he has been awesome; working, going to the printing room and all that. The Majority has to commend him. He is the one holding the fort for them. I commend him highly, but for this particular Motion, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice must come.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We are holding on with it.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes. Mr Speaker, that is why you will live long.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, his prayer is noted. The Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is not within the jurisdiction. However, his Deputy is actually rushing to get here. We will stand this down so that we take the Motion numbered 22. *[Pause]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let us turn to page 13, item listed 22, Motion by the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, they can continue.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Majority Chief Whip, who is doing that on behalf of the Minister?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture is also outside of the jurisdiction. She sent a message last night. We want to pray you to permit the Minister for Transport, the Minister for Education or the Minister for Local Government,

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to do this. We have them in abundance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: The Hon Majority Chief Whip, you cannot say ‘or’—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minister for Transport will do this on behalf of the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: If it gets to a point where their Ministers are deserting them, as a Chief Whip, I can only sympathise with them. Mr Speaker, I will not object. I sympathise with him.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let the records reflect that my Ministers have not deserted me, nor abandon nor forsaken me. The Hon Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture does not have a Deputy, so that is the difficulty we have.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Mr Nikpe, may you do us the honours and take the Motion listed 22. I hope the Chairperson of the Committee is here.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

MINISTRY OF FISHERIES AND AQUACULTURE

Minister for Transport (Mr Joseph Nikpe Bukari) on behalf of Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢428,006,495.00 for the services of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Chairperson of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs (Dr Godfred Seidu Jasaw): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion, and in doing so, present the Committee's Report.

Mr Speaker, while seconding, allow me to correct a typographical error that is captured on the Motion. The figures we have quoted there is GH¢428,006,495.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is how it is supposed to be.

Dr Jasaw: No, Mr Speaker. The right figure is GH¢428,006,496.00. The figure 5 is supposed to be 6.

While at it, allow me to present your Committee's Report. We invited the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture to come and present the Estimates for the 2026 Budget. We had very productive deliberations and your Report is hereby submitted. May I invite *Hansard* to capture the content of this Report as if it was read in its entirety.

Introduction

The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 financial year was presented to Parliament on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana.

Pursuant to Orders 195(4) and 239 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the estimates which relate to the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture (MoFA) to the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs for consideration and report to the House.

Deliberations

The Committee met on Thursday, 27th November, 2025, and considered the 2026 Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture.

In attendance at the meeting were the Minister responsible for Fisheries and Aquaculture, Hon Emelia Arthur, and other officials of the Ministry, as well as the Ministry of Finance.

In furtherance of the principles of Open Parliament initiative, the Committee also extended invitation to some civil society organisations, including Ghana Fisheries Recovery Activity (GFRA), Hen Mpoano, and the Canoe and Fishing Gear Owners Association of Ghana (CaFGOAG).

The Committee extends its heartfelt gratitude to the Hon Minister, officials from the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture and its Agencies, and representatives from the Ministry of Finance for their thoughtful insights and expert clarifications.

The Committee is equally grateful to the invited CSOs for their constructive and meaningful contributions.

Reference Materials

The Committee referred to the following documents during the consideration of the Budget Estimates:

- i. The 1992 Constitution;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government for the 2026 Financial Year;
- iv. The Report of the Committee on Food, Agriculture and Cocoa Affairs for the 2025 Financial Year; and
- v. The Medium-Term Expenditure Framework of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for 2026-2029.

Policy Objectives

The policy objectives of the National Medium-Term Development Policy Framework (NMTDPF) relevant to the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture are to:

- i. Ensure sustainable development and management of aquaculture;
- ii. Ensure sustainable development and management of fisheries resources;
- iii. Ensure sustainable and resilient food production system;

- iv. Strengthen mainstreaming, coordination and implementation of gender-related interventions in all sectors;
- v. Enhance institutional capacity and coordination for effective climate action;
- vi. Reduce environmental pollution; and
- vii. Enhance climate change resilience.

Goal

The goal of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture is to “promote sustainable fishing and aquaculture practices and improve fisheries and aquaculture infrastructure to boost productivity, reduce post-harvest losses, and strengthen the value chain.

Core Functions

The Ministry carries out a range of essential functions aimed at promoting and regulating the fisheries and aquaculture sector. These core functions include:

- i. Develop policies, legislation, regulations, guidelines, procedures, standards and programmes on fisheries and aquaculture;
- ii. Coordinate plans, programmes and projects on fisheries and aquaculture at all levels of development;

- iii. Facilitate the modernisation and expansion of fisheries and aquaculture development into the National Policy Framework;
- iv. Design and deliver a monitoring and evaluation framework and guidelines for monitoring of policy/plan implementation;
- v. Monitor and evaluate policies, plans and programmes related to the operations of the sector;
- vi. Conduct research and impact surveys to support policy formulation and plan preparation;
- vii. Ensure an effective information management system on fisheries and aquaculture development;
- viii. Prepare and implement the Ministry's annual budget, programmes and projects;
- ix. Advise the Government on all fisheries and aquaculture-related policies;
- x. Coordinate the development and implementation of human resource management policies, systems and programmes consistent with the requirements of the sector to enhance service delivery; and
- xi. Ensure the availability of appropriate administrative and financial management systems and support services for the effective and efficient running of the sector for efficient service delivery.

2025 Performance Review Financial Performance

The total amount of GH¢81,377,679.39 was released for the implementation of the programmes and projects of the Ministry in the 2025 financial year, representing 30.8 per cent of the total approved budget of GH¢264,081,413.00.

Table 1 below provides the detailed performance of the budgetary allocations to the Ministry during the year under review:

Table 1: Summary of Expenditure by Economic Classification (2025)

2025 FINANCIAL PERFORMANCE						
	2025 Approved Budget	Releases	Actual Expenditure	Variance	% Rele ased	% Utili sed
Item	A	B	C	D	F=B /A*1 00	G=C /B*1 00
COMPEN SATION	34,955,747.00	26,509,834.00	26,509,834.07	8,445,912.93	75.8	100

GOODS AND SERVICES	66,068,864.00	47,826,355.82	41,655,947.15	18,242,508.18	72.8	87.1
GoG	5,003,714.00	2,489,552.00	1,957,744.00	2,514,162.00	49.7	78.6
IGF	61,065,150.00	45,336,803.82	39,698,203.15	15,728,346.18	74.2	87.6
CAPEX	163,056,802.00	7,041,489.50	7,041,489.50	156,015,312.50	4.3	100
GoG	100,000,000.00	-	-	100,000,000.00	-	-
IGF	63,056,802.00	7,041,489.50	7,041,489.50	56,015,312.50	11.1	100
TOTAL	264,081,413.00	81,377,679.39	75,207,270.72	182,703,733.61	30.8	92.4

Source: 2026 Programme-Based Budget Estimates of MoFA

Programme Performance for 2025

In 2025, the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture launched a series of initiatives and implemented a number of programmes and projects under five key Budget Programmes, all aimed at advancing the fisheries sector. The anticipated outcomes and achievements for each programme are outlined below.

Management and Administration

The Management and Administrative Programme provides the central support necessary for the Ministry to achieve its objectives, focusing on the efficient use of resources, policy coordination, and administrative services for all other programmes. In 2025, this programme was credited with several significant achievements, including the following:

- i. Attended 22 international conferences, meetings, and seminars in honour of Ministry's international obligations;
- ii. Enhanced staff capacity through targeted professional development, with 102 personnel undertaking training. This included 65 staff in local courses, 25 in in-service training, and 12 in foreign training programmes;

- iii. Prepared and submitted three (3) quarterly budget performance reports, three (3) quarterly progress reports, and three (3) quarterly and annual performance reports;
- iv. Prepared three (3) financial reports and four (4) internal audit reports; and
- v. Prepared and submitted two (2) quarterly reports and four (4) annual/mid-year reports.

Fisheries Resource Management

In the quest to regulate and manage the operations of marine and inland fisheries resources to reduce stock depletion in the marine sector and to eradicate Illegal, Unregulated and Unreported (IUU) fishing, the Ministry recorded the following achievements:

- i. Registered and licensed 76 industrial vessels;
- ii. Issued a total number of 5,742 canoes;
- iii. Observed 104 number of fishing holidays for canoes and two (2)

months of closed season for industrial trawlers;

- iv. Conducted one (1) canoe frame survey, and registered and embossed 75% of canoes in an effort to control fishing;
- v. Recorded 64,949.1 mt of fish production from inland capture; and
- vi. 442,360 mt of fish production for various marine fleet.

Aquaculture Development

The primary objectives of the Aquaculture Development programme are to enhance domestic fish production to reduce reliance on imported fish and fishery products, generate new employment opportunities for unemployed youth and women across the aquaculture value chain, improve national food and nutrition security, and foster the socio-economic advancement of the country.

The Ministry recorded significant progress towards achieving these objectives. Key accomplishments include the production of 173 million fingerlings from hatcheries and a total aquaculture fish output of 50,478.36 metric tons.

Fisheries Law Enforcement

The Ministry, in its efforts to protect and conserve Ghana's fisheries through strengthening enforcement of relevant laws and increasing stakeholder

education to improve voluntary compliance, recorded the following key milestones:

- i. The Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146) was passed to improve the management, regulation and sustainable development of the fisheries and aquaculture sector;
- ii. Ratified the WTO Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies and deposited the instrument of implementation at the WTO headquarters;
- iii. Drafted the National Blue Economy Strategy, Communication Strategy and Implementation Plan through inter-ministerial collaboration;
- iv. Successfully conducted two (2) sea-based monitoring and enforcement patrols lasting a total of 48 hours;
- v. 40 trawl vessels were successfully tracked by the Vessel Monitoring System (VMS);
- vi. 168 hours of trawl vessels were monitored per week;
- vii. Three (3) tuna vessels were equipped with video Express Mail Service (EMS);
- viii. Conducted 358 quayside inspections on industrial vessels;
- ix. Secured five (5) Fish Watch volunteers to improve compliance to fisheries laws and regulations;

- x. Trained forty (40) personnel of the Fisheries Enforcement Unit;
- xi. Trained and deployed 89 Fisheries Observers;
- xii. Had 244 number of Observers Missions; and
- xiii. Recorded a 100 per cent observer coverage for the missions.

Aquatic Animal Health and Post-Harvest Management

To promote the supply of safe and high-standard fish and fishery products for consumption at home and abroad, and to curtail post-harvest losses, the Ministry recorded the following achievements:

- i. Completed the construction of one (1) fully functional fish health lab in compliance with health and sanitary measures;
- ii. Trained 51 staff and industry personnel, and sensitised 336 aquaculture operators in biosecurity, sanitary and fish health issues;
- iii. Monitored 32 aquaculture establishments;
- iv. Trained 47 fisheries officers in post-harvest extension service delivery;

- v. Established two (2) model Training and Demonstration Centres;
- vi. Trained 47 fisheries officers in group dynamics and post-harvest practices;
- vii. Trained seven (7) fisheries groups in group dynamics and post-harvest practices;
- viii. Conducted one (1) cross-border monitoring exercise;
- ix. Certified 121 artisanal fish processing facilities (SFCLS); and
- x. Carried out four (4) port inspections and traceability inspections.

Outlook for 2026

Financial Requirement

The budgetary allocation for the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the year 2026 is the sum of GH¢428,006,496.00, made up of GH¢94,585,861.00 (22.1 per cent) as compensation of employees; GH¢50,103,714 (11.7 per cent) for Goods and Services; and GH¢244,400,000.00 (57.10 per cent) as Capital Expenditure. The detailed breakdown by economic classifications is shown in Table 2 below.

Table 2: 2026 Budget Allocation by Economic Classification

SOURCES OF FUNDING	ECONOMIC CLASSIFICATION				
Item	Compensation	Goods & Services	Capex	Total	% of Total Allocation
GoG	38,916,921	50,103,714	244,400,000	333,420,635	77.9
IGF	-	51,084,229	43,501,632	94,585,861	22.1
Donor	-	-	-	-	
Grand Total	38,916,921	101,187,943	287,901,632	428,006,496	100
%	9.1	23.6	67.3	100	

Source: 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government

Table 3: 2026 Budgetary Allocation by Programme

Programmes	Sources of Funding				
	GOG(GHC)	IGF(GHC)	Donors (GHC)	Total (GHC)	Percent Allocation (%)
Management and Administration	174,683,521	59,376,931	-	234,060,452	54.69
Fisheries Resource Management	118,316,834	8,482,919	-	126,799,753	29.63
Aquaculture Development	37,470,068	18,747,791	-	56,217,859	13.13
Fisheries Law Enforcement	2,080,006	5,988,220	-	8,068,226	1.89
Aquatic Animal and Post-Harvest Management	870,206	1,990,000	-	2,860,206	0.66

Source: Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture Development

Programme Outlook for 2026

The Ministry's 2026 agenda is planned to be implemented under five sub-programmes, designed to guide policy formulation, build capacity and provide support services that enable optimal sector performance.

Management and Administration

Under the Management and Administration programme, the Ministry plans to implement five sub-programmes designed to provide administrative support to enable the sector achieve its medium to long-term goals and objectives.

Finance and Administration

This sub-programme focuses on delivering timely logistical support to operational units to improve service delivery and ensure compliance with the Public Financial Management Act, 2016 (Act 921) and Regulations, 2019 (L.I 2378). For 2026, the Ministry plans to implement the following:

- i. Participate in regional and international fisheries meetings, seminars and conferences;
- ii. Facilitate the organisation of the fisheries component of the National Farmers' Day Celebration;
- iii. Strengthen the monitoring mechanism for premix fuel distribution;

- iv. Procure office vehicles and motorbikes;
- v. Facilitate the payment of subscriptions;
- vi. Develop and validate a Sector Procurement Plan; and
- vii. Facilitate general operations of the Ministry.

Human Resource Management

The Human Resource Management Sub-programme aims to develop staff capabilities for efficient service delivery and improve overall staff welfare. To achieve this, the Ministry will implement the following activities in the 2026 financial year:

- i. Implement the 2026 Training Plan;
- ii. Facilitate foreign training programmes;
- iii. Develop a Human Resource (HR) Operational Manual;
- iv. Undertake exchange programmes and study tours; and
- v. Institute reward scheme for performing officers.

Policy, Planning, Budgeting, Monitoring and Evaluation

Focused on optimising outcomes, this sub-programme is dedicated to strengthening policy planning, formulation, implementation, monitoring, and

evaluation. To achieve this, the Ministry will undertake the following key operations during the 2026 financial year:

- i. Develop the 2027–2030 Sector Budget;
- ii. Monitor and evaluate fisheries sector programmes and projects;
- iii. Develop Regulations for the implementation of Act 1146;
- iv. Develop proposals to source for funding to undertake prioritised programmes and activities;
- v. Develop a communication strategy;
- vi. Undertake feasibility study of Fishing Village Infrastructure Project;
- vii. Construct a fish market at Dambai;
- viii. Complete and operationalise the Anomabo Fisheries College; and
- ix. Facilitate the implementation of Public Private Partnership (PPP) projects in aquaculture and related areas.

Research, Statistics and Information Management

The objective of this sub-programme is to improve the timely production and use of fisheries and aquaculture data for decision-making and policy formulation. In 2026, the Ministry aims to achieve the following:

- i. Improve ICT infrastructure for fisheries management;
- ii. Develop and implement a fisheries information management system;
- iii. Conduct research on topical issues in the fisheries sector to inform decision-making;
- iv. Undertake stakeholder engagements;
- v. Finalise and implement MoFA ICT Policy;
- vi. Provide public relations and media coverage services in the implementation of annual Closed Seasons;
- vii. Plan and organise quarterly fisheries media outreach and sensitisation programme;
- viii. Support implementation of ICT Policy and institutional guidelines;
- ix. Establish Fisheries Communication and Knowledge Hub;
- x. Establish Fisheries and Aquaculture Research Database;
- xi. Develop and maintain an interactive Fisheries Information Portal;
- xii. Develop a Stakeholder Collaboration and Information Sharing Platform;
- xiii. Procure computers and Accessories; and
- xiv. Establish a Data Centre.

Fisheries Sector Coordination

This sub-programme seeks to regulate and manage the utilisation of the fisheries and aquaculture resources of Ghana by implementing the following operations:

- i. Honour fisheries-related international obligations;
- ii. Provide administrative support for fisheries operations (payment of utilities, transport management, general maintenance, staff capacity enhancement and welfare);
- iii. Conduct general operations in audit, finance, and human resource;
- iv. Hold service statutory meetings;
- v. Procure 12 pick-ups and 10 motorbikes for the operations of the Fisheries Commission;
- vi. Construct Fisheries Commission Office at Asuogyaman Zone (Akosombo);
- vii. Renovate the Monitoring, Control and Surveillance Department (MCSD) Office at the Fishing Harbour;
- viii. Procure computers and accessories for Regional and Zonal Offices; and
- ix. Service Collecte Localisation Satellites (CLS) Obligations;

Fisheries Resource Management

The Ministry intends to implement activities across three sub-programmes aimed at protecting, conserving, and sustainably managing fisheries resources for current and future generations.

Marine Fisheries Resource Management

This sub-programme aims to enhance sustainable management and conservation of marine resources for national development by undertaking the following initiatives:

- i. Conduct stock and environmental assessment as science evidence based for stock recovery;
- ii. Pilot one Mariculture to boost natural stocks biomass;
- iii. Complete the construction of an office at Winneba;
- iv. Complete the construction of Staff Quarters at Elmina; and
- v. Establish Marine Protected Areas.

Inland Fisheries Resource Management

The objective of the inland fisheries resource management sub-programme is to promote sustainable inland fisheries resource exploitation for national development. The Ministry aims at achieving this objective by undertaking the following operations in the 2026 financial year:

- i. Develop an Inland Management Plan;
- ii. Emboss inland canoe registration numbers;
- iii. Carry out a frame survey on the Bui Dam;
- iv. Train at least 20 fishers in two (2) fishing communities per region on approved fishing gears and techniques and proper fishing methods;
- v. Conduct one stock assessment in small water bodies in four (4) regions;
- vi. Enhance the capacity of 48 (3 per region) Fisher Associations in the management of inland fisheries resource;
- vii. Procure an equipment for canoe registration; and
- viii. Procure a stock assessment equipment.

Fisheries and Aquaculture Research & Development

Under this sub-programme, the Ministry plans to conduct scientific research for the sustainable management of the fisheries and aquaculture resources through the following operations:

- i. Conduct ecosystem survey (Stock and environmental assessment);

- ii. Conduct studies into the extension of the Inshore Exclusive Zone (IEZ) and its implications;
- iii. Procure a Research Vessel;
- iv. Train 50 staff (200 annually) in Routije Research Methods and Data Management;
- v. Procure computer & accessories for data centre;
- vi. Establish one centralised digital data system for inland fisheries sectors;
- vii. Establish Fisheries Data Centre;
- viii. Develop and implement fisheries information management system; and
- ix. Improve ICT infrastructure for fisheries management.

Aquaculture Development

The primary goal of the aquaculture development programme is to promote domestic fish production, expand employment opportunities in the aquaculture sector, improve national food and nutrition security, and advance Ghana's socio-economic growth. These objectives will be pursued through the execution of the two (2) sub-programmes detailed below.

Fisheries Hatchery Operations

In the 2026 operational year, the Ministry, through this sub-programme,

will implement targeted interventions to increase the availability and quality of fingerlings that are genetically improved for growth performance, disease resistance, and biosecurity. A central component of these activities will involve training 100 hatchery operators in advanced broodstock management practices and scientifically-informed fingerling production techniques.

Aquaculture Training and Extension

Under the aquaculture training and extension sub-programme, the Ministry aims to equip existing and prospective fish farmers with the relevant husbandry management tools and practices to enable them to run aquaculture enterprises as viable businesses.

To achieve this, the Ministry plans to undertake the following specific interventions in the 2026 financial year:

- i. Provide logistics for aquaculture extension service delivery;
- ii. Train 300 fish farmers on feed formulation using local ingredients;
- iii. Engage the Ministry of Finance and relevant stakeholders on aquaculture inputs subsidies and tax waivers;
- iv. Train 200 Extension Officers in aquaculture extension service delivery; and
- v. Procure vehicles for aquaculture extension service delivery.

Fisheries Law Enforcement

The overarching aim of this programme is to protect and conserve the fisheries resources of Ghana as well as improve voluntary compliance by fishers through the enforcement of fisheries laws and regulations, sensitisation and education of all stakeholders.

In the 2026 fiscal year, the Ministry intends to allocate a portion of its budget to support the implementation of the following projects under the Fisheries Law Enforcement Programme.

- i. Embark on at least four (4) sea patrols;
- ii. Undertake ten (10) community sensitisation exercise to enforce compliance on fisheries laws and regulations;
- iii. Facilitate installation of EMS on 20 Ghanaian flag tuna vessels;
- iv. Conduct 500 routine daily quayside inspections on industrial vessels (trawlers = 45, tuna = 30, tuna carrier = 1) at the Tema and Takoradi ports;
- v. Undertake 12 Volta Lake patrols to combat Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) fishing and also for the maintenance of patrol boats;
- vi. Conduct 24/7 electronic monitoring of all industrial fishing vessels; and
- vii. Establish Monitoring, Control and Surveillance (MCS) offices in strategic inland communities.

Aquatic Animal and Post-Harvest Management

The objective of the Ministry under this programme is to reduce fish health risks through effective detection, prevention, and control measures while promoting the production of safe and high-quality fish along the value chain for both domestic consumption and export. The Ministry plans to pursue these objectives through the implementation of the Fish Health and Sanitation Sub-programme and the Post-Harvest Sub-programme.

Fish Health and Sanitation

The objective of this sub-programme is to provide specialised aquatic husbandry and laboratory services to operators in the capture and culture of fisheries, control the movement of fish and fishery products across various boundaries, and safeguard the introduction of foreign fish species into the country's inland water bodies, including culture establishments. Target programmes of the Ministry to achieve the above objectives include the following:

- i. Develop an Aquatic Animal Health Strategy and Implementation Plan of AAHP;
- ii. Organise two (2) sensitisation workshop for 100 fish farmers on bio-security at the farm level;
- iii. Train 50 Fisheries Officers and Veterinarians on Aquatic Animal Health;

- iv. Conduct routine biosecurity monitoring and surveillance on farms and landing beaches; and
- v. Upgrade and operationalise laboratories conducting routine diagnostics.

Post-Harvest Management

The Post-Harvest Management Sub-programme is designed to deliver improvements across the fish supply chain, specifically in handling, processing, storage and distribution, resulting in enhanced quality, safety, and shelf life. Accordingly, the Ministry has outlined these priority initiatives for 2026:

- i. Train officers and stakeholders on best practices in post-harvest management and trade;
- ii. Establish and maintain a national post-harvest database;
- iii. Strengthen extension delivery system for the post-harvest sector;
- iv. Facilitate the formation of functional fisher associations within the post-harvest value chain;
- v. Facilitate trade in fish and fishery products (domestic and international); and
- vi. Establish demonstration centres to serve as technology hubs and provide hands-on training.

Observations

The Committee made the following observations at the meeting:

Progress on Lifting the “Yellow Card” issued on Export of Fish from Ghana to European Union Market

The House may recall that as part of efforts to address the persistent threats by the European Union (EU) of a potential ban on Ghana’s fish exports to the European market, and to enhance the overall management of the nation’s fisheries resources, Parliament enacted the Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146) in June 2025. The Act, which has been widely acknowledged as a comprehensive legal framework, among other provisions, strengthens regulatory oversight, mandates enhanced surveillance and monitoring, and seeks to address the deficiencies previously identified by the EU.

The Committee, however, expressed concern regarding Ghana’s continued placement under the EU “Yellow Card” status, which poses the risk of escalation to a “Red Card”, a designation that would result in a complete ban on fish exports to the EU. The concerns by the Committee were further reinforced by the recent inspection visits by the EU Mission to fishing communities, which revealed widespread infractions among industrial fishing vessels. The findings by the EU Mission underscore critical weaknesses in monitoring, control, and surveillance, arising from inadequate enforcement of fisheries regulations and limited logistical capacity.

The Committee notes that a complete ban on the export of fish to the EU market would have grave consequences for the fisheries sub-sector and the national economy at large. Accordingly, the Committee urges the Ministry to expedite the development and enactment of the Regulations required to give full effect to the implementation of the Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146), in order to facilitate the lifting of the EU “Yellow Card” and safeguard Ghana’s continued access to the European market.

Delay in Release of the Approved Budgets

The Committee commended the Government for the sustained commitment to increasing budgetary allocation to the Ministry over the years. For instance, the Committee observed that a total amount of GH¢150,103,033, GH¢264,081,413 and GH¢428,006,496 were allocated to the Ministry in 2024, 2025 and 2026 respectively. These allocations represent an increase of 57 per cent and 62 per cent over the 2025 and 2026 fiscal years, respectively.

The Committee, however, expressed concern that despite an appreciable increase in the Ministry’s budgetary allocation over the years, actual releases remained significantly below required levels necessary to effectively implement planned programmes. For instance, it was noted that as at 30th September, 2025, a total amount of GH¢81,377,679.39, representing 30.8 per cent of the approved budget of GH¢264,081,413 for the 2025 fiscal

year, had been released, imposing substantial constraints on the operational activities of the Ministry. Although current update indicated an improvement in releases to 50.7 per cent as at 27th November, 2025, it is still considerably low to achieve the Ministry's targets for the fiscal year under review.

The Committee is of the view that delay in releases hinders the effective and efficient implementation of the Ministry's programmes and activities, and accordingly urges the Ministry of Finance to ensure the timely and full release of approved budgetary allocations.

Pollution of Water Bodies and Safety of Fishes

The Committee sought clarification regarding the safety of fish consumed in Ghana, given the increasing rate of pollution of the nation's water bodies resulting from illegal mining activities, as well as the erosion and discharge of industrial and plastic wastes.

In response, the technical officers assured the Committee and the general public that notwithstanding certain research findings and allegations of contamination, fish from Ghana's water bodies remain generally safe for consumption. They explained that when toxicity and turbidity levels exceed specific thresholds that may render fish from a given water body unsafe for human consumption, the fish naturally perish as a result of gill damage and impaired respiration caused by the suspended particles and the pollutants.

With respect to marine fish, the officers further clarified that although inland rivers discharge polluted waters into the sea, the vast dilution capacity of marine ecosystems significantly reduces the concentration of contaminants, such as mercury, cyanide, and other toxins, by the time they reach marine fisheries zones.

Despite the assurance by the Ministry, pollution of water resources poses significant threat to the sustainability of fisheries resources, especially inland fishing. The Committee, accordingly, urges all stakeholders to intensify efforts to combat illegal mining and curb pollution of the nation's water bodies, in order to safeguard aquatic life and enable Ghana to fully realise the potential of its fisheries resources.

Weak fisheries extension services

The Committee noted with concern the inadequate staffing within the Fisheries Extension Services of the Ministry. This deficiency has significantly undermined the capacity of Extension Officers to conduct effective field visits to aquaculture farms and fishing communities, resulting in reduced monitoring, weakened technical support for fish farmers, and an inability to address ageing hatchery stock or implement key programmes, including fish health surveillance.

The Committee is of the view that sustained and increasing investment in aquaculture development could be severely constrained if fish farmers do

not receive timely and adequate technical support services. Accordingly, the Committee recommends, as a matter of priority and urgency, the recruitment of additional Extension Personnel and the provision of enhanced logistical resources to revitalise the Fisheries Extension Unit, in order to safeguard Ghana's aquaculture development and fisheries sustainability objectives.

Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated (IUU) Fishing, Enforcement Gaps and Piracy Threats

The Committee also observed that the Ministry intends to strengthen the capacity of the Fisheries Enforcement Unit (FEU) by procuring essential logistics to facilitate regular monitoring, control and surveillance activities across the marine and inland fisheries sub-sectors. The Ministry indicated that improved assets, such as patrol vessels, vehicles and surveillance equipment, are critical to enabling officers to undertake routine checks aimed at curbing illegal, unreported and unregulated (IUU) fishing, as well as addressing emerging security threats, including piracy. The Committee welcomed this intervention, noting that enhanced enforcement of fishing laws and improvement in logistics will significantly improve compliance, deter illegal practices, and promote sustainable management of the nation's fisheries resources.

Boosting Aquaculture in Partnership with the Private Sector

The Committee noted with satisfaction the growing interest of the

private sector in partnering with the Government to promote aquaculture. Of particular significance is the increasing investment by the private sector in hatcheries, which presents a vital opportunity to decentralise fingerling production, thereby reducing the logistical burden on the Fisheries Commission in transporting fingerlings from centralised government facilities to distant locations.

The Committee commends these initiatives by the private sector, and urges the Ministry to provide appropriate incentives, including the scaling up of technical training at the district level and the establishment of resilient community-based supply chains and market systems to sustain private sector interest and continued investment.

The Committee further recommends the implementation of targeted programmes for women and youth to reduce poverty, address income disparities, and create employment opportunities.

Civil Society Organisations (CSOs) Perspectives

As part of its commitment to the Open Parliament Initiative, aimed at promoting co-creation, inclusivity, and joint ownership in the implementation of development priorities, the Committee, for the first time, invited relevant civil society organisations (CSOs) to participate in its deliberations and share their perspectives.

The CSOs in attendance commended Parliament for this initiative, describing it as a “historic and powerful demonstration of transparency and accountability in line with Ghana’s Open Governance principles.” They expressed satisfaction with the Committee’s and the Ministry’s deep knowledge of the sector, noting that “the posturing of Members of the Committee and their contributions demonstrated a genuine interest in supporting the Ministry to achieve success.”

The CSOs welcomed certain initiatives of the Ministry, including plans to:

- a. Enhance fisheries enforcement and monitoring to improve safety and combat illegal fishing;
- b. Construct fish markets to address post-harvest challenges;
- c. Complete the Anomabo Fisheries College;
- d. Automate the premix fuel system; and
- e. Provide fishing inputs, including outboard motors and nets.

In their view, these interventions are critical for safeguarding livelihoods, improving accountability, and building a resilient small-scale fisheries sector that continues to feed millions of Ghanaians.

The CSOs, however, expressed concern over the lack of clear budgetary allocations to fund the operations of

critical multi-stakeholder structures established to manage marine fishery resources, such as the Science and Technical Committee (STC), Fisheries Operational Management Committee (FOMC), National Small Pelagic Management Committee (NSPMC), Regional Small Pelagic Committees (RSPC), and Landing Beach Enforcement Committees (LBEC).

They suggested a review of L. I. 2233 (the Premix Fuel Committee Regulation) to allocate a portion of the margins from premix fuel to sustain the operations of these structures.

The CSOs also recommended that sufficient time be provided to interrogate the Ministry’s policies and financial data, and added that in subsequent hearings, invitations be extended to cover CSOs in all the three sub-sectors of the fisheries industry.

In summary, they were of the view that the Ministry’s budget reflects the needs of the sector. The hearing process was also inclusive, transparent, and participatory, signalling a bold shift toward inclusive and participatory fisheries governance, reflecting the spirit and intent of the Fisheries Co-Management Policy, which recognises fishers as essential partners in sustainable fisheries resource management.

Conclusion and Recommendations

The Committee, in collaboration with the civil society organisations, have carefully examined the budget estimates of the Ministry of Fisheries and

Aquaculture for the 2026 financial year and is satisfied that the policies and programmes outlined for the year will go a long way to sustain the transformation of the sector as a viable economic segment to national development.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its Report and approve the total sum of Four Hundred and Twenty-Eight Million, Six Thousand, Four Hundred and Ninety-Six Ghana Cedis (GH¢428,006,496.00) to implement the planned programmes and activities of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the 2026 financial year.

Respectfully submitted.

May I just highlight a few for your records? I take us to paragraph 7 where the budget performance for the 2025 financial year has been captured. They had a total allocation of a little over GH¢200 million, and they showed the programmes for which they expended these finances in executing. We were satisfied with the answers that they provided and we considered the outlook for 2026.

3:04 p.m.

This year, the significant bit of their budget is that it has been increased by over 100 per cent and that the CAPEX bit of it, which hitherto was very low, has now appreciated to about 67 per cent of the budget. Mr Speaker, that is commendable and that will allow them to be able to implement some of the planned projects that are captured broadly under management and

administration, fisheries resource management, aquaculture development, fisheries law enforcement, which we passed in this House, aquaculture and animal post-harvest management. Mr Speaker, these are the broad programmes that they intend to implement, but to emphasise that they will be very loud on aquaculture.

Mr Speaker, the Committee made certain observations. Key amongst them is that we also had, in line with Parliament's open governance policy, invited Civil Society Organisations to represent the fisheries sector and they participated fully in our deliberations. They opened up and brought dimensions that we otherwise, normally, did not consider and so I commend the policy on open governance for Parliament because we are bringing governance too closer to the people.

Mr Speaker, allow me to go to the conclusion and indicate that the Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt its report and approve the total sum of GH¢428,006,496 to implement the planned programmes and activities of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture.

Question proposed.

Dr Isaac Yaw Opoku (NPP — Offinso South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise in support of the Motion on the Floor which is urging the honourable House to approve the sum of GH¢428,006,496 for the services of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Speaker, I must say that when your Committee met with the Ministry and the various agencies, we were satisfied with the performance of the Ministry as far as the 2025 activities were concerned. Because of time constraint, I will mention a few of them.

The first one was the Anomabo Fisheries College. This College was started in 2013 and for more than a decade now, the project has not been completed. The Committee was happy to note that it is nearing its completion and that very soon, the project will be launched. When this project is completed, it is going to serve as a facility for education for the fisher folks. Currently, the extension delivery is very poor, so it will give the Ministry the opportunity to train their staff in the fishery and aquaculture sector.

Mr Speaker, we were also glad to learn that 22 automated premix fuel outlets, started by the previous regime, have also been completed. This is also going to aid the premix secretariat in addressing some of the challenges they encounter.

Another area which the Committee was also happy about was the fish health sector. One fish health laboratory has been completed, and it is important because we have to ensure that the fish we consume is wholesome for Ghanaians. This is where they will be taking samples for analysis to ensure that the fish we consume is safe.

Mr Speaker, we were also glad to learn that the Ministry is not only

concentrating on marine fisheries, they are also looking at aquaculture. Those of us who are not along the coast are always happy to learn that aquaculture has not been left out by the Ministry.

In spite of these, we realised that the Ministry is constrained when it comes to the release of funds. Mr Speaker, we were sad to learn that as at the end of the third quarter, at the end of September, only 30 per cent of the budgetary allocation had been released. If the House can remember, the 2025 allocation was GHC264 million, but at the end of September, which is the third quarter, only GHC81 million had been released. This is unacceptable, and we urge the Minister for Finance to ensure that more funds are released to the Ministry. But, Mr Speaker, I must also indicate that at the time of our interaction with the Ministry, we were told that releases have gone up from 30 per cent to 50.7 per cent.

Whilst commending the Ministry about some achievements, the Committee was also not happy about the performance when it comes to Internally Generated Fund (IGF). Looking at their projections, it was relatively poor. For the main Ministry projection, they were only able to meet 45.68 per cent of the IGF collections. Fisheries Commission achieved only 51 per cent, and the Premix Secretariat, only 29 per cent.

Mr Speaker, whilst concluding on my comments, let me mention one serious concern raised by the Committee. This is in relation to the safety of fish we consume in this country, especially the

locally produced ones. If we look at the level of contamination from our river bodies following *galamsey* activities, the Committee was worried whether the fish we consume is wholesome. Our fears were allayed by the technical officers of the Ministry.

They assured us that when it comes to fish in the river bodies, once the level of contamination is so high, the fish cannot survive. So, virtually, there is no fish living in those rivers anymore. But when it comes to the marine, because of the volume of the marine water, the contamination will be so low that we do not have to entertain any fear. That notwithstanding, we still urge the Ministry to do further assessments, to give us empirical data to allay the fears of Ghanaians, that indeed the fish we consume in this country is safe.

Mr Speaker, with these few comments, I urge the honourable House to adopt the Committee's Report and approve the recommendation of the Committee that the Ministry should be allocated the sum of GH¢428,006,496.

I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members—

Yes, are you a Member of the Committee? Let me hear you.

3:14 p.m.

Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten (NDC — Tema East): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to support the call for

this House to approve the stated sum for the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture to undertake their operations for the 2026 fiscal year.

Mr Speaker, having listened to the Minister and the officials, your Committee was very certain that once this House approves the requested amount, efforts made by the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture would contribute to the needed change that we want in this country, especially in the fisheries sector. I took notice of the programmes the Ministry has lined up to improve stock levels of our fisheries, especially the Fisheries Resource Management, which is key in increasing local production, not only from the marine side, but also inland and aquaculture programmes that the Ministry has lined up.

Inland Fisheries Resource Management is one key intervention that would help our people to develop an inland management plan, a plan that would call for action and improve our fish resources. Again, Mr Speaker, if we look at plans of the Ministry to improve fisheries and aquaculture research development, this is one plan that would aid the sustainability of fish resources in this country, especially when we look at targeted activities such as establishing one centralised digital data system for the inland fisheries sector, and the establishment of a fisheries data centre. These are the activities that would help us incorporate technology and modern ways of fishing, which are data-based for informed decisions and aqua resource management.

Mr Speaker, I note a few concerns as to releases that the Ministry has to complain about, but we are sure that your Committee would also liaise with the Ministry to ensure that releases are done not only timeously, but in the quantum that they would require to execute these important activities of the Ministry.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to support the call for this House to approve the budget sum of GH¢428,006,496.00 for the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I am not cutting anybody short, but I want to plead with you. We have a number of Reports to take, so let us try to make our comments a bit snappy so that we can take more of the Reports.

Yes, Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi?

Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah (NPP — Ofoase Ayirebi): Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the submissions on this Report. I support that this House would approve this Report. I have two quick comments.

The first is that, in all honesty, it does not matter the breadth of brilliant ideas that are put on the table by the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture or contributors, if the budgetary allocations would not be released. Page 22 of the Report, under the signature of the Chairperson of the Committee, says, “Mr Speaker, for instance, it was noted that as of 30th September, 2025, a total amount

of GH¢81 million, representing 30.8 per cent of the approved budget for the fiscal year, has been released.”

Mr Speaker, what can they do with 30 per cent of their budget? They can wax lyrical about very brilliant ideas, yellow card, green card, this, and that, but if only 30 per cent of the budgetary allocation is being made available, then they might as well close down their Ministry, because they would not be able to achieve their objectives.

Mr Speaker, it goes back to the earlier points we have been making about the fact that the Government needs to pay attention to revenue, else this is what would happen. You would have ministers, they would announce programmes, but there is no money to fund it.

Mr Speaker, my second point, and then I would take my seat, has to do with an item on page 23, paragraph 9.4, where it says that fisheries extension services are weak. It is important for a lot of attention be paid to fisheries extension services. Here is why. They are the services that ensure that those in the aquaculture industry would get the kind of support, knowledge, and facilitation, so that they can do their business at a cost-effective level and in a way that promotes the industry.

Mr Speaker, we are not paying enough attention to the private sector and how to support the private sector. In fact, just yesterday, the Public Utility Regulatory Commission (PURC) announced that from 1st January, there is

going to be an increase in utility tariffs, about 9.8 per cent in electricity tariffs, and 15.9 per cent in water. If we add it to the already existing about 18 per cent in electricity, it means that by January next year, the cost of production for manufacturers, private sector, those who are producing here in Ghana, from electricity, is going to go up by about 30 per cent. If we are competing with somebody from the Ivory Coast or from some other jurisdiction who does not have these increases in utility prices, how competitive would we be?

So, it is important that the Government pays attention to the underlying issues, whether it is about Fisheries Extension Services aimed at assisting those in the fisheries industries or the cost of production, like utility, electricity, *et cetera*. If they do not, we would be putting our private sector at a disadvantage. We can do all of these approvals, but if they do not get those things done, the private sector would continue to be at a disadvantage.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Chairperson, I think you made some corrections earlier on the figure. You said it is supposed to be GH¢428,006,496.00 instead of GH¢428,006,495.00. But the actual budget presentation captures GH¢428,006,495.00. In order not to appear controversial, let us restrict ourselves to what the budget figures have given us. When you go to page 181, the item numbered 14, Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture, the figure is GH¢428,006,495.00. But you are saying you should make it GH¢428,006,496.00.

I want us to restrict ourselves to what the figures we have in the Budget, which is the official Report. I do not know where you got your correction from, but I want us to restrict ourselves to what the budget figures are actually presenting to us. I hope I have made myself clear.

Dr Jasaw: Yes, Mr Speaker, I agree with you perfectly. Except that that figure also came from the estimates that were submitted by the Ministry of Finance. But it is just a decimal point, so we can go with what your ruling is.

Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Leadership, I am going to restrict the numbers going forward. Please, bear with me.

Yes, Alhaji Habib Iddrisu?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu (NPP — Tolon): Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to speak in support of the approval of the Motion for the estimates of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture. Mr Speaker, looking at the observation, it is sad to an extent that the Minister for Fisheries and Aquaculture rushed to Parliament in June, pleading under the certificate of urgency, that the Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146), be passed.

3:24 p.m.

The Chairperson and the Minister were of the view that if this is passed, it will help us to reverse our status on the Illegal, Unreported and Unregulated

(IUU) Fishing “yellow card” from the European Union. But Mr Speaker, looking at the Report, Ghana is still on the “yellow card”; it has not been lifted yet, even though we passed the Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146).

Mr Speaker, if you look at page 5 of the Report of the Committee, and I quote:

“That a total amount of GH¢81,377,679.39 was released for the implementation of the programme and project of the Ministry for the 2025 fiscal year, representing 30.8 per cent.”

I do not know what is wrong with this Government with half releases; releases that are not even up to 50 per cent. What do you expect the Ministers to do? As it was indicated to the Chairperson, now they have allocated GH¢428,006,495. Mr Speaker, if you calculate another 30 per cent, because looking at the projection that the Minister has presented in the Budget, it means that things are going to get worse. Nothing is going to get better based on the projection. For the 2025 projection, as of September, only 30 per cent of the allocation to the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture was released.

Mr Speaker, at the moment, even though the Committee asked the necessary questions, we are still not safe. The fish we eat in Ghana is no longer safe. The Committee, based on their observation, asked those critical questions, whether it is still safe to eat fish in Ghana. I am very much afraid,

when you want to buy fish from the market, you ask yourself—because the Committee said that:

“The Committee sought clarification regarding the safety of fish consumed in Ghana given the increasing rate of pollution of the nation’s water bodies, resulting from illegal mining activities, as well as erosion and discharge of industrial...”

Mr Speaker, illegal mining has made our water bodies very unsafe. This Government campaigned seriously in the coastal areas and won majority of the seats there. Yet, they released only 30 per cent of the budgetary allocation to the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the Ministry’s operations. It is very worrying. I think that with this trend, like my Brother, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah said, if they cannot run the Ministry, they should just close it down, or annex it to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture. Because they cannot run a Ministry with only 30 per cent release of allocation. They should add it to the Ministry of Food and Agriculture, so it could be the Ministry of Agriculture, Fisheries and Aquaculture. It will help rather than giving them small allocations and releases.

Mr Speaker, we will approve it for them, but we are very mindful that less than 30 per cent of the allocation will be released.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Leadership are supposed to conclude.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It does not matter. I can sacrifice you. Allow me to sacrifice you. [*Uproar*]

Mr Dafeamekpor: No, Mr Speaker, do not sacrifice me this way. Mr Speaker, let me set the records straight. Let me refer you page 22 of the Report. Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, the Hon Member for Ofoase Ayirebi, and the First Deputy Minority Whip, conveniently refused to read the entirety of that paragraph for mischievous reasons, for ulterior motives.

Mr Speaker, the Report says “although the current update indicated an improvement in releases to 50.7 per cent...”. A year ago, Mr Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, as a Minister of State, was lamenting about 30 per cent. So, it cannot be accurate that the releases were 30 per cent, because you take the average, and we are saying that as we are on our feet; it is more than 50 per cent.

So, Mr Speaker, let us adopt this Report and make progress.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you, Hon Members.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.
Resolved:*

That this honourable House approved the sum of GH¢428,006,495.00 for the services of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Leadership, if I tend to sacrifice you, you should appreciate where I am coming from. I want us to at least move a bit faster.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, again in the spirit of cooperation with my Colleague, we want to help him, but he should look at his back and look at this Side. He should not be unnecessarily litigant. If he wants to antagonise us, we will call for quorum. But because of my Hon Majority Leader, I will not call for quorum—[*Laughter*—]but the Hon Majority Chief Whip should behave properly. If he starts punching my Members—Quorum is determined by the mood of this House.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. I hope we do not get there.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, may I pray you to allow us take the Motions numbered 14, 27 and 28. The Deputy Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is here. We want to plead with you for him to take the Motions on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, we have addressed that. Both of them were not here, when we were told that the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is out of the jurisdiction.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It was a special request from the Leadership. Mr Speaker, we stood down Motions numbered 14, 27 and 28, because the

Hon Minority Chief Whip was very specific. It is not because other Ministers are not here and he will not allow them. He said specifically in respect of the Business of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice, he wants the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice or his Deputy to be here. That is why we stood it down.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has been here all day. He is a former Leader in this House. I have seen the Deputy Minister for Defence and the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice is here. But on this occasion, we want to take the Motion of the Minister Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. *[Interruption]* No, we will not agree. Whatever he says, we are determined to take Motion number 10. Let us take Motion number 10. Why does he want to leave the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs out? Mr Speaker, I do not know if the Majority Frontbench has a problem with the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. He has been here all day. They do not like him? Let us take his Motion. When we are done, then we would take that of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice and then Defence.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we all want Mr Ahmed. He and Mr Haruna Iddrisu are the favourites of this House. But the point is that—

3:34 p.m.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, ordinarily, when a Minister is in the Chamber, you cannot sidestep the Minister and do the business of a Deputy Minister, that is the practice of this House. So, the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is here. He is ready, except that the Report has not been adequately distributed—*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, for the purposes of this House, adequate distribution happens when the Report has been loaded onto the console and sufficient copies are considered to have been made available when it is loaded onto the console.

Mr Speaker, what they are holding, are copies shared at Committee meetings. But the final copy has not been loaded onto the console. So let us pay attention to the console. When we see that it has been uploaded, then we can now take that Report. In the meantime, that of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice has been loaded onto the console, so there is sufficient distribution; there is adequate distribution, so, we will take that one and wait until Mr Ahmed Ibrahim's Report is loaded—*[Interruption]*—Is it there?

Mr Speaker, I plead that we take that of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, to calm down tempers on whether we should take that of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice or the Ministry of Local

Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, kindly indulge me to acknowledge the beautifully dressed students from Zabzugu Senior High School. They came all the way from Zabzugu—*[Hear! Hear!]* They are led by Francis Kala, who is the guidance and counselling coordinator. As I said, they are from the Zabzugu Constituency. I think the Hon Member is here. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Hon Member, I hope you take care of them, looking at the distance. We welcome you. We wish you a pleasant stay in Parliament.

[Students of Zabzugu Senior High School were acknowledged]

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Leader, which one are you taking?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: This conspiracy against Mr Ahmed Ibrahim; I can only sympathise with him. If you listen to our respected Leader, he was making the point forcefully that the Report has not been uploaded. A while ago, we took that of the Ministry of Fisheries and Aquaculture but the Report was not uploaded. That one, he turned a blind eye to it. Mr Ahmed Ibrahim, now you know that people love you.

Mr Speaker, let us do it. We on this Side are prepared to stage all the compromises in lieu of our Friend. So, for a Former Leader, we want to take Motion 10, after which we do all the others. We are all right.

Mr Dafeamekpor: We want to assure my Colleagues on the other Side that willy-nilly, we will take the Hon Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs next, after the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice does this on behalf of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice. We also have four Bills to lay. Yesterday, they demanded the presence of the Attorney-General, so we could not lay the Bills. I want us to take those quickly and then we can come back to a favourite son of the House and handle his Business.

Mr Speaker, let us move to the Motion numbered 14.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Before we take the Motion numbered 14, I forgot to also introduce Nana Budu I, who is the Chief of Swedru from Gomoa Central. Nana, you are welcome.

Thank you very much.

Hon Members—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is unavoidably absent, so the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice will do this on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, page 11—Is it the item numbered 14?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, the Motion numbered 14, on the page numbered 11 of the *Order Paper*.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We also have presentation of Papers. Why would you not let him present the Papers before we take the Motion? No, it is here, the item numbered 9. He is here, so let him lay it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members, let us turn to page 11, the item numbered 14, Motion. Let me invite the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice to do us the honours in moving the Motion.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

RIGHT TO INFORMATION COMMISSION

Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Dr Justice Srem-Sai) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice: Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢20,413,271.00 for the services of the Right to Information Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Where is the Chairperson? Mr Shaibu Mahama?

Alhaji Habib, sitting here as the Speaker, I have noted the Motion that has been moved and I think it has been

moved rightly. [*Hear! Hear!*] So, Mr Shaibu Mahama, let us hear you.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Shaibu Mahama): Mr Speaker, let me thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion and in so doing, present your Committee's Report.

Introduction

The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year was presented to Parliament on Thursday, 13th November 2025, by Dr Cassiel Ato Forson, the Hon Minister for Finance, in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution.

Pursuant to Orders 195(4) and 238 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Budget Estimates of the Right to Information Commission (RTIC) to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs for consideration and report to the House.

Deliberations

The Committee met on Thursday, 27th November 2025, and considered the Annual Budget Estimates of the Right to Information Commission. Representatives of the Commission, led by, the Chief Executive Officer Genevieve Shirley Lartey, three (3) Commissioners and other technical staff, including Officers from the Ministry of Finance, were in attendance.

The Committee expresses its appreciation to the Commission and the officials of the Ministry of Finance for their contributions during the deliberations.

Reference Documents

The Committee referred to the following documents during the consideration of the Budget Estimates:

- i. The 1992 Constitution;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of the Republic of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year;
- iv. The Programme-based Estimates for the Right to Information Commission for the 2026 Financial Year;
- v. The Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal on the 2025 Budget Estimates of the Right to Information Commission;
- vi. Right to Information Commission Act, 2019 (Act 989); and
- vii. The Right to Information Commission Medium Term Expenditure
- viii. Framework for 2025-2028.

Vision of the Commission

The Commission's vision is to set out the practical regime of right to information for all to secure access to information under the control of public authorities, in order to promote transparency and accountability in the work of every public Institution.

Mission of the Commission

To build an informed citizenry, to promote transparency in public discourse and to hold government and institutions accountable to all.

Core Functions of the Commission

The core functions of RTIC are to:

- i. Issue written orders requesting for the production of information;
- ii. Examine, reproduce, take extracts from or hold information for unlimited periods, including information found in any premises entered pursuant to an inspection conducted by the Commission in the performance of the monitoring function of the Commission;
- iii. Promote, sustain awareness and educate the public on the right to information within the country.
- iv. Conduct any research it considers necessary or appropriate for the attainment of the object of this Act;

- v. Monitor, ensure compliance and implementation of its directives by the public institution and relevant private body with this Act;
- vi. Publish findings, recommendations, orders, decisions and directives quarterly; and
- vii. Undertake any other action that the Commission considers necessary for the effective performance of its functions.

Performance Overview of the 2025 Financial Year

Programme Performance

During the year under review, the Right to Information Commission undertook various programmes and activities. The outcomes and achievements of the Commission are as follows.

Promotion of the Right to Information Act

The Commission forged strategic partnerships with key institutions to enhance the effective implementation of the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989) through the provision of technical assistance, capacity-building support, and financial resources. Prominent among these partners are STAR-Ghana, GIZ, the Open Government Partnership/European Union, and the Centre for Law and Democracy. These collaborations have significantly strengthened the Commission's mandate and facilitated the successful execution

of major initiatives, including the observance of the International Day for Universal Access to Information.

Monitoring and Compliance Exercises

In the pursuit of its statutory mandate, the Commission continues to uphold its adherence to the provisions of the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989). In the year 2025, the Commission undertook a nationwide compliance and monitoring exercise covering one hundred and one (101) public institutions to ascertain their level of conformity with the requirements of the Act. The assessment indicated that fifty-two (52) institutions were compliant, while forty-nine (49) institutions fell short of the stipulated standards.

In line with its regulatory obligations, the Commission has instituted appropriate remedial measures to address the identified gaps and to guide the affected institutions toward achieving full compliance. These efforts are intended to strengthen institutional accountability and reinforce the effective implementation of the Right to Information framework across the public sector.

Stakeholder Engagements

The Commission, throughout the year, continued to maintain a strong focus on staff development through targeted training and capacity-building initiatives. Staff benefited from programmes in Executive Training on Human Resources Policies, Presentation Skills, Public Speaking, Executive

Assistant Competencies, and a Comprehensive Methodology for Assessing RTI Implementation.

Public Sensitisation

The Commission continues to discharge its statutory mandate of promoting broad public understanding of the Act by undertaking nationwide sensitisation, education, and capacity-building programmes for public institutions on the Right of Access to Information. During the period under review, the Commission engaged a total of seventy-five (75) institutions, including the Ghana Prisons Service, the University of Ghana, the Civil Service, the Bank of Ghana, the Audit Service, and the Bono Regional Coordinating Council, among others.

Media Engagements

The media remains a critical stakeholder in advancing public awareness of the provisions and utilisation of Act 989. As a result, efforts to deepen the understanding of both institutions and applicants regarding their right to access information under the RTI Act, were undertaken by the Commission. Media Houses such as Moon Lite FM, Boss FM, GTV, Metro TV, Channel One, TV3, and Joy were engaged. These media Houses participated in a series of media sensitisation programmes across multiple platforms.

Review Applications

The Commission continues to apply Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR) mechanisms as an integral component of

its mandate to facilitate the expeditious and equitable resolution of review applications submitted under the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989). As at 2025, a total of eighty-seven (87) review applications had been received and processed at various levels. Of this number, forty-five (45) were amicably settled through ADR interventions, seven (7) culminated in the issuance of formal decisions, twenty-seven (27) remain under active consideration, four (4) were discontinued at the instance of the applicants, and four (4) were appropriately referred in line with statutory procedures.

These interventions have substantially enhanced the Commission's capacity to resolve disputes efficiently, thereby strengthening the enforcement of the Act and promoting a culture of openness and accountability within public institutions.

Overall, the Commission's continued reliance on structured ADR mechanisms has proven effective in reducing delays, promoting voluntary compliance, and fostering greater collaboration between applicants and public institutions. This approach remains critical to consolidating the gains made in the implementation of the Right to Information regime and advancing the national transparency and good governance agenda.

Celebration of RTI Month

The Commission organised a series of programmes between August and October to commemorate the 5th Anniversary RTI Month/ International

Day for Universal Access to Information. The activity projected the Commission's journey in the implementation of the RTI law and provided the opportunity for direct engagements with relevant stakeholders in the access to information space. The programmes included a Press Launch, Media and Civic Engagement, Stakeholders' Conference and a Thanksgiving Service.

Financial Performance

For the 2025 Financial year, the Right to Information Commission was allocated an amount of Eighteen Million, One Hundred and Eighty-Two Thousand, Four Hundred and Twenty-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢18,181,421.00).

The details of the financial performance of the Right to Information Commission during the year 2025 is provided as follows:

Table1 Expenditure Item / Funding Source	2025 Approved Budget	Releases (End Oct, 2025)	Actual Expenditure (Oct, 2025)	Variance (Releases)	Variance (Expendi ture)	% Utilisati on as at Oct, 2025
	A	B	C	D=A-B	E=B-C	F=(C/A) *100
Compensa- tion of Employees	15,941,876.00	13,315,712.38	10,803,160.60	2,626,163.62	2,512,551.78	67.8
GoG	15,941,876.00	13,315,712.38	10,803,160.60			
Goods & Services	2,240,545.00	1,677,568.13	986,824.69	562,976.87	690,743.44	44.0
GoG	2,240,545.00	1,677,568.13	986,824.69			
IGF	-	-	-	-	-	-
FLG	-	-	-		-	-
CAPEX	-	-	-	-	-	-
GoG	-	-	-	-	-	-
Total	18,182,421.00	14,993,280.51	11,789,985.29	3,189,140.49	3,203,295.22	64.84

Source: Presentation by the RTIC for the 2026 Budget Hearing

As of October 2025, a total of GH¢14,993,280.51 representing 82.5 per cent of the approved budget of GH¢18,182,421.00 has been released, however, utilisation of the said amount was GH¢11,789,986.29. The variance between budgeted allocation and releases was GH¢2,626,163.62 representing 3.1 per cent. The table also shows a worrying trend of allocation for CAPEX for the year.

Outlook for 2026

In the pursuit of its objective to build an informed citizenry, promote transparency of information held, check corruption and hold institutions of government accountable, the Right to Information Commission (RTIC) has outlined the following activities for the 2025 financial year.

Draft Legislative Instrument

The Commission intends to submit its draft Regulations to Parliament in the year 2026. The Commission hopes to commence the processes for engaging the relevant Parliamentary Sub-Committee to enable the presentation of the draft Regulations before Parliament for its passage to provide a clearer legal framework for operationalisation.

Sensitisation Programme

The Commission, in the year 2026, will scale up its outreach programme. It

would conduct sensitisation in fifty (50) public institutions in partnership with Civil Society Organisations to enhance transparency and citizen engagement.

Decentralisation

To improve accessibility, the Right to Information Commission plans to open five (5) regional offices in Cape Coast, Ho, Takoradi, Koforidua and Tamale.

Expansion in Compliance Monitoring

The Commission will extend its compliance monitoring measures to cover an additional 150 public institutions across Accra, Kumasi, Bolgatanga, and Sunyani. The initiative is to enhance the enforcement of rights guaranteed under the law across all levels of government.

Budgetary Allocation for The 2026 Fiscal Year

A total of Twenty Million, Four Hundred and Thirteen Thousand, Two Hundred and Seventy-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢20,413,271.00) has been allocated to the Right to Information Commission for the implementation of its activities for the 2026 financial year. Below is a table detailing the allocations by economic classification and sources of funding:

Table 2:

Budgetary Allocation by Economic Classifications and Sources of Funding

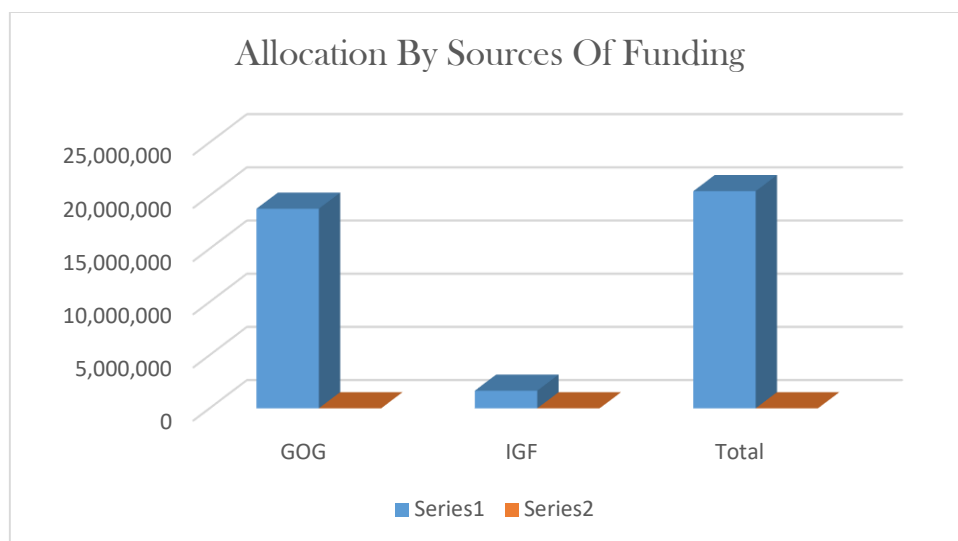
RTIC				
2026 BUDGET ALLOCATION				
ECOMOMIC CLASSIFICATION	SOURCES OF FUNDING			
	GoG	IGF	TOTAL	%
COMPENSATION OF EMPLOYESS	16,337,059.00	-	16,337,059.00	80.0
GOODS & SERVICES	2,420,545.00	1,655,667.00	4,076,212.00	20.0
CAPEX	-	-	-	
TOTAL	18,757,604.00	1,655,667.00	20,413,271.00	
%	91.9	8.1		100

Source: 2026 Presentation on the Budget Estimates by the RTIC to the Committee

The above table indicates that the RTIC has been allocated a total of GH¢20,413,271 in the 2026 financial year. The distribution of funds indicates a continued prioritisation of recurrent expenditure over administrative and operational expansion. Compensation of Employees amounts to GH¢16,337,059, representing 80 per cent of the Commission's total allocation. Goods and Services receives GH¢4,076,212, constituting the remaining 20 per cent. Notably, the Commission received no allocation for Capital Expenditure (Capex) in 2026, similar to the pattern observed in previous years.

The heavy concentration of the budget on Compensation suggests that while the Commission can maintain its staffing levels, limited funds are available to expand core operational activities such as investigations, monitoring compliance, public sensitisation, digital RTI systems, or regional presence. The absence of Capex funding is particularly concerning for a regulator whose effective functioning requires ICT systems, logistics, vehicles, office expansion, and secure digital infrastructure for compliance oversight.

Table 3:



Source: 2026 Budget and Economic Policy of Government

Observations

Delays in Releases

The Committee was informed that for the first and second quarters of the year 2025 no releases were made by the Ministry of Finance in favour of Right to Information Commission (RTIC). The situation impacted negatively on the Commission and hampered its ability to execute planned programmes and activities earmarked for the period.

The Committee noted with concern the delay in the release of funds to the Commission that hindered the Commission's ability to discharge its lawful mandate in line with the programmes and activities for the period. The Committee questioned whether it was prudent for government to provide remuneration for staff who do not have the resources and needed tools to work as a result of the delay in releases.

The Committee also observed that the Right to Information Commission (RTIC) is a creature of law. To effectively discharge its mandate of deepening transparency and promoting public accountability, any attempt to stifle the Commission with the needed resources is likely to affect its ability to monitor and ensure compliance of public institutions. Thus, in order to promote the tenants of any good democracy and strengthen anti-corruption measures while enhancing public integrity, the Commission should be adequately and timely resourced to execute its mandate of building informed citizenry and promoting transparency of information held by or under the control of public institutions.

The Committee recommends to the Ministry of Finance to ensure timely release of funds to the Commission to enable the effective execution of its mandate of holding public and relevant private institutions to act in accordance with the provisions of the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989).

Budgetary Constraints

The Committee expressed concern about funding needs of the Commission as against the allocated ceilings for the 2026 financial year. The Committee was informed that with the exception of compensation of employees, the allocation to Goods and Service is inadequate. Despite the Goods and Services projected figure of GH¢8,400,000.00 the Ministry of Finance approved ceiling is GH¢4,076,212.00 constituting 48.5 per cent. There is no allocation for CAPEX under the 2026 financial year.

The Committee notes that the Commission was unable to establish the needed presence in five (5) regions as planned under the 2025 budget due to inadequate funds. For instance, although the Commission paid two years rent for a rented facility in Cape Coast, the inability to equip the office with the needed resources due to lack of funds thwarted its effort to establish its presence.

It came to fore that at the inception of the Commission five years ago, the Commission obtained clearance for the recruitment of three hundred and sixty-five (365) staff but only one hundred and twenty (120) were actually employed. Out of this number, the Commission currently boast of one hundred and five (105). The attrition rate is partly attributed to the absence of necessary working tools such as desktop computers, laptops and photocopier machines.

The Committee is of the view, that to enable the Commission realise its object

of augmenting staff strength and establish the needed presence within the five regions as planned in the 2026 budget, the Committee recommends an upward adjustment of the Commission's budget during the Mid-Year Budget Review to enable the Commission execute its mandate in the year 2026.

Capex Deprivation

It came to fore, that the Commission had no allocation for CAPEX for the year 2025 and the situation has not change in 2026. The non-allocation of CAPEX places a limitation on the Commission's ability to acquire essential logistics for work. The Committee was informed that the three pick-ups provided by the government to the Commission at the time of its inception have become a subject of investigation by the National Investigations Bureau. As it stands now, if the vehicles are withdrawn, the Commission would be left with no vehicle to operate. This would hinder its operational activities relating to sensitisation and monitoring of public institutions' compliance with the tenets of the RTI law.

The Committee notes that in the absence of any CAPEX allocation for the year, the programmes and activities of the RTIC will grand to a halt. The Committee therefore recommends to the Ministry of Finance to consider providing some CAPEX allocation to the Commission during the consideration of the Mid-Year Budget Review.

Importance of Retooling the RTIC

The Committee noted that the right to information is a right enshrined under the

1992 Constitution which right must be exercised by all citizens without any impediments. Parliament passed the Right to Information Act, 2019 (Act 989) and gave meaning to the enforcement of that right by passing the enabling Act which brought into being the Right to Information Commission.

The Committee emphasised the importance of resourcing the RTIC as a constitutional entity, in order to enhance its objective of deepening transparency and accountability achievable. In its view, to attain the aspirations of these constitutional provisions, the RTIC which is a creature of law ought to be properly resourced to adequately perform the functions envisaged under the 1992 Constitution. Hence, adequate funding to such an important state institution is critical and ought not to be toyed with.

The Committee urges government that the RTIC is one of the institutions that should be well resourced and must be given a special dispensation and priority in terms of resources allocation.

Office Accommodation

It was disclosed that the RTIC operates from a rented facility at Dworwulu at the cost of US\$3,500 per a month, a situation that worsens its precarious financial position in the face of the inadequate resource allocation.

The Committee noted and advised that in order to lessen its financial burden, the Commission should scout for unoccupied government facilities and

notify the Chief of Staff for its eventual allocation.

The Committee urges the Commission to vigorously pursue the agenda of scouting to enable efficient use of the inadequate resources for the planned programmes and activities for the year.

Authorisation for Release of IGF Retention

The Committee was informed that the Commission was granted a 100 per cent IGF retention last year. However, the Commission cannot access the amount because of the requirement of authorisation by the Ministry of Finance for its release.

Meanwhile, the Commission expressed fear that the account may be swept if the authorization of the Ministry of Finance delays. It was of the view that any attempt to sweep the IGF retention would create a devastation effect on the Commission to honour its committed obligations.

The Committee urges the Ministry of Finance to grant timely authorization of the IGF retained to enable the Commission discharge its obligations on time.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee, in recognition of the important role played by government to support the Commission in ongoing administrative and operational needs and ensure continuity in service delivery to

the public, urge government to enhance the budgetary allocation to the Commission.

Consequently, in order to maintain the need for the Commission to enhance public awareness, improve compliance by public institutions, and deepen access to information nationwide, the Committee accordingly recommends to the House, the adoption of its report and approval of the sum of Twenty Million, Four Hundred and Thirteen Thousand, Two Hundred and Seventy-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢20,413,271.00) to the Right to Information Commission for the 2026 financial year.

Mr Speaker, I so submit.

Question proposed.

3:44 p.m.

Mrs Abena Osei-Asare (NPP — Atiwa East): Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity to contribute the Report on the Right to Information Commission. From where I came from, I know that the Right to Information Commission does a lot to help prevent illicit financial flows. The mere fact that—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member for Atiwa East, can you help the House? Where are you coming from?

Mrs Osei-Asare: Mr Speaker, from where I was the Minister of State and a Deputy Minister for Finance.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mrs Osei-Asare: Yes. They played a very significant role to help in the prevention or reduction illicit financial flows. We all know that it takes a huge chunk of our revenues in this regard. They play a very important role where they promote transparency and accountability. State actors and non-state actors, ordinary citizens, can call for information, write to them, and get information. This alone acts as a check on those who are involved in such activities.

Mr Speaker, looking at the role they play and the amount of money that has been allocated for them, it is woefully inadequate. When we look at their 2025 reports, they were given GH¢1.6 million as the sum for their goods and services and this is what they use to engage citizens and also other equally important activities.

But then, you give GH¢1.67 million, and till date they have released less than a million, GH¢986,000.00. Just 58 per cent of that. How do we expect them to work efficiently? When we look at page 3 of their Report, it also says that they have forged a partnership with quite a number of people to help promote what they do. A partnership with Star Ghana, Deutsche Gesellschaft für Internationale Zusammenarbeit (GIZ), the European Union, and other foreign partners. But we ask ourselves, they are doing a very important job for our country, so why do we not commit so much to help them achieve their objective? But rather, we expect foreign donors to help them do their work. Is this a matter of misplaced priority?

This is because I know the quantum of illicit financial flows that this country loses. So, the mere fact of their presence, what they can do and their mandate helps reduce this and I believe the Minister for Finance — I saw my Colleague, Mr Ampem here so, if he can speak to the Minister to make sure they are funded adequately. Even with the GH¢1.6 million that was given to them, like I said, they have been given 58 per cent of that amount. How do they expect them to work to help them raise the needed revenue that they need? Because we need revenue for your Big Push, *nkoko nketenkete*, and all the other things they have told us they are going to embark on in 2026. This holds the key so I expect them to do better.

Mr Speaker, again, when we go to their Reports, we all know that this year, Government increased salaries by 9 per cent and last year they were given GH¢15.7 million as part of their compensation. So, with 9 per cent, it should be around GH¢17.3 but what do we see in their budget for compensation? It is around GH¢16 million. Clearly, from the onset of this budget, they are adequately funded for their compensation. How is that possible? Yet we expect so much from them, and they are doing so much for us. This is something we ought to check. Because if GH¢15.7 million has been increased it by 9 per cent, it should be around GH¢17.3 million. So clearly, their compensation budget alone is woefully inadequate.

They will come back to this House, and we will complain that they have gone

over and above their compensation budget because the Minister refused to give them what is needed. This is not us asking for more but clearly, if you have GH¢15.7 million as your 2025 compensation amount, and Government has increased salaries by 9 per cent, GH¢16.9 million should not be what should be allocated for compensation, but rather GH¢17.3 million.

Mr Speaker, lastly, before I sit down, we also saw on page 4 of the Report that they went around monitoring compliance exercises, monitoring institutions that are compliant to the standards of the RTI. Out of the 101 institutions that they assessed, 49 fell short of the standard. In this Report, nothing has been told of how they are going to handle the 49 institutions that fell short. It is not just a matter of engaging, but we also want to see enforcement such that when people fall short, there should be sanctions or penalties to help them, or even a system where you can bring them back to track. There is nothing like that in this Report.

So, it is not just a matter of allocating the money, but we want credible outcomes that we can use to judge and say that where we are putting our monies, we are getting good feedback, or we are getting something that we believe will help strengthen our institutions in this country.

Mr Speaker, I would urge the Minister for Finance to look at the compensation budget again, and also, at least, if they claim they are giving them their goods and services, they should adequately fund them. They should not

let them be solely dependent on donor partners, because what they are doing is going a long way to help close some leakages somewhere for us and also increase our revenue. I want to urge them that they should continue with what they are doing. They should engage more, they should share their mandates with others, so that when people are confident enough to come and make requests for information, this alone will put fear in a lot of people who engage in illicit financial flow.

Mr Speaker, on this note, I would like for the House to adopt the Report and approve the sum of GH¢20,413,271.00 for the Right to Information Commission.

Thank you very much.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, I am inclined to give it to the Minister.

Yes, Hon Member for Kwesimintsim?

Mr Philip Fiifi Buckman (NDC — Kwesimintsim): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the call for the approval of the budget for the Right to Information Commission. Going through the Report, one thing is outstanding, that the Commission is bent on ensuring the promotion of a culture of openness and accountability within the public institutions. Democracy thrives on openness and accountability, and effective information helps in doing so. I would want to commend the Commission for the work done in 2025, looking at the Report, what they were

able to do, sensitising the public, going around, even with inadequate funds, they were able to perform that effective function for the state.

In 2025, the approved budget was GH¢18,182,421.00 and the release to them was GH¢14 million. In fact, we must commend the Ministry of Finance for the 82 per cent release to the Commission. I agree that we still have to do better in providing for CAPEX. We still have to do better in ensuring that they come up efficiently in performing their duties.

3:54 p.m.

Mr Speaker, I want to humbly say that the institution is performing very well and ensuring that information flows well for us. I also want to say that we should all come together to support the Commission and to support the budget as allocated to them, and I believe that by the end of the year, we shall see efficient performance from the Commission.

Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Mr Baffour? However, I still go with my plea. Let us make things a bit brief for us. I beg of you.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, the role of the RTI Commission in creating a transparent and accountable government cannot be overemphasised. But, when you look at the allocation given to it, it looks as though, as much as on paper we consider it to be an

important outlet in our fight against corruption and perhaps in ensuring transparent and accountable government, we do not seem to be putting our money where our heart is.

Mr Speaker, I looked at the amount allocated to it, and I have been wondering what we expect of that office. The office is not only a curative measure in terms of the fight against corruption, but it is also preventive. When you look at other offices that are responsible for the fight against corruption, we would see that heavy funds have been allocated to them. In some instances, GH¢158 million is allocated to agencies that rather prosecute or investigate corruption in situations where the horse has already bolted.

Mr Speaker, the RTI Commission rather puts a light on the activities of public office holders. Indeed, the RTI Commission is like a transparent glass around public office holders. But what do we see? It is so disheartening to notice that there is serious attrition in that office. Clearly, it is not an attractive office to most professionals.

Mr Speaker, one of the things that came out from our Committee hearing is the fact that a lot of them are leaving because they do not have the necessary tools for performing their duties. Why would they stay in view of the paltry sum of GH¢20 million which has been allocated to them? We need to increase funds for the Office.

Mr Speaker, it is even disheartening to note that we did not even make an

allocation for CAPEX, so they continue to live in the rented office, whereas other agencies are being spent on, and offices are being provided for them, because we thought that it was the tiger that was going to roar and drive away corruption.

Mr Speaker, if there is any office that will make corruption unattractive, it is the RTI Commission. If there is any office that will make the public office holder scared of corruption, it is the RTI Commission.

So, Mr Speaker, as I add my voice to the approval of their Budget, I am urging the Ministry of Finance to consider enhancing their Budget, and also ensure that they are paid enough to be able to retain human resources.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, I want the Deputy Minister for Finance to listen before he makes his remarks. I do not know if there is an attempt to also collapse the RTI Commission. Considering the fact that in the first and second quarters of 2025, there were zero releases, how do we expect them to survive?

Mr Speaker, with the allocation to compensation, if care is not taken, with the increments that have been done across the board, they might not be able to pay their salaries because they have allocated about GH¢16,337,059, and if we look at what was allocated last year, and we calculate 9 per cent of that, it is more than what is being given here.

Mr Speaker, capital expenditure is zero. This is a Commission that normally needs to enhance its capacity in terms of IT systems, logistics, vehicles, and office expansion. At the moment, they are still renting. They intend to get offices in five regions, which are Cape Coast, Ho, Takoradi, Koforidua and Tamale. How will they be able to do that?

Mr Speaker, the Deputy Attorney-General, who moved the Motion, is not even concentrating on what we are saying; he needs to pay attention to the RTI Commission. Many times, when citizens send their requests under the Constitution in Article 21, under the Act 989, for example, I send a request to the Office of the President with regards to the helicopter crash, they addressed it by doing a press conference on my request. There is no official response from the Presidency, but rather a press conference to address this issue. So, they need to liaise with the Minister for Finance to indicate that in the first quarter and second quarter, no releases were made. How do you expect them to survive? With the money that they have been given, there is zero capital expenditure, and compensation is less by 5 per cent. At the end of the year, if they are not careful, they might not be able to pay salaries, and this means that they are moving to a stage of collapse.

So, they need to liaise with the Ministry of Finance to enhance their capacity. Not giving them CAPEX means that they will not be able to enhance their capacity in ICT, transportation and logistics. They want to open offices, yet at the moment, they

are still renting. Why? With the money they have been given, they may not be able to pay their salary for the year. So, they need to talk to the Ministry of Finance to enhance it. Mr Dafeamekpor is the one who likes a lot of procedure when it comes to law, yet they are now using press conferences to address requests that are made under the RTI Act 989.

Mr Speaker, we should approve this Budget, but the Ministry of Finance has given out a lot of money. For example, if we take off one of the helicopters, we can add part of the money to what the RTI Commission needs. We do not need four helicopters; that is why Mr Brogya Genfi is here to move the Motion to support that. So, the important thing is that Parliament has the power to vary whatever has been budgeted for, and I am saying that we should drop some of the helicopters and give part of the money to RTI to enhance them.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, lastly, let me hear the Hon Deputy Minister.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, a lot has been said about the importance of the RTI Commission, so I do not want to belabour that point. Except to allay the fears of especially the former Minister of State at the Ministry of Finance, and Alhaji Habib, because both of them have made statements with regard to the allocation to the RTI for their compensation. I think they have not paid attention to the details, and that is why they are worried.

Mr Speaker, it is true that we have increased their compensation allocation marginally from GH¢15.9 million to GH¢16.3 million. But from the details, we would notice that this year, from January to October 2025, when we allocated GH¢15.9 million to them, and they have actually spent only GH¢10.8 million on compensation.

4:04 p.m.

So there is a balance of about GH¢5 million left. At this rate, if we look at it critically, they spend on average, a little over one million on compensation a month. There are only two months' compensation left. So, they will end the year with a balance of close to GH¢3 million. That is why we have increased it marginally. With the 9 per cent increase in compensation, the allocation will still be able to cater for the compensation needs of the RTI Commission, and even a few employees, if they so choose to add onto it.

There was also another point that was made with regard to their getting donor funds, that the fact that they get donor funds does not mean we should not give them an allocation from the Government of Ghana (GoG) source. The way it works, and my senior Colleague is very aware, is that when we are doing allocation, we look at the total sources of funds to the State, and then we say, if they are getting donor funds, they do not really need more of the GoG funding. So it balances out. I just wanted to put on record that the allocation for compensation will be able to adequately

cater for compensation for 2026, so they should not be worried.

Thank you.

Mrs Osei-Asare: Mr Speaker, just a correction, and to let my Colleague on the other Side know that what he said is not the case. When we look at the Report, page 7, it says releases at the end of October is GH¢13.3 million. The Ministry of Finance will only release the compensation when one needs it. Compensation includes other allowances, so the Ministry of Finance has released GH¢13.3 million at the end of October. So I still stand by that, that it is inadequate. It is not a 10, because compensation includes other allowances, so the Ministry of Finance will pay the salary plus the allowances, and that is why the Ministry of Finance has released GH¢13.3 million in October, and the actual, which is the salary, GH¢10.8 million has been paid. Otherwise, the Ministry of Finance would never have released it.

Even moneys that are due ministries, departments and agencies are not being released. So why does he think the Ministry of Finance will release money for fun? That is not possible, Mr Speaker. The GH¢13.3 million is the actual release that the Ministry of Finance has made, and it is because the Ministry of Finance thinks that is what should be given to them by October. Thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, are you also coming back?

Mr Ampem: Yes, she must be corrected. Mr Speaker, she should read the Report well. There is releases, and there is actual expenditure; the actual expenditure as of October is GHC10.8 million, and that is the point I am making. So as of October, the actual expenditure is GHC10.8 million. So, at this rate, this is what is going to happen. Thank you.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GHC20,413,271.00 for the services of the Right to Information Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, please, the Motion numbered 27.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right, Hon Members. The Motion numbered 27—Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we in Leadership have a responsibility to help in navigating Business, that is why we normally have a Conclave. That is why oftentimes we defer matters and say the Leadership should confer. We conferred, and the agreement was that when we take that Motion, we will revert to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. My Friend did not get back to me. If he has changed his mind, that is all right. He can do so, but if it is the case that he has changed his mind, he should revert to us.

What is the problem with Hon Ahmed? What is happening in this House? We do not understand. Mr Speaker, we have the Report on the console. We also have hard copies. So they should justify why they want to sidestep the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Tell us. We are listening.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the Minority Chief Whip, just about 30 minutes ago, would not let me have peace. He said, apart from the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, he wants his Deputy. If the Deputy does not come, that Business would not be taken. I summoned the Deputy, and he has come. Because of that even yesterday, we could not lay his Bills. They insisted that the Deputy must be here. Now we have brought him.

They raised the issue about *mensuro*. [**Some Hon Members:** Who is *mensuro*?] Mr Speaker, *mensuro* is the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Now, I implored them that the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice has several Businesses. Apart from the three Motions, there are Bills. So, let us take those and get it over with. After that, we will take the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. That was the agreement. The agreement was not that we will take the Motion numbered 14 and come back to 10, before we go back to 27 and 28, which stands in the name of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, and then go back to 9 to lay the Bills. So that once we are dealing with

his Businesses, we take care of all those. This is the agreement.

If they insist that we take the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs —Mr Speaker, the Motion numbered 10.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are not in a hurry. I need to respond to him. The Motion number 10; that is all right. Clearly, Hon Ahmed Ibrahim needs prayers. *[Laughter]* Because with the Business of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, apart from the Motion, it is just the First Reading of the three Bills. That is not difficult; however, we have a senior Member of this House, and they are detaining the man. The man has been in Leadership. What is the evil of Hon Ahmed? I do not understand. What has Hon Ahmed Ibrahim done? So, Hon Ahmed Ibrahim clearly needs prayers. He called it the item numbered 10, so let us proceed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, to save the House, let us turn to the item numbered 10. Hon Leader, let me deal with Hon Ahmed Ibrahim.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I am surprised that the Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is being subjected to this treatment. *[Laughter]* Religion. Where we will all spend eternity. And they are humiliating him this way in the Chamber.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon Minister, let us hear you.

4:14 p.m.

Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (Mr Ahmed Ibrahim) (MP): Mr Speaker, the way my Colleagues are praying for me— I have sat on the other Side for eight years, when the Minority is calling a person, then that person must be ready for releases. So, I really need prayers.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

MINISTRY OF LOCAL GOVERNMENT, CHIEFTAINCY AND RELIGIOUS AFFAIRS

Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (Mr Ahmed Ibrahim) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢4,793,139,071.00 for the services of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mrs Queenstar Maame Pokuah Sawyerr): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the Motion and in so doing, I present this Report of the joint committee of the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development and the Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs.

Executive Summary

This Report presents the findings and recommendations of the Joint Committee on

Local Government and Rural Development and the Committee on Chieftaincy, Culture and Religious Affairs on the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (MLGCRA), in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 193 and 95(2) of the Standing Orders of Parliament. The Budget was referred to the Committee following its presentation to the House by the Minister for Finance, Hon Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, on 11th November, 2025.

For the 2026 Financial Year, an amount of Four Billion, Seven Hundred and Ninety-Three Million, One Hundred and Thirty-Nine Thousand, and Seventy-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢4,793,139,071.00) has been allocated to the Ministry and its Agencies. The allocation is composed of Government of Ghana (GoG) funds, Internally Generated Funds (IGF) and Development Partner (DP) support. The distribution by expenditure item is as follows: 65.04 per cent for Compensation of Employees, 19.00 per cent for Goods and Services, and 15.96 per cent for Capital Expenditure.

In reviewing the Ministry's 2025 performance, the Committee observed significant achievements across its nine Programmes, notably:

- Improvements in sector data systems, including upgrades to the District Development Data Platform (DDDP) and the DPAT portal.

- Continued progress in developing the National Decentralisation Policy and Strategy (2026–2029), and the disbursement of GH¢25 million in allowances to 261 MMDAs for Assembly Members.
- Provision of temporary employment to 65,020 poor and indigent individuals through community development initiatives.
- Expansion of horticultural training and greening initiatives within the Department of Parks and Gardens.
- Enhancement of the National Sanitation Day (NSD) platform and implementation of school source segregation pilots through the GARID Project.
- Registration of 432,925 births and 41,882 deaths by the Births and Deaths Registry;
- Monitoring and technical support provided by the 16 RCCs to all MMDAs;
- Strengthened institutional collaboration and regulatory support by LUSPA; and
- Enhanced engagements with Traditional and Religious Authorities, including support to Judicial Committees of Houses of Chiefs.

The Committee, however, identified several constraints affecting sector performance. These include:

- Persistent delays and shortfalls in budget releases, particularly for Goods and Services and Capital Expenditure;
- Inadequate staffing and inconsistent reporting across the Local Government Service;
- Insufficient office and residential accommodation, especially in the newly created regions;
- Limited logistics and digital infrastructure for effective planning, sanitation enforcement, community development and civil registration; and
- Outstanding Legislative Instruments required for the effective functioning of chieftaincy institutions.

To address these challenges, the Committee recommends, inter alia:

- A rebalancing of expenditure towards Goods and Services and CAPEX to improve service delivery;
- Improved predictability and timeliness of releases by the Ministry of Finance;
- A comprehensive staff rationalisation exercise within the Local Government Service, based on

needs assessments and approved structures;

- Prioritisation of completing RCC offices and residential facilities in the new regions;
- Enhanced digital systems and capacity-building across RCCs, MMDAs, and Agencies; and
- Expedited processing of the seventeen (17) draft Legislative Instruments relating to stools, skins, and traditional council governance.

Subject to the observations and recommendations in this Report, the Committee recommends to the House the approval of GH¢4,793,139,071.00 for the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the 2026 Financial Year.

Introduction

Pursuant to Article 179(1) of the 1992 Constitution and Orders 193 and 95(2) of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Minister responsible for Finance and Honourable Member for Ajumako Enyan Esiam, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, on Thursday, 11th November, 2025, presented to the House the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year.

Following the referral of the Budget to the relevant Committees in accordance with the Standing Orders, the Joint Committee on Local Government,

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and Sanitation and Water Resources met on Thursday, 27th November and Friday, 28th November, 2025 to consider the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (MLGCRA) for the 2026 Financial Year.

Attending were the Hon Minister responsible for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, Mr Ahmed Ibrahim; the Hon Deputy Minister, Mrs Rita Naa Odoley Sowah; the Chief Director of the Ministry; Heads of Agencies under the Ministry; and other senior officials from both the Ministry and the Ministry of Finance who supported the Committee in its deliberations.

The Committee expresses its appreciation to the Hon Minister, the Deputy Minister, the Chief Director, and the technical teams for their cooperation and assistance. The Committee also acknowledges with gratitude the participation of the scheduled officers from the Ministry of Finance, whose contributions facilitated the Committee's consideration of the Estimates.

Reference Documents

In the course of examining the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, the Committee relied on the following key documents:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;

- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament (2024 Edition)
- iii. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Fiscal Year.
- iv. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year;
- v. The 2026–2029 Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF) and the Programme-Based Budget Estimates for the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs; and
- vi. Relevant Reports of the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development, including the 2025 Annual Budget Estimates of:
 - the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs;
 - the Ministry of Sanitation and Water Resources; and
 - the Ministry of Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

These documents provided the constitutional, procedural, and policy basis for the Committee's review of the Estimates.

Mandate, Mission and Functions of the Ministry

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (MLGCRA) derives its mandate from a

combination of constitutional provisions, statutory enactments, and sector policy frameworks that collectively define its responsibilities for decentralisation, local governance, chieftaincy administration, and religious affairs coordination.

Mandate of the Ministry

The Ministry's mandate is based on:

- Articles 240–252 of the 1992 Constitution, which provide for decentralisation, the establishment of Local Government Authorities, and the promotion of local participation in governance;
- The Local Governance Act, 2016 (Act 936), which regulates the political, administrative, and planning authority of Metropolitan, Municipal and District Assemblies (MMDAs);
- The Chieftaincy Act, 2008 (Act 759), which provides for the National House of Chiefs, the Regional and Traditional Councils, and the regulation of matters relating to chiefship, customary law and succession;
- Policy directives relating to the coordination of religious affairs, aimed at fostering national cohesion, inter-faith collaboration, and peaceful coexistence.

Together, these provisions assign the Ministry the responsibility for steering and coordinating the country's decentralised governance structure,

supporting the chieftaincy institution, and managing religious affairs.

Mission of the Ministry

The Mission of the Ministry is:

To promote decentralisation, effective local governance, socio-cultural harmony, and inclusive development through suitable policies, capacity-building, and responsive public services.

This mission emphasises the Ministry's commitment to responsive local government, robust traditional governance systems, and lasting social cohesion.

Core Functions of the Ministry

In fulfilment of its mandate, the Ministry performs the following core functions:

a. Decentralisation and Local Governance

- Formulating and coordinating decentralisation policies;
- Providing policy guidance and oversight to MMDAs, Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs), and the Local Government Service (LGS);
- Strengthening planning, budgeting, monitoring and evaluation systems at the local level;
- Promoting local economic development (LED) and community empowerment.

b. Chieftaincy and Traditional Governance

- Supporting the National, Regional, and Traditional Houses of Chiefs in fulfilling their constitutional and statutory roles.
- Handling issues pertaining to customary law, succession, and dispute resolution mechanisms within the chieftaincy institution.
- Collaborating with traditional authorities to promote peacebuilding, cultural preservation, and reforms in customary governance.

c. Religious Affairs Coordination

- Promoting dialogue among religious bodies to enhance national cohesion;
- Supporting policy responses to emerging issues in the religious sector;
- Facilitating cooperation between Government and faith-based institutions in areas of social development.

d. Sector Oversight and Institutional Coordination

The Ministry has oversight responsibility for the following institutions:

1. Local Government Service (LGS/OHLGS)

2. Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs)

3. Institute of Local Government Studies (ILGS)

4. Department of Parks and Gardens (DPG)

5. Births and Deaths Registry (BDR)

6. Land Use and Spatial Planning Authority (LUSPA)

7. Department of Community Development (DoCD)

8. Chieftaincy Secretariat and Houses of Chiefs

9. Religious Affairs Directorate

10. Environmental Health and Sanitation Directorate (EHSD)

These agencies collectively assist the Ministry in fulfilling its mandate for decentralisation, cultural governance, and social cohesion.

Contribution to National Development

The Ministry plays a role in national development by:

- Enhancing service delivery at the sub-national level;
- Promoting inclusive governance and citizen participation;
- Supporting peaceful and functional chieftaincy institutions;

- Strengthening legal identity systems through the BDR;
- Promoting orderly spatial planning and environmental management;
- Facilitating urban greening and the enhancement of public spaces;
- Improving socio-economic resilience through community development programmes.

In performing these functions, the Ministry remains key to Ghana's pursuit of sustainable development, local level transformation, and national unity.

Performance Review for 2025 – Ministry of Local Government, Decentralisation and Rural Development

For the 2025 Fiscal Year, an amount of Four Billion, Forty-Four Million, Three Hundred and Fifty-six thousand, four Hundred and fifty-four Ghana Cedis (GH¢4,044,356,454.00) was approved for the Ministry of Local Government, Decentralisation and Rural Development and its Agencies. The approved allocation covered Compensation of Employees, Goods and Services, and Capital Expenditure from the Government of Ghana (GoG), Development Partners (DP), and Internally Generated Funds (IGF).

The breakdown of the allocation, releases, and expenditure performance is presented in **Table 1**.

Table 1: 2025 Budget Allocation by Source and Expenditure Items

(All figures in Ghana Cedis – GH¢)

Expenditure Item / Funding Source	Approved Budget (A)	Releases as at Sept. 2025 (B)	Actual Expenditure (C)	Variance 1 (A–B)	Variance 2 (B–C)
Compensation of Employees					
GoG	2,708,564,957.00	2,074,596,190.20	2,074,596,190.20	633,968,766.80	0.00
IGF	4,000,000.00	2,574,952.45	2,574,952.45	1,425,047.55	0.00
Goods and Services					
GoG	48,643,584.00	23,375,923.81	13,045,923.81	25,267,660.19	10,330,000.00
IGF	17,830,700.00	9,649,148.22	10,844,929.78	8,181,551.78	-1,195,781.56
DP	608,542,213.00	368,050,740.59	368,050,740.59	240,490,472.41	0.00
Capital Expenditure (CapEx)					
GoG	147,300,000.00	88,380,000.00	0.00	58,920,000.00	88,380,000.00
DP	509,375,000.00	13,427,762.91	13,427,762.91	495,947,237.09	0.00
IGF	100,000.00	241,658.37	241,658.37	-141,658.37	0.00
GRAND TOTAL	4,044,356,454.00	2,580,297,376.55	2,482,783,158.11	1,464,059,077.45	97,514,218.44

Source: 2026–2029 Medium-Term Expenditure Framework – Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs

For the 2025 Fiscal Year, a total approved budget of GH¢4,044,356,454.00 was allocated to the Ministry of Local Government, Decentralisation and Rural Development (MLGDRD) and its Agencies. This amount comprised resources from the Government of Ghana (GoG), Development Partners (DP), and Internally Generated Funds (IGF) for the execution of activities across Compensation of Employees, Goods and Services, and Capital Expenditure (CapEx).

Compensation of Employees

Under GoG, the Ministry received an approved allocation of GH¢2,708,564,957.00 for Compensation of Employees. As at September 2025, a total of GH¢2,074,596,190.20 had been released, representing 76.6 per cent of the approved figure, and the entire amount was fully expended.

Additionally, under IGF, an approved allocation of GH¢4,000,000.00 was provided for Compensation. Releases totaled GH¢2,574,952.45, all of which were fully utilised. The Ministry therefore recorded no variance between releases and actual expenditure for both GoG and IGF, indicating full application of funds received.

Goods and Services

For Goods and Services, GoG approved an amount of GH¢48,643,584.00. Releases amounted to GH¢23,375,923.81, out of which GH¢13,045,923.81 was expended as at

September 2025. This resulted in an unutilised released balance of GH¢10,330,000.00, and a funding gap of GH¢25,267,660.19 when compared with the approved amount.

Under IGF, the Ministry received an approved allocation of GH¢17,830,700.00 for Goods and Services. Releases as at September 2025 were GH¢9,649,148.22, while actual expenditure amounted to GH¢10,844,929.78. This resulted in an over-expenditure of GH¢1,195,781.56, indicating that operational demands exceeded the resources released.

Under Development Partner (DP) support, an amount of GH¢608,542,213.00 was approved for Goods and Services. Releases amounted to GH¢368,050,740.59, and the full amount released was expended, resulting in no variance between releases and actual expenditure. However, the shortfall between approved and released funding remains significant at GH¢240,490,472.41.

Capital Expenditure (CapEx)

For GoG-funded CapEx, the Ministry was allocated GH¢147,300,000.00. Releases totaled GH¢88,380,000.00, representing 60 per cent of the approved figure. However, no expenditure had been recorded as at September 2025, leaving the full released amount unspent. This resulted in a release–expenditure variance of GH¢88,380,000.00 and an unreleased balance of GH¢58,920,000.00.

Under Development Partner funding for CapEx, the Ministry received an approved amount of GH¢509,375,000.00. Releases amounted to GH¢13,427,762.91, all of which were fully expended. The difference between the approved amount and releases stood at GH¢495,947,237.09, reflecting substantial reliance on expected DP resources yet to be disbursed.

Under IGF, CapEx allocation was GH¢100,000.00. Releases amounted to GH¢241,658.37, and this amount was fully expended, resulting in an over-expenditure of GH¢141,658.37 relative to the approved allocation.

Overall Sector Performance

Overall, out of the GH¢4,044,356,454.00 approved for the sector, a total of GH¢2,580,297,376.55 had been released as at September 2025, representing approximately 63.8 per cent of the approved allocation. Actual expenditure amounted to GH¢2,482,783,158.11, reflecting a utilisation rate of 96.2 per cent of releases.

The Ministry therefore recorded a total funding gap (approved minus released) of GH¢1,464,059,077.45, and an overall release–expenditure variance of GH¢97,514,218.44.

The Committee observes that, although the Ministry showed high utilisation of released funds, notable shortfalls in releases—especially for DP-funded programmes and GoG-funded

CapEx—hindered the timely execution of key projects and service delivery programmes across the local governance sector.

Performance for 2025 (Non-Financial) and Outlook for 2026

The Ministry delivers its mandate through nine (9) Programmes, implemented by the central Ministry and its Agencies. The Committee examined the 2025 non-financial performance of each Programme and the outlook for 2026 based on presentations from the Ministry, its Agencies, and related documentation.

The programmes are as follows:

1. Management and Administration
2. Decentralisation
3. Local Level Development and Management
4. Parks and Gardens
5. Environmental Health and Sanitation
6. Births and Deaths Registration
7. Regional Services
8. Land Use and Spatial Planning
9. Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs

Management and Administration 2025 Performance

In 2025, the Ministry undertook key administrative and institutional

strengthening initiatives to enhance sector coordination and monitoring. Notably:

- The Ministry activated all required non-financial systems for data capture under its Monitoring and Evaluation framework.
- The Ministry integrated the District Performance Assessment Tool (DPAT) scoring sheet into the District Development Data Platform (DDDP).
- The Ministry developed and rolled out the DPAT Assessment Portal, enabling improved data collection, verification, and reporting.
- Administrative support was provided to Agencies and RCCs to facilitate timely submission of performance reports.

Outlook for 2026

In 2026, the Ministry intends to:

- Operationalise additional modules on the DDDP to enhance real-time reporting by MMDAs.
- Build the capacity of staff of RCCs, MMDAs, Technical Working Groups (TWGs) and the DDDP Steering Committee in data utilisation and sector reporting.
- Strengthen internal audit systems, procurement management, and PFM compliance to support the delivery of decentralisation reforms.

Decentralisation Programme 2025 Performance

The Committee observed significant progress in the coordination of Ghana's Decentralisation agenda. Key achievements include:

- In collaboration with the Inter-Ministerial Coordinating Committee on Decentralisation (IMCCoD), the Ministry held 4 zonal consultative workshops and 2 national stakeholder meetings towards the development of the National Decentralisation Policy and Strategy (2026–2029).
- A total of GHC25,000,000.00 was disbursed to the 261 MMDAs to pay monthly allowances of Assembly Members, thereby strengthening local democratic representation.
- The Ministry coordinated cross-sectoral alignment of district plans and ensured compliance with planning guidelines issued by the NDPC.

Outlook for 2026

The Ministry will:

- Transfer approximately GHC1.2 billion (Investment Grant) to the 261 MMDAs to support the implementation of the 2026 Annual Action Plans (AAPs).
- Engage Parliament on the review of the DACF disbursement

formula, with a proposal to increase the share from 5 per cent to 5.5 per cent to ensure a more equitable and sustainable fiscal base for local governments.

- Launch and disseminate the National Urban Policy and Implementation Plan (2026–2035) to guide urban development nationwide.
- Strengthen collaboration with IMCCoD to advance intergovernmental policy coherence.

Local Level Development and Management Programme 2025 Performance

The Ministry implemented several initiatives aimed at improving local development outcomes. These include:

- Provision of temporary employment to 65,020 poor and extremely poor persons, of whom 70 per cent were women and 1,350 were Persons with Disabilities (PWDs).
- Payment of a total of GH¢2,884,150.00 in wages to 2,786 community workers, including 1,101 women; youth formed 34.62 per cent of the workforce.
- Continued supervision of infrastructure projects across the newly created regions, particularly administration blocks, staff bungalows, and related facilities for RCCs and decentralised departments.

Outlook for 2026

In 2026, the Ministry will:

- Complete and commission outstanding infrastructure projects in the six newly created regions, including RCC administrative facilities and departmental bungalows.
- Undertake feasibility studies for the preparation of Integrated Solid Waste Management Masterplans for five coastal cities, thereby improving resilience against climate and sanitation challenges.
- Expand social protection partnerships and community development interventions across MMDAs.

Parks and Gardens Programme 2025 Performance

The Department of Parks and Gardens made significant strides in urban beautification and horticultural development:

- Maintained a total green area of 1,869,589m² nationwide.
- Trained 1,673 students (921 males, 752 females) in horticulture across its training centres.
- Propagated 203,249 seedlings for sale and public landscaping.
- Landscaped 108,758m² of public and institutional spaces.

Outlook for 2026

The Department plans to:

- Maintain an expanded landscape area of 2,500,000m² across major cities and towns.
- Propagate 400,000 seedlings for national greening initiatives.
- Strengthen collaboration with the media to enhance public awareness on horticultural preservation.
- Achieve a projected 195,000 visitor turnout at the Aburi Botanical Gardens through enhanced promotional activities.

Environmental Health and Sanitation Programme 2025 Performance

The Committee notes the following achievements:

- Introduction and nationwide roll-out of National Sanitation Day (NSD) as part of the Clean Up Ghana Agenda, aimed at improving cleanliness and sanitation behaviour.
- Validation of the revised Environmental Sanitation Policy (2010) and the National Environmental Sanitation Strategy and Action Plan (NESSAP).
- Initiated a school-based waste segregation pilot in 15 schools within the Greater Accra Region under the GARID Project.

Outlook for 2026

The Ministry intends to:

- Sustain the nationwide implementation of National Sanitation Day.
- Scale up source segregation programmes to institutions nationwide.
- Promote Community-Led Total Sanitation (CLTS), Market-Based Sanitation (MBS) and household toilet programmes to maintain Open Defecation Free (ODF) achievements.
- Complete administrative blocks and residential facilities for RCCs and decentralised departments in the newly created regions, as well as for Regional Police Commands and their Deputies.

Births and Deaths Registration Programme 2025 Performance

During 2025, the Births and Deaths Registry achieved:

- Registration of 432,925 births (221,030 males; 212,895 females), representing 54 per cent of the expected 801,935 births.
- Registration of 41,882 deaths (22,678 males; 19,204 females), representing 29.2 per cent of the expected 143,485 deaths.

Outlook for 2026

The Registry aims to:

- Register 735,966 births out of an expected 817,740 births.
- Register 58,581 deaths out of an expected 146,453 deaths.
- Continue the implementation of the Births and Deaths Act, 2020 (Act 1027).
- Roll out the Vital Statistics Strategic Plan (2025–2030).

Regional Services Programme 2025 Performance

The 16 Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs) delivered their statutory mandates through:

- Conducting four (4) monitoring visits per RCC to MMDAs.
- Supporting MMDAs in the review of their Composite Plans and Composite Budgets.
- Conducting the 2025 Regional Composite Budget Implementation Monitoring Exercise from 26th–30th June 2025.
- Holding Regional Budget Hearings from 14th–24th October 2025.

Outlook for 2026

In 2026, RCCs will:

- Rehabilitate office accommodations and residences in 10 RCCs.

- Strengthen coordination and technical backstopping to MMDAs.
- Organise Regional Budget Hearings and Composite Budget Monitoring across all regions.

Land Use and Spatial Planning Programme 2025 Performance

The Land Use and Spatial Planning Authority (LUSPA) undertook key initiatives, including:

- Strengthening collaboration with key stakeholders such as the Energy Commission and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC).
- Supporting the implementation of the Fees and Charges (Miscellaneous Provisions) Regulations, 2023 (L.I. 2481).

Outlook for 2026

The Authority intends to:

- Pursue amendments to Act 925 and operationalise the Land Use and Spatial Planning Development Fund (LUSPDF).
- Disseminate and roll out training on Revised Zoning Guidelines, the Planning Manual, and updated spatial planning procedures.
- Strengthen Spatial Planning Committees (SPCs), Technical Sub-Committees (TSCs), and Physical Planning Departments across all 261 MMDAs.

2026 Budget Allocation for The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs

For the 2026 Financial Year, the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (MLGCRA) has been allocated a total amount of Four Billion, Seven Hundred and Ninety-Three Million, One Hundred and Thirty-Nine Thousand, and Seventy-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢4,793,139,071.00) to implement its programmes and activities.

This allocation comprises resources from the Government of Ghana (GoG), Internally Generated Funds (IGF), and Development Partners (DP) under the Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF). The expenditure is distributed across Compensation of Employees, Goods and Services, and Capital Expenditure (CapEx).

The detailed breakdown of the allocation is presented in Table 2.

Table 2: 2026 Budget Allocation by Sources of Funds and Expenditure Items

(All figures in Ghana Cedis – GH¢)

Item	GoG	IGF	DP Fund	ABFA	Total	% Share
Compensation of Employees	3,110,169,089.00	7,085,250.00	1,117,917,213.00	–	3,117,254,339.00	65.04 %
Goods & Services	478,667,494.00	11,661,067.00	420,338,340.00	–	910,666,901.00	19.00 %
Capital Expenditure (CapEx)	146,600,000.00	9,458,231.00	609,159,600.00	–	765,217,831.00	15.96 %
Total	3,735,436,583.00	28,204,548.00	1,029,497,940.00	–	4,793,139,071.00	100 %
%Share	77.93 %	0.59 %	21.48 %	–	100 %	–

The Committee observed that the 2026 allocation reflects the Ministry's critical mandate in advancing Decentralisation, supporting Local Governance Structures, strengthening Chieftaincy Institutions, and promoting Religious Harmony nationwide.

Key observations include:

a) Compensation of Employees – 65.04 per cent of Total Allocation

A total of GH¢3,117,254,339.00 has been earmarked for Compensation, reflecting the Ministry's large workforce across the Local Government Service, RCCs, Decentralised Departments, Houses of Chiefs, and associated agencies. This remains the dominant cost driver in the sector.

b) Goods and Services – 19.00 per cent of Total Allocation

An allocation of GH¢910,666,901.00 has been made to support operational activities such as:

- Local governance coordination
- Capacity-building programmes
- Chieftaincy adjudication processes
- Environmental health and sanitation enforcement
- Maintenance of parks, gardens, and open spaces
- Births and deaths registration services
- Spatial planning functions

c) Capital Expenditure (CapEx) – 15.96 per cent of Total Allocation

A total of GH¢765,217,831.00 will support infrastructure development and modernisation across:

- RCCs and MMDA administrative facilities
- Training centres and horticultural installations
- Spatial planning infrastructure
- Chieftaincy institutions and traditional councils

d) Funding Sources

- GoG remains the primary funding source, contributing 77.93 per cent of the total.
- Development Partners contribute 21.48 **per cent**, mainly towards technical assistance, urban development, sanitation, and planning systems.
- IGF accounts for 0.59 per cent, reflecting revenue from Births and Deaths Registry, ILGS, Parks and Gardens, and LUSPA.

The Committee notes that the balance of funding between GoG and DP support underscores the importance of both domestic resource mobilisation and sustained development partner collaboration for sector outcomes.

Observations and Recommendations

In the course of its deliberations on the 2025 Performance and the 2026 Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs (MLGCRA) and its Agencies, the Committee made a number of observations and proposes the following recommendations.

Cross-Cutting Observations and Recommendations Imbalance in the Budget Structure

The Committee notes that the 2026 Budget Allocation is heavily skewed towards Compensation of Employees, which accounts for 65.04 per cent of the

total allocation, while Goods and Services and Capital Expenditure constitute 19.00 per cent and 15.96 per cent respectively. In 2025, similar patterns were observed, with serious shortfalls in releases for Goods and Services and CapEx, and in some cases (notably GoG-funded CapEx), no expenditure had been recorded as at September 2025 despite substantial releases.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Finance and the MLGCRA work towards rebalancing the expenditure mix in favour of Goods and Services and Capital Expenditure, to ensure that the large wage bill translates into tangible service delivery outcomes at the local level. Priority should be given to funding operational activities and infrastructure critical to decentralisation, spatial planning, sanitation, civil registration and chieftaincy administration.

Delays and Shortfalls in Releases

Across several programmes, the Committee observed significant gaps between approved allocations and actual releases, especially for Development Partner (DP) resources and GoG-funded Capital Expenditure. This has led to delays in completing administrative blocks, staff bungalows, spatial planning infrastructure, and chieftaincy-related projects in the newly created regions.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Finance improves the predictability and timeliness of releases, particularly for CapEx and critical

Goods and Services, and that the Ministry intensifies engagement with Development Partners to ensure disbursement schedules are honoured. The Ministry should also prioritise the completion of existing projects before initiating new ones.

Human Resource Gaps and Rationalisation

The Committee noted inadequate staffing in some departments of the MMDAs and Agencies, alongside inconsistent reporting on staff strength and recruitment. There are also disparities in the distribution of technical personnel, particularly planners, engineers, environmental health officers, and community development staff, across districts and regions.

The Committee recommends that the Local Government Service (LGS) undertakes a comprehensive staff rationalisation exercise, including an audit and redistribution of personnel, subject to financial clearance from the Ministry of Finance. Particular attention must be paid to underserved and newly created districts. The LGS should also ensure that all officers are appropriately graded and well placed in line with the approved establishment.

Infrastructure and Logistics Deficits

The Committee observed that several Regional Coordinating Councils, decentralised departments, and chieftaincy institutions face inadequate office accommodation, residential facilities, and logistics, especially in the

newly created regions. These deficits undermine effective supervision, monitoring and adjudication functions.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry prioritises the completion and furnishing of RCC offices and bungalows, and the provision of vehicles and ICT equipment to RCCs, Houses of Chiefs, and key Agencies. Where feasible, the Ministry should explore Public–Private Partnerships (PPPs) and cost-sharing arrangements with MMDAs to address these infrastructure gaps.

Digitalisation, Data Systems and Monitoring

The Committee notes the progress made in digitalising sector data systems, including the District Development Data Platform (DDDP), the DPAT portal, and the ongoing digitisation of births and deaths registration and spatial planning systems. However, the effective use of these platforms is constrained by limited connectivity, skills gaps, and logistical challenges at RCC and MMDA levels.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry:

- Intensifies capacity-building for staff of RCCs, MMDAs and Agencies in the use of these digital platforms;
- Ensures the provision of adequate ICT equipment and connectivity; and
- Strengthens the Monitoring and Evaluation systems that feed into national development planning and budget reporting.

Zero Ceiling for Critical Monitoring & Evaluation (M&E) Activities

The Committee was concerned that certain critical budget lines related to performance and accountability, which had clear objectives for promoting effective monitoring and social accountability, as well as strengthening performance management culture, received a zero-ceiling allocation in the 2026 budget.

Although the Committee acknowledged the fact that the zero-ceiling request was for a special, high-level M&E, specifically for monitoring the performance of Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Chief Executives (MMDCEs), who are political heads, and for whom Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) have been developed, and therefore was distinct from the Ministry's routine M&E, it argued that such separate budget lines risks double-spending, since all Ministries' activities are for the Office of the President.

The Committee therefore recommended that the Ministry of Local Government should improve its internal M&E systems to incorporate such data collation, rather than creating a new budget line and putting pressure on the Ministry of Finance. It added that since the Ministry of Finance issues a bulk ceiling, the Ministry of Local Government had the discretion to allocate at least a small amount to these crucial areas to build a case for supplementary funding, rather than putting a zero.

Agency-Specific Observations and Recommendations Local Government Service (LGS)

The Committee was informed of several challenges confronting the Local Government Service, including:

- Inadequate staffing in some departments of the assemblies;
- Inadequate budgetary allocations relative to the Service's expanding mandate;
- Non-release or delayed release of quarterly Goods and Services allocations to divisions of the Service; and
- Inadequate office and residential accommodation, particularly for staff in newly created Assemblies;
- Inconsistent reporting on staff strength and recruitment across the Service.

The Committee recommends that:

- The LGS undertakes a comprehensive rationalisation of staff, aligning recruitment and deployment with clear needs assessments, and only recruiting upon receipt of financial clearance from the Ministry of Finance;
- The LGS ensures that all officers are properly placed and graded in accordance with established schemes of service;

- The Ministry and the LGS work together to secure adequate logistics and accommodation, particularly in the new regions and new districts; and
- The Ministry of Finance ensures the timely release of Goods and Services allocations to sustain supervision and capacity-building activities.

Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs)

The Committee notes that while RCCs continued to perform their coordination and monitoring roles, they are constrained by:

- Inadequate operational funds for regular monitoring of MMDAs;
- Office and residential accommodation challenges in some regions;
- Limited logistics (vehicles, ICT tools) to undertake composite budget monitoring and technical backstopping.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry prioritises the rehabilitation and completion of RCC offices and residences as indicated in the 2026–2029 MTEF;
- RCCs be adequately resourced to undertake at least four monitoring visits per year to each MMDA;
- The Ministry of Finance ensures stable funding for RCCs' Goods and Services votes to support effective regional oversight.

Institute of Local Government Studies (ILGS)

The Institute plays a strategic role in building the capacities of local government functionaries, yet:

- Its infrastructure and training facilities require upgrading;
- It faces funding constraints in running its training and research programmes;
- Demand for training from MMDAs, RCCs and other stakeholders exceeds its current capacity.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry and the ILGS develop a medium-term institutional strengthening plan, including infrastructure upgrades and modernisation of training facilities;
- Adequate budgetary support be provided to ILGS to deliver targeted training for Assembly Members, MMDA staff, RCC staff and chieftaincy institutions;
- ILGS be supported to expand e-learning platforms to increase reach and reduce training costs.

Department of Parks and Gardens (DPG)

The Committee acknowledges the important role of the DPG in urban

greening and environmental beautification. However, the Department:

- Operates with limited resources and logistics, given the scale of green spaces to be maintained nationwide;
- Has difficulty maintaining equipment and sustaining the landscaping of public spaces;
- Requires stronger collaboration with MMDAs and private sector actors to sustain urban green infrastructure.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry should support the DPG to expand its IGF base through horticultural services while safeguarding public access to parks;
- Adequate Goods and Services and CapEx allocations should be ensured to maintain existing green spaces and develop new ones;
- MMDAs should be encouraged to integrate Parks and Gardens units into their development plans and budgets, with DPG providing technical leadership.

Environmental Health and Sanitation Directorate (EHSD)

The Committee notes the positive impact of National Sanitation Day and the introduction of school-based source segregation under the GARID Project. However:

- Sanitation enforcement and public compliance remain uneven across districts;
- There are inadequate environmental health staff and logistics in many MMDAs;
- The scaling up of CLTS, MBS and household toilet interventions requires sustained funding and coordination.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry strengthens the sanitation directorate at the local level by increasing staffing and logistics for Environmental Health Officers;
- National Sanitation Day be institutionalised and linked to performance assessment of MMDAs;
- Funding for CLTS, MBS and household toilet programmes be prioritised in collaboration with the Ministry of Sanitation and Water Resources and Development Partners.

Births and Deaths Registry (BDR)

The Committee notes that although there were improvements in 2025:

- Birth registration coverage stood at 54per cent, and death registration at 29.2per cent, both short of universal coverage targets;

- The Registry faces logistical, staffing and infrastructure constraints, especially at district level;
- The ongoing implementation of Act 1027 and the Vital Statistics Strategic Plan (2025–2030) requires sustained investment.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry expands the network of registration centres, particularly in underserved rural areas;
- The Registry be provided with adequate ICT infrastructure to roll out the electronic Births and Deaths Registration System nationwide;
- Stronger collaboration be fostered between the BDR, Ghana Health Service and the National Identification Authority to ensure integrated identity and vital statistics systems.

Land Use and Spatial Planning Authority (LUSPA)

The Committee observed that LUSPA is central to the regulation of the built environment and spatial development, yet:

- It operates under resource constraints and relies heavily on a small central team;
- Complete implementation of the Land Use and Spatial Planning

Development Fund (LUSPDF) and associated legal instruments is still pending.

- Many MMDAs lack the tools and capacity to enforce spatial plans and building regulations.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry fast-tracks the amendment of Act 925 and the operationalisation of the LUSPDF;
- LUSPA be supported with CapEx and technical logistics (survey equipment, GIS tools) to implement its mandate;
- Capacity-building programmes be scaled up for Spatial Planning Committees, Technical Sub-Committees and Physical Planning Departments across all MMDAs.

Department of Community Development (DoCD)

The Committee acknowledges the role of the DoCD in community mobilisation, skills development and local economic development, but notes that:

- The Department is under-resourced relative to its mandate;
- Many community development centres require rehabilitation;
- There is high demand for community-based training, especially for women and youth.

The Committee recommends that:

- Adequate funding be provided to DoCD for community training programmes and centre rehabilitation;
- DoCD be more closely integrated into MMDA Local Economic Development (LED) strategies;
- Partnerships with NGOs, CBOs and faith-based organisations be encouraged to expand community development outreach.

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs

The Committee notes that:

- The Ministry has made progress in engaging Traditional and Religious Authorities, including providing support for festivals and mediation processes;
- There remain logistical gaps and capacity constraints in the Houses of Chiefs and Traditional Councils;
- Several Legislative Instruments (LIs) concerning succession to stools and skins, as well as the composition of Regional Houses of Chiefs, remain at various stages of processing.

The Committee recommends that:

- The Ministry prioritises the inauguration and upgrading of no fewer than ten (10) Traditional Areas to Council status as planned.

- Adequate logistics and training be provided to Judicial Committees and newly established Traditional Councils to strengthen chieftaincy adjudication and governance;
- The Ministry, in collaboration with the Attorney-General's Department, expedites the finalisation and laying of the seventeen (17) draft Chieftaincy LIs, including amendments to L.I. 2409, to provide legal clarity and reduce disputes;
- Engagement with religious bodies be deepened to promote peace, tolerance and social cohesion, especially in areas prone to conflict.

Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs Programme and Activities for 2025

Inauguration of Traditional Councils

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs trained members of the newly inaugurated Teshie and Zuarugu Traditional Councils as well as train them on the legal and institutional framework governing Traditional Councils in a bid to strengthen institutional leadership capacity.

Construction of Office complexes for the Houses of Chiefs in the six newly created Regions,

The Ministry of Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs in the year 2025 continued the construction of Regional Houses of Chiefs' office complexes for the newly created six regions in the

Northeast: Savannah, Oti, Western North, Ahafo, and Bono East. The Committee was informed that construction works are progressing steadily.

Strategic Partnerships

The Ministry engaged with religious and traditional leaders to foster strong partnerships and leverage their influence for positive socio-cultural outcomes. This included the Paramount Chiefs of Yilo Krobo, Twifu, and Hemang, as well as delegations from the Kwahu Traditional Area, La Traditional Area, Nungua Traditional Council, Ga Dangbe Wulomei, the Royal House Chapel International, Catholic Church, Presbyterian Church of Ghana, Seventh Day Adventist Church and Apostolic Faith Mission Church among others.

The Ministry, in its quest to reinforce the unique relationship with Traditional and Religious authorities, took part in festivals, celebrations, and anniversaries. The Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs directorate further extended technical and financial support for the organisation of the National Day of Prayer and Thanksgiving, as well as the organisation of the 2025 Eid al-Fitr and Eid al-Adha celebrations in the Muslim Community.

Legislative Review

In order to improve laws governing Chieftaincy, an internal Committee was constituted in 2025 to review the Chieftaincy Act, 2008 (Act 759), Constitutional Instrument (CI 27) and Legislative Instruments (LI 798) to align

some legislative gaps with current trends governing the Chieftaincy Institution.

Capacity Building

The Ministry in collaboration with the United Nations Population Fund (UNFPA), initiated a dissemination workshop for the National House of Chiefs and traditional council registrars; aimed at reducing the incidence of child marriage, sexual and gender-based violence within traditional areas. Further to was a declaration by two paramountcies to end child marriage in the Navrongo and Anum traditional areas.

Again, capacity building workshops were held for the Volta Regional House of Chiefs, counsel of the various Houses of Chiefs, members of the Teshie and Zuarungu Traditional Councils on Chieftaincy, Judicial and Administrative processes to equip them in their adjudication activities in 2025.

Dispute Resolution

On matters relating to conflict resolution, aimed at promoting peace and stability for national development, the Directorate together with the National House of Chiefs were able to settle sixty-four (64) chieftaincy disputes out of five hundred and twenty-three (523) cases in 2025, through judicial committees at the National, Regional, and Traditional Council levels.

Outlook for the Ensuing Year (2026)

The Department intends to undertake the following activities in the ensuing year to realize its objectives:

- Continue the construction of Office complexes for the Houses of Chiefs in the six newly created Regions in the Northeast: Savannah, Oti, Western North, Ahafo, and Bono East;
- Training workshops for newly inaugurated Traditional Council members in the Ashanti and Bono East.
- Inaugurate and upgrade Ten (10) Traditional areas to Council status and further conduct training and provide logistics for members of the newly inaugurated Traditional Council in the Ashanti and Bono East regions, for the effective and efficient operations of the Councils.
- In 2026, Capacity building will be provided for Registrars at the various Houses of Chiefs, as well as Counsel of the various Regional Houses.
- The Ministry will continue to review the Chieftaincy legal instruments, focusing on facilitating the passage of seventeen (17) draft Legislative Instruments related to the Succession to Stools and Skins, and an amendment to the Chieftaincy Membership of Regional Houses of Chiefs Instrument, LI 2409 of 2020
- To foster stronger bonds among Christian Ecumenical bodies, the Ministry intends to collaborate

with religious organisations to hold the second edition of the National Day of Prayer and Thanksgiving in 2026.

- The Ministry plans to advance the finalization and submission of the proposed national policy on Religion to Cabinet for approval.
- In 2026, the Ministry intends to reinforce the Muslim Ummah, promote religious co-existence and further continue to provide support and technical assistance to faith-based organisations and other stakeholders in advocating for interfaith and intra-faith harmony to promote religious tolerance.
- In 2026 the Ministry will advance the development of a local religious pilgrimage and establish a database of religious bodies.
- The Ministry intends to strengthen partnerships with Traditional Councils, faith-based organizations, and peace-building organisations to enhance harmony and development.

Key Priority Areas

The Ministry, in the year 2026, intends to undertake the following key priority activities:

- Speedy adjudication of Chieftaincy cases pending before the National and Regional Houses of Chiefs, Traditional and Divisional Councils.

- Payment of Monthly allowance to Traditional Authorities.
- Completion of the Regional Houses of Chiefs in the six newly created Regions.
- 2nd Edition of the National Prayer Day to foster Religious tolerance and social cohesion.
- Finalization of the proposed National Policy on Religion

Key Challenges

The Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs Directorate of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs, in the year under review, faced a number of challenges which include:

- Inadequate office personnel
- Outmoded legal provisions on adjudication of chieftaincy disputes.
- Inadequate office equipment and logistics for effective service delivery.
- Delay in the approval of commitment authorization
- Inadequate office accommodation
- Inadequate involvement of traditional and religious authorities in national development.

- Lack of sustainable financing scheme for Chieftaincy
- Regulatory deficiencies in Religious space

Budgetary Allocation for the year 2026

To implement its programmes and activities for the year 2026, a total amount of Thirty-two Million Three Hundred and Fifty-one Thousand, Seven Hundred and Eighty-eight Ghana Cedis (GH¢32,351,788.00) has been allocated to the Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs Programme area. The breakdown of the allocation by economic classification is provided as follows:

Table 3: 2026 Budgetary Allocation for the Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs

(All figures in Ghana Cedis – GH¢)

Economic Classification	Funding Sources				
Item	GOG (GH¢)	IGF (GH¢)	Donor (GH¢)	Total (GH¢)	%
Compensation	-	-	-	-	-
Goods and services	12,351,788.00	-	-	12,351,788.00	38.18
Capex	20,000,000.00	-	-	20,000,000.00	61.82
Total	32,351,788.00	-	-	32,351,788.00	100
%	100				

Source: 2026 Budget Statement/Committee Presentation

Observations

Inadequate Funding and Logistics

The Committee observed that a total amount of Thirty-two Million, Three Hundred and Fifty-One Thousand, Seven Hundred and Eighty-eight Ghana Cedis. (GH¢32,351,788.00) allocated to the Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs sector for the implementation of its programmes is woefully inadequate.

An amount of Twenty Million Ghana Cedis (GH¢20,000,000.00), representing 61.82 per cent of the total budget for the Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs Directorate is expected to cater to infrastructure development, modernization of chieftaincy institutions and other long-term investments.

Goods and Services would account for the remaining Twelve Million, Three Hundred and Fifty-one Thousand, Seven Hundred and Eighty-Eight (GH¢12,351,788.00), making up 38.18 per cent of the total allocation.

Delay in the Adjudication of chieftaincy dispute cases

The Committee noted with concern the huge backlog of Chieftaincy related cases pending before the National and Regional Houses of Chiefs. In the year 2025, the National and Regional Houses of Chiefs only managed to settle sixty-four (64) chieftaincy disputes out of the five Hundred and twenty-three (523) cases pending before it, representing 12 per cent of cases adjudicated by the National House and Regional Houses of Chiefs.

The Committee noted that the delay in release of funds for the necessary logistics, training, advisory services and incentive packages are partly attributable to the inability of National and Regional Houses of Chiefs to adjudicate on matters expeditiously in conflict prone areas that leads to economic disruption, widespread violence and loss of lives.

The Committee therefore urge the Ministry of Finance to release funds timeously to minimize chieftaincy related conflicts and further curb the incessant outbreak of violence, chieftaincy disputes and clashes across the country.

Formal Assignment of Roles to Chiefs

The Committee highlighted the continued dependence on chiefs for various national and community engagements and stressed the need to formally assign specific roles to chiefs

within the governance structure. Such formal assignments would justify enhanced budgetary allocations and provide a structured framework for the involvement of chiefs in national development efforts.

Delay in the processing of commitment authorization from the Ministry of Finance.

The committee expressed concern on the bureaucratic channels and cumbersome procedure the Chieftaincy and Religious Directorate of the Ministry has to undergo in securing commitment authorization to support operational activities such as dispute resolution processes, monitoring of religious bodies, traditional, council engagements, administrative expenses among others.

In the view of the Committee, the cumbersome procedure in securing commitment authorization poses a challenge for the Directorate to access its funds. The Committee propose that the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs and the Ministry of Finance engage and agree on the best way to harmonize the bottlenecks associated in accessing funds for the activities on the Directorate.

Conclusion

The Committee recommends that the Directorate of Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs be well resourced to continue to invest in essential services that promote social harmony, cultural preservation,

and effective governance within the chieftaincy and Religious Sector.

In view of the above, the Committee recommends that the House adopts its report and approve the sum of Thirty-two Million, Three Hundred and Fifty-One Thousand, Seven Hundred and Eighty-eight Ghana Cedis (GH¢32,351,788.00) to enable the Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs Directorate of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to implement its programmes and activities for the 2026 financial year.

Sanitation Programmes and Activities for 2025 Solid Waste Management

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs achieved the following under solid waste management:

- Technical evaluation of bids completed
- Construction of Koforidua IRECOP is 85 per cent complete. Construction of Agomeda IRECOP is 35 per cent complete.
- School source segregation pilot initiated in 15 schools within the Greater Accra Region under the GARID Project
- Baseline study completed

Liquid Waste Management

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs achieved the following under liquid waste management:

- Construction/rehabilitation of wastewater treatment facilities at 74 per cent completion
- Pilot of the decentralized Plans for ending open defecation and achieving safely managed sanitation initiated in three districts

Environmental Health and Management

The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs achieved the following under liquid waste management:

- National Sanitation Day launched and formally re-introduced by H.E. John Dramani Mahama on 6th September, 2025
- Construction of 1No. 500-capacity dining hall at Ho School of hygiene completed and in use
- Construction of 1No. 3-storey school block at Accra School of hygiene Phase 1 is completed with phases 2 and 3 pending

Outlook for the Ensuing Year (2026)

The Department intends to undertake the following activities in the ensuing year to realize its objectives:

Solid Waste

- Undertake feasibility studies and development of integrated solid waste management masterplans for 5 coastal cities in Ghana

- Develop a national roadmap and strategy for sustainable management of end-of-life textiles in Ghana
- Facilitate the roll-out of source segregation programs in households and institutions
- Facilitate the integration of informal waste service providers in inclusive MMDA franchise agreements
- Undertake construction of waste transfer station at GAEC
- Undertake construction of engineered landfill at Ayidan

Liquid Waste Management

- Undertake the construction of sustainable faecal sludge management infrastructure in selected urban centres in Ghana
- Facilitate sewer rehabilitation, sewer network densification and increasing household connections to sewer network in selected cities
- Facilitate the implementation of the revised RSMS and National ODF Plan
- Operationalize the National Sanitation Fund
- Secure US\$30 million additional financing for the rehabilitation and expansion of Asafo Sewerage System under the GAMA/GKMA Sanitation and Water Project

Environmental Health and Management:

- Undertake dissemination of revised ESP, NESSAP, SESIP and National Hand Hygiene Strategy
- Undertake the nationwide implementation of the National Sanitation Day
- Facilitate national sanitation and hygiene BCC campaigns and enforcement of sanitation by-laws
- Facilitate the establishment of Waste Management Departments in all MMDAs
- Facilitate the training of Environmental Health Officers, tutors and students of Schools of Hygiene on environmental sanitation M&E tools
- Facilitate the establishment and operationalisation of Regional and District Sanitation Task Forces.

Key Priority Areas

The Ministry, in the year 2026, intends to undertake the following key priority activities:

- Sustain the nationwide implementation of National Sanitation Day.
- Scale up source segregation programmes to institutions nationwide.

- Promote Community-Led Total Sanitation (CLTS), Market-Based Sanitation (MBS) and household toilet programmes to maintain Open Defecation Free (ODF) achievements.
- Complete administrative blocks and residential facilities for RCCs and decentralised departments in the newly created regions, as well as for Regional Police Commands and their Deputies.

Budgetary Allocation for the year 2026

To implement its programmes and activities for the year 2026, a total amount of nine million three hundred and sixty-nine thousand, one hundred and six Ghana cedis (GHC9,369,106.00) has been allocated to the Sanitation Programme area. The breakdown of the allocation by economic classification is provided as follows:

Table 3: 2026 Budgetary Allocation for Sanitation
(All figures in Ghana Cedis – GHC)

Economic Classification	Funding Sources				
Item	GOG (GHC)	IGF (GHC)	Donor (GHC)	Total (GHC)	%
Compensation	-	-	-	-	-
Goods and services	1,869,106.00	-	-	1,869,106.00	19.95
Capex	7,500,000.00	-	-	7,500,000.00	80.05
Total	9,369,106.00	-	-	9,369,106.00	100
%	100				

Source: 2026 Budget Statement/Committee Presentation

Observations

Impact of Sanitation Day

The Committee notes the positive impact of National Sanitation Day and the introduction of school-based source segregation under the GARID Project. However, the Committee expressed concern that the Sanitation enforcement and public compliance remain uneven across district, and recommended that the National Sanitation Day be institu-

tionalised and linked to performance assessment of MMDAs.

Health Staff and Logistics

The Committee observed that there are inadequate environmental health staff and logistics in many MMDAs making the execution of planned environmental and health programmes a daunting tasks for the assemblies. The Committee recommended, therefore,

that the Ministry strengthens the sanitation directorate at the local level by increasing staffing and logistics for Environmental Health Officers;

Household Toilet Interventions

The Committee observed that the scaling up of CLTS, MBS and household toilet interventions requires sustained funding and coordination, and recommended that funding for CLTS, MBS and household toilet programmes be prioritised in collaboration with the Ministry of Sanitation and Water Resources and Development Partners.

Conclusion

The Committee recommends that the Directorate of Sanitation be well resourced to effectively carry out its environmental sanitation and health programmes.

In view of the above, the Committee recommends that the House adopts its report and approve the sum of Nine Million Three Hundred and Sixty-Nine Thousand, One Hundred and Six Ghana Cedis (GHC9,369,106.00) to enable the Sanitation Directorate of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to implement its programmes and activities for the 2026 financial year.

Overall Recommendation

Subject to the observations and recommendations outlined above, the Committee recommends to the House to adopt this Report and to approve the sum

of Four Billion, Seven Hundred and Ninety-Three Million, One Hundred and Thirty-Nine Thousand, and Seventy-One Ghana Cedis (GHC4,793,139,071.00) for the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the 2026 Financial Year.

Respectfully submitted

Question Proposed.

Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye — *rose* —

Majority Chief Whip (Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamekpor): Mr Speaker, we just want to agree on the number of contributors.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, I will do two on each Side and Leadership, please.

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, the Ministry is more or less a combination of three key sectors, Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs. Let us do three each and the Leadership making four. It is very important. Look at the report.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is that Ministry also taking care of our District Assemblies Common Fund?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Yes, they take care of the District Assemblies Common Fund too.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: All right. Three each, but please be snappy.

Mr Francis Asenso-Boakye (NPP — Bantama): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion for the approval of the 2026 Budget Estimates for the Ministry under review of an amount of GH¢4,793,139,071.00.

Right from the outset, I would like to commend the Hon Minister, his Deputy, the officials of the Ministry and the agencies for their cooperation shown during the Committee's deliberations. Mr Speaker, the Report before us is a reflection of both some commendable progress and also some persistent challenges within the sector. The Ministry recorded some achievement in the year 2025, including upgrading of the District's Development Data Platform and the DP80 portal to strengthen data-driven planning. Planning is science and data is needed for evidence-based development planning.

Mr Speaker, another progress worthy of note is the National Decentralisation Policy, which is on course, and also the payment of allowance to district assemblies' elected officials. Also, I note from the Report that we have some improvements in horticultural training and urban beautification through the Department of Parks and Gardens. Mr Speaker, these outcomes demonstrate that when resources, flow and systems operate efficiently, the Ministry delivers results that impact citizens at the local level.

The Committee also identified significant challenges that threatens the effectiveness of decentralisation. Firstly, there is budget imbalance. It is striking to

note that compensation alone absorbs 65 per cent of the total allocation, leaving limited resources for Goods and Services, and even more importantly, Capital Expenditure. This means that we are just pay salaries, but under-resource the very institutions expected to deliver services. That is why we are facing various challenges at the district assembly. I always use the opportunity to talk about flooding. It is because the institutions at the district level who are supposed to perform their duties to ensure that they issue permits where there should be development and all that, do not have the resources to do their work.

Another important bottleneck or setback is the delays and shortfalls in releases. The Committee experienced significant gaps between approved budgets and actual releases, especially for CAPEX. This phenomenon has delayed key projects such as the Regional Coordinating Council offices, staff bungalows, and special planning facilities.

We also experienced lack of essential technical staff at the District Assemblies. For District Assemblies to effectively perform their duties, they require that they have staffed with the right quality human resources, such as engineers, planners, architects, and all other development professionals. But unfortunately, when you go to the assemblies, the story is different. One of the key reasons they find it very difficult, Mr Speaker, to attract this quality human resource is lack of accommodation, a place for them to lay their bed after a hard day's work.

4:24 p.m.

That is why I am excited to hear that this Government is continuing the district housing scheme initiative of the former administration, so that there will be enough accommodation at the district level. I had the opportunity to talk about this during the Mid-Year Budget Review. The Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs indicated that he plans to coordinate with the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Works, Housing and Water Resources to expedite this process of providing housing for our district assembly officials.

Even more important is the creeping centralisation going on at the district level. During the debate on the Budget Statement and Economic Policy, I had the opportunity to talk about it. The whole business of decentralisation is to allow local government officials, who are the main targets of decentralisation, to take their own decisions, identify their own priorities, and help in the planning of their communities. But lately, what we experience is official central government control of resources that belong to the district. They tell them to use this percentage for this and that. When operational guidelines and project choices are detected from the centre through decentralisation, they get lost. Assemblies cannot be accountable to their people if they lack discretion and timely resources.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, please we have so many—

Mr Asenso-Boakye: We do not have time and we want the Ranking Member to comment? These are very important issues that I have to bring to the fore. If they have decided to go on the path of decentralisation, but the people do not have power to be part of the decentralisation, there is a problem.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I appreciate it, but try to summarise it.

Mr Asenso-Boakye: In conclusion, the Committee made some recommendations. One is rebalancing the budget to strengthen goods and services and CAPEX, and also improving predictability of releases, especially for critical service areas. Mr Speaker, the Ministry remains central to inclusive development, chieftaincy governance, and effective local service delivery.

While estimates have strengths, the issues of centralisation and resource imbalance must be addressed. Subject to the Committee's observations and recommendations, I support the approval of GH¢4,793,139,071,000 for the financial year 2026.

Dr Fred Kyei Asamoah (NPP — Offinso North): I rise to contribute to the Motion for the House to approve the sum of GH¢4,793,139,071 for the services of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the year ending 31st December, 2026. Mr Speaker, as we commend the Ministry for some work done, there is so much to be desired, done and completed as well.

It would interest the House to know that the 2026 budget of the Ministry has allocated just 2.43 per cent for the entire institution of chieftaincy and religious affairs. Probably, that is why the Minister was being heckled when his name was mentioned. The Minister is committing 2 per cent of the entire budget of the Ministry for such an institution as chieftaincy, where we have people like his Royal Majesty Otumfuo Nana Osei Tutu II, the Asantehene, contributing to resolve disputes. If we look at the budget and the performance, the Ministry was able to settle just 12 per cent of the chieftaincy disputes it is being faced with.

If we look at the percentage release of goods and services and CAPEX for 2025, it is just 11 per cent for the Ministry as far as chieftaincy is concerned. It will interest the House to know that the NPP Administration started the construction of building for the Regional House of Chiefs in the six newly created regions. They committed GH¢20 million to continue the work of the NPP Administration, but not even a cedi has been contributed to the completion of these buildings. They have to put their mouth where their money is.

If we look at how much this country is committing to resolve conflicts as a result of unresolved chieftaincy issues, the Ministry was even supposed to bring to this House an amendment of the Chieftaincy Act, 2008 (Act 759). There is also outstanding legislative instrument that was supposed to be brought to the House. Unfortunately, none of these were done.

The 2.43 per cent of the Ministry's budget that I am talking about includes GH¢84 million for compensation. So, if we look at the logistics, goods and services and CAPEX that our chieftaincy institution needs to resolve the issues and the codification of our chieftaincy succession plan, unfortunately, there is no evidence from this budget that there is going to be enough or something done for the Minister to resolve the issues. We have not even gone to the religious issues, because maybe the Minister needs a lot of prayers to survive.

So, Mr Speaker, we want to entreat the Ministry of Finance to reallocate some additional funds. If they cannot do it now, they should do it during the Mid-Year Budget Review, so that we can improve on our chieftaincy and religious institutions. They have a lot of formal roles they can play. In this, we are recommending that the Ministry will improve on the funding and logistics support for the chieftaincy, and also improve on the chieftaincy disputes that we need to resolve. With these few words, Mr Speaker, I support the Motion.

Mr Charles Akwasi Agbeve (NDC — Agotime-Ziope): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I also rise to ask this House to approve the budget of the Ministry.

An important agency of the Ministry, that is the Births and Deaths Registry, is to help us register births and deaths of this country. The Ministry needs support to get them to do this exercise effectively. There are some regions or

districts that do not have any birth or death registration officer. So, one wonders what happens to the registration of these important new births and deaths to this country.

There is a lot of pressure on MPs today. With these new recruitments going on, we are all virtually paying to get them birth certificates now. All of them are rushing to Accra because of the absence of these officers in their districts. So, I encourage the Ministry of Finance to look at this particular agency carefully under the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. In fact, they need a lot of logistics.

4:34 p.m.

Another important agency that needs to be helped to get the Minister to do his work very well is the Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs); the RCCs lack vehicles. Some of the regions of the Regional Ministers are vast; they cannot cut across. Therefore, the Minister for Finance should help the Ministry to get these RCCs to renovate their bungalows and get vehicles to be able to do efficient monitoring of the district assemblies, who we are giving huge sums of money to implement government policy. If they are not able to go around to monitor and evaluate what they are doing, it would not help us well.

Finally, Mr Speaker, I also want to plead that the Ministry looks at the Land Use and Spatial Planning Authority. This important Authority, formerly known as Town and Country Planning, also needs resources. They would help us plan well.

But they lack personnel at the district levels. That is why planning at the district level is becoming a challenge. Therefore, if they are also resourced, they would go a long way to help the Minister plan our urban areas and districts carefully.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, I also add my voice that the House approves of GH¢4,793,139,071.00 for the Ministry.

I thank you.

Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib (NPP — Weija-Gbawe): Mr Speaker, I thank you for this opportunity. I am alarmed at the rate of releases being made by the Ministry of Finance to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy, and Religious Affairs. I actually sat somewhere quietly and asked myself, if the Hon Minister is planning to contest the presidential election, or is he stepping on the toes of some people? Because it is as if they want to run the Ministry moribund.

Mr Speaker, this is a rhetorical question. Let us do the 2025 reality check. When you examine what was allocated in 2025, it was GH¢4.4 billion. That was what was approved. Let us see what was released: GH¢2 million. What is happening? In the Report, they had almost a billion and over, which was not released to the Ministry in 2025. This is a Ministry that is dealing with other respective institutions, chieftaincy, and religion.

Mr Speaker, let us even ask if Hajj is under the Ministry? They are not doing

anything with Hajj because it is not under the Ministry. When it comes to traditional authorities, we know that they have been dealing with critical conflict issues. The current one is the Bawku issue. I do not think that the Minister sitting there has any sums of money to deal with any of these issues involving chieftaincy.

Mr Speaker, let me come to the critical question. We were in this Chamber when the Minister came in his red tie and said he was going to pay assemblies allowances. He indicated he was going to give them GHC100 million. Mr Speaker, do you know how much they have received? An amount of GHC25 million. *Na GHC 75 million ewo he; sika no wo he. Shikaa egbɛ eyɔɔ*. To wit: where is the GHC75 million for the assembly members? What you say is what you do. Do not come and promise us and say it is better. Mr Speaker, it has become the normal setting that we come and promise and run away. We do not do anything.

Mr Speaker, you would realise that Compensation alone is taking close to 65 per cent and 19 per cent of the amount for Goods and Services for the Ministry. Mr Speaker, do you know what the 19 per cent means? It means that they do not even have the capacity to run operations. Deputy Minister for Finance, please, I need your attention on this matter. You are giving 19 per cent to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for Goods and Services. That 19 per cent means that they cannot run operations. That is why you have about GHC88 million sitting there.

Mr Speaker, come with me, and I would show you that they had GHC88 million for Capital Expenditure (CAPEX), which I call the capital expenditure scandal. An amount of GHC88 million is sitting in there, but they could not even access that money. Why? Because they have not given them the wherewithal to run the operations of the Ministry. This is a major problem.

Now, they come here and ask us to still approve of some money. When we even approve, they come back and do not release the money. Majority Leader, they are not releasing their money to the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs.

Mr Speaker, let me round up. This is critical. I am a Member of this Committee, and these are issues bothering us. If you go to the Local Government Service, close to 7,000 people lost their jobs, and there is a gap. So, when you go to the district assemblies or municipal assemblies, or metropolitan assemblies, they do not have the technical men to run the activities for the Local Government Service. What they do is that they only sit there and watch. They only have staff who are sitting in the offices. They do not have the real technical people, planners, and engineers. They are not available. This is a situation we need to consider and have an amendment to.

Mr Speaker, the last one for me. In 2025, they came to this House, and made this promise that we are going to have a Royal Academy of Chiefs and Traditional Authorities (RACTA). And

that they were also going to pass the University of Local Governance Bill to elevate the institute of local government institutions. Mr Speaker, they have not done that for a year now. It is gone. As I speak with you, we do not know the situation and the position of the District Road Improvement Programme (DRIP); we do not know the situation on sanitation, a lot of sanitation workers are not being paid. They have not been paid for close to nine months. Mr Speaker, this is a problem. The Minister for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs is there, and his hands have been tied behind his back. There is nothing going on for him. Yet, we are calling *mensuro. osuro*.

Mr Speaker, thank you for this opportunity.

Mr Fred K. Agbenyo (NDC — Guan): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to the Reports on the Committee on Local Government and Rural Development. Mr Speaker, let me start by commending the sector Minister and the agencies under the Ministry that, indeed, they are doing a good work, except that the logistics and resources needed to function effectively are a major problem.

4:44 p.m.

Mr Speaker, when we go to most of the institutions, they are simply understaffed. The personnel that they need to be able to do their work are simply not available. The majority of them have indicated that they have

applied to the Ministry of Finance for clearance so they can employ more people to help in their work. Unfortunately, they have not received that clearance. We want to call on this House to appeal to the appropriate authorities to release their necessary funds for them so they can employ more people to work at the districts.

Mr Speaker, we all know the role that the Chieftaincy Institution plays in our country and we all know that wherever there are wars, there are conflicts and misunderstandings in this country, it is largely traced to the institution of chieftaincy. We are sad to note that barely 12 per cent of the many chieftaincy cases that came before the Ministry was addressed in the whole year. There are issues in almost every region of this country. And when we ask them, they say that the money that would be paid to them as allowances for sitting on the cases is not available and that is why some of these cases are still pending. It is important that we release whatever funds that are necessary to these institutions so that they can sit down and resolve all the conflicts that we have in the area.

Mr Speaker, one other area that is of major concern to me is the Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs). It is true that the RCCs themselves do not have any means of generating their own funding. If we go to almost all the districts today, most of the RCCs depend on the assemblies. Anytime they want to organise a programme, they call on the assemblies to contribute some moneys before they are able to organise their

programmes. Have we not come to that time where we can encourage the RCCs to generate their own fund or their own source of fund so that they stop depending on the little money that the assemblies are generating?

Mr Speaker, one other thing that is worrying to me is that if we check across the country, it does appear that districts that are not generating enough money are the districts that we allocate less District Assemblies Common Funds and those that are generating enough IGF, we still allocate them more money. And I do not understand how we intend to bridge the equity. The understanding should have been that those who are not generating enough IGF should be given enough Common Funds so they can do their development.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: That is also to encourage them to generate more IGF.

Mr Agbenyo: But Mr Speaker, in my Constituency, for example, the Guan District, as we speak, do not have any market. We do not have any business so there is nothing that we can really do to generate the money. So apart from the Common Fund coming in so that we can sell our businesses, how do we generate money?

Mr Speaker, allow me to conclude by calling on this House to approve the budgets that are allocated to the Ministry for its work.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leadership?

Minority Chief Whip (Mr Frank Annoh-Dompreh): Mr Speaker, I rise, certainly, to speak in support of the Motion for the approval of the sum of money advertised in lieu of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. Many of our Colleagues have spoken and lamented enough. I intend to be brief.

Mr Speaker, I recall vividly how passionate the Hon Ahmed Ibrahim was — I think this was his seat. In his other world, he sat on this seat. The many occasions that he stood to fight for releases to this particular Ministry. I am saddened, having gone through the Report, I do not need to be repetitive. If we look at the variance for 2025, over GH¢1.4 billion. Why? What is critical is that sanitation service providers have not been paid the whole of this year. None of them has been paid. The company that is responsible for treating a whole liquid waste generated by Parliament, has not been paid for the whole year.

Mr Speaker, any time we have budget estimates and we are considering the passage of Motions, we often, narrow down on certain key areas, and, the Speaker, has often given some consequential directives. The fact that sanitation service providers are not being paid in this country cannot be treated as an ordinary matter. I know the Hon Majority Leader has been carried along and other Colleagues in Leadership have been told.

Mr Speaker, we will go ahead and approve this but I implore the Majority that there should be an extra engagement with the Minister for Finance. Our Colleague is here. All over the country, the service providers are not being paid for landfill sites, liquid waste generated and solid waste generated. I recall that in the last Parliament, a Bill was brought. I think we even got to, the First Reading and we were promised that it would be reintroduced in this Parliament. The Institute of Local Government Studies, a critical state institution, train all the staff of local government, MMDCEs, but check the releases to this Institution. It is pathetic. Yes, Hon Leader, it is very sad.

I do not know the sins of Mr Ahmed Ibrahim; I do not understand. What has he done? What is most ironic is that the Ministry has been expanded to include Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. The man is suffering, look at him. *[Laughter]* The man cannot go and meet the traditional leaders and the religious leaders. What are the sins of Hon Ahmed Ibrahim? I want to know. What has he done?

I have already intimated that earlier speakers have related to the same matter. So, agencies under the Ministry are all being crippled; the Department of Parks and Gardens, Births and Deaths Registry, and all other agencies. Mr Speaker, I would implore Colleagues to support the passage of the Motion. However, we have done it before; there should be a further engagement, especially on this matter. Mr Ampem should take his pen and take copious notes. Otherwise, we will not pass the

Appropriation. If they do not do something about the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious affairs the Appropriation will suffer. What has Hon Ahmed Ibrahim done? What are the sins of Hon Ahmed Ibrahim?

So, Mr Speaker, while I am calling for Members to support the passage of this Motion, I want to make a passionate appeal to you, that because sanitation has a lot of implications, it could lead to the unfortunate outbreak of epidemic. We should engage the Minister further and do some financial engineering to relieve our Colleague for once, because the situation is getting out of hand.

Having said this, I call on Members to support the passage of this Motion. I am sure the Deputy Minister for Finance wants to say something.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: He wants to say something about releases.

Mr Ampem: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I have listened to many of our Colleagues, especially those on the other Side, and one thing runs through all their submissions. They want more money for the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs to spend, and I welcome that idea. Being a former District Chief Executive (DCE), I appreciate local governance, and I accept that, except to let them appreciate also that we have done far better than previously.

Mr Speaker, 2023, the allocation to Local Government, Decentralisation and Rural Development was GH¢2,074,000,000. In 2024, it went to GH¢2.8 billion. In 2025, we increased it from GH¢2.8 billion to GH¢4 billion. This year's, 2026 Budget we have increased the allocation to GH¢4.7 billion.

Mr Ampem: That is two times more than what they were doing.

4:54 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, but what about the releases?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, for the releases this year, we have released more than GH¢2.5 billion to the Ministry of Local Government. That is more than their total allocation in 2023. So, inasmuch as I appreciate the call, I want them to also appreciate the fact that this is an improvement, even though it is not up to the level that we all want. This is a marked improvement over what has happened. So, we will take their admonition in good faith, but they should appreciate the fact that this is a vast improvement over previous years.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I earlier drew your attention that we are considering the estimates of the Ministry for Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. When did we ever hear thunder strike the way that it struck a moment ago? *[Laughter]* We have considered estimates for several days now, whose ministry did we consider the Estimates of and thunder struck? So, I

continue to urge and caution that in dealing with the Ministry of Religious Affairs, we should be very careful.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.
Resolved:*

That this honourable House approved the sum of GH¢4,793,139,071.00 for the services of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Now, we will move to the Motion numbered 27.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice has a lot of businesses to do; apart from the Motion, there are First Reading of Bills. Some of the other Ministers have their estimates ready, we can take them. The Minister for Foreign Affairs is here. If his own is ready, we can take it. I also saw the Minister for Education. We can take his too because the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice has a lot to do; he has to lay Papers, and we also have to take the Motion. There are about three Bills. So, let us take the Minister for Foreign Affairs and then we can move.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I will not respond, but the prayer is that the business of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice was truncated to prioritise that of the Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs. We have some other Businesses on the *Order Paper*

Addendum. So, after taking Motions numbered 27 and 28, we will take *Order Paper Addendum*, lay those Reports and then we will go back to Motion numbered 9.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I have been telling my good Friend to give me the Order of Business so that I can flow with him. He is my good Friend, but clearly, Mr Ablakwa is going to suffer the fate of Mr Ahmed. That is how it looks because I know the Minister for Foreign Affairs has a number of trips outside the jurisdiction. He is a senior Member of the House. The Deputy Attorney-General should wait; he is not a Member of Parliament. He should sit down and enjoy Parliament, and also learn how we move the Motions and all that. This is not the courthouse. Let us take Mr Ablakwa.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, by all means, we will take Motion numbered 17, so let us take Motion numbered 27, we will come back to take 17, then go back to take 28.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. I have already mentioned Motion numbered 27, so let us take it and then come back to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Please, I am in control, and I am saying that we would take 27; I am not changing it. So, Leader, I beg of you.

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we understand your directives, but what we are saying is that we should take Motion numbered 17, which is the Minister for Foreign Affairs and then come back to the Deputy Minister.

Mr Speaker, if we look at the organogram of government, the Minister for Foreign Affairs is a senior Minister. So why should we allow the Minister for Foreign Affairs to be seated while the Deputy Attorney-General takes his Motion? The Majority Leader always believes in hierarchy. Even in Parliament under Order 21, we go by the hierarchy. So, let us take Motion numbered 17, then we go to the Deputy Minister. One day, if he becomes a Minister, we will give him that respect, but for now, he is a Deputy Minister.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, personally, it has been a long time since I saw Mr Okudzeto; I want him to sit here a bit, so I can see him. Then, I will attend to him.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

LEGAL AID COMMISSION

Deputy Minister for Justice and Attorney-General (Dr Justice Srem-Sai): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢47,515,501.00 for the services of the Office of the Legal Aid Commission for the year ending 31st December 2026.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Shaibu Mahama): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion, and in so doing, present your Committee's Report. I urge the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as having been read.

5:04 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Commission is designed to support and provide legal services for the indigent. Mr Speaker, for many Ghanaians, access to legal aid services is a huge problem because of the cost of hiring lawyers. This office is a very important office, and the estimates of this office, over the years, have not seen very appreciable increase. While we recommended that in the Mid-Year Budget some provisions be made, additional provisions be made, especially for CAPEX, for the office. We also think that the office of the Legal Aid Commission still lacks certain basic amenities. We would recommend that the Legal Aid Commission be properly situated as a Commission that will provide the desired services that is needed for the indigent. We have designed a programme as part of the Report to visit the regional offices, to talk to the Regional Coordinating Councils (RCCs) to create some offices because most of the regions do not have legal aid offices. Because of that, they cannot access legal services.

Mr Speaker, one important innovation, we were told by the director, is that they are putting in place a 24-hour call system for everybody in this country. If a person has an issue, it does not matter which part of the country one finds themselves, they can call 24/7 to that office and then they will give you some advice. On that note, Mr Speaker, may I move to the concluding part and invite the *Hansard* to capture the Report as read.

Introduction

The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the year ending 31st December, 2026 was presented to Parliament by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Forson on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution.

Pursuant to Orders 194 and 238 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Budget Estimates of the Legal Aid Commission to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs for consideration and report to the Plenary.

Deliberations

The Committee met on Thursday, 27th November, 2025 and considered the 2026 Budget Estimates of the Office of Legal Aid Commission. Present at the meeting were the Executive Director of Legal Aid Commission, Mr Edmund Amarkwei Foley and other officers of the Commission.

The Committee is grateful to the officials for attending upon the Committee.

Reference Documents

- i. The 1992 Constitution;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Legal Aid Commission Act, 2018 (Act 977);

- iv. The 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of the Republic of Ghana;
- v. The Programme Based Budget Estimates for the Legal Aid Commission for the 2026 Financial Year;
- vi. The Report of the Committee on Constitutional, and Legal Affairs on the 2025 Budget Estimates of the Legal Aid Commission; and
- vii. 2026 Annual Budget Estimates Presentation of the Legal Aid Commission.

Goal of the Legal Aid Commission

To provide quality legal services to the poor and vulnerable in society and to bring justice to the doorstep of the people.

Vision of The Commission

To be the leading agency delivering professional and quality legal services to the poor while partnering harmoniously with stakeholders in the justice system to achieve a just and equitable Ghanaian society.

Mission of The Commission

To ensure equality of access to justice and treatment before the law by serving as a Public Defender for the poor in need of cost-effective justice; Establish sufficient presence in the districts to ensure legal aid is accessible to the

indigent in need of legal services. The above can be achieved by:

- a. Ensuring the availability of qualified, diligent and committed legal paralegal and alternative dispute resolution personnel to provide legal services to protect the interest and rights of the indigent;
- b. Developing an informed public with an increased understanding of the law and the legal services provided by the Commission; and
- c. Cooperating with local and international legal aid practitioners to learn and share similar experiences.

Core Functions of the Commission

The mandate of the Legal Aid Commission (LAC) as provided for in the Legal Aid Commission Act, 2018 (Act 977) are as follows:

- a. To provide legal aid to an indigent:
 - i. Through the representation of clients in court;
 - ii. Utilisation of Alternative Dispute Resolution mechanisms;
 - iii. By Legal Advice and Education; and
- b. To provide legal aid to a person who has reasonable grounds to take, defend, prosecute or be a party to proceedings related to the

Constitution in accordance with clause 1 of Article 294 of the Constitution.

Key Achievements of the Legal Aid Commission in 2025

Some of the achievements of the Commission in 2025 are as follows:

- i. Received a total of 3,467 cases;
- ii. Resolved 826 of the cases in various courts;
- iii. Received 5,651 cases regarding Alternative Dispute Resolution (ADR);
- iv. Provided legal advice in 69 cases;
- v. Resolved 2,986 of these ADR cases; and
- vi. Continued with its education and sensitisation programmes across various media and community platforms nationwide on the services they provide to the public.

A significant portion of the cases handled by the Commission consisted of

issues related to marriage, maintenance, divorce, as well as serious crimes such as manslaughter, murder, rape, and defilement, among others.

Expenditure Trends for the 2025 Financial Year

A total amount of Forty Million, Two Hundred and Sixty Thousand, Five Hundred and Twenty Ghana Cedis (GH¢40,260,520.00) was allocated for the activities of the Legal Aid Commission (LAC) for the year under review. This amount comprised an amount of GH¢30,751,455.00 for Compensation, GH¢4,165,246.00 for Goods and Services and GH¢5,343,819.00 for Capital Expenditure.

At the end of the 2025 financial year, an amount of Twenty-Three Million, Five Hundred and Forty-Four Thousand, Eight Hundred and Sixty-Two Ghana Cedis and Fourteen Pesewas (GH¢23,544,826.14) of the approved budget was expended by the LAC. Details of the releases and actual performance are shown in Table 1 below:

Table 1: Details of Releases of the 2025 Approved Budget of the LAC

CLASSIFICATION	2025 BUDGET APPROVED GH¢ (A)	TOTAL RELEASE GH¢ (B)	EXPENDITURE GH¢ (C)	VARIANCE 1 GH¢ D=(A-B)	% VARIANCE D=(A-B)/A*100
COMPENSATION OF EMPLOYEES	30,751,455.00	20,568,998.28	20,568,998.28	10,182,456.72	33.11
GOODS AND SERVICES	4,165,246.00	3,136,883.50	2,975,863.86	1,028,362.50	24.68
CAPEX	5,343,819.00	3,740,673.48	-	1,603,145.52	29.99
TOTAL	40,260,520.00	27,449,041.67	23,544,862.14	12,811,478.33	31.82

Outlook for 2026

The Legal Aid Commission in 2026, intends to undertake the following activities:

- i. Conduct research into barriers affecting legal aid delivery in 6 regions;
- ii. Capacity building of 191 legal and administrative staff;
- iii. Operationalise two (2) Regional offices and create three (3) new district offices to expand legal aid services to districts;
- iv. Conduct 450 sensitisation exercises as part of public sensitisation efforts;
- v. Renovate official buildings in five

(5) regions;

- vi. Run pilot case management system; and
- vii. Operationalise 24-Hour Call centre to ensure uninterrupted access to legal aid and justice, particularly for vulnerable groups.

Annual Budget Estimates of the Legal Aid Commission for the 2026 Financial Year

For the 2026 Financial year, the sum of Forty-Seven Million, Five Hundred and Fifteen Thousand, Five Hundred and One Ghana cedis (GH¢47,515,501.00) has been allocated to the LAC for its planned programmes. The details of the allocation are shown in the Table 2 below:

Table 2: Details of the Annual Budget Estimates of the LAC for the 2026 Financial Year

ECONOMIC CLASSIFICATION	ALLOCATION GH¢
Compensation	36,061,737.00
Goods and Services	6,006,550.00
IGF	103,395.00
Capex	5,343,819.00
Total	47,515,501.00

Source: 2026 Annual Budget Estimates Presentation of the Legal Aid Commission

Observations

Inadequate Funds

The Committee observed that, notwithstanding the Commission's commendable efforts to improve access to legal aid for the citizenry, its operations continue to be constrained by inadequate funding and delays in the timely disbursement of financial resources necessary for the effective execution of its constitutional mandate.

The Committee further noted that the Legal Aid Fund, which is a statutory fund established to facilitate legal aid delivery has been depleted. The Fund is used to remunerate pro bono/private legal practitioners who aid the Commission. This has resulted in payment arrears. The situation has significantly undermined the Commission's ability to operate optimally and fulfil its

obligations. The Commission informed the Committee that donor funds are used to support the Fund as and when they become available.

In view of the above, the Committee recommends that the Ministry of Finance enhances funding and prioritise the timely release of funds to the Legal Aid Commission to ensure continuity and efficiency in its service delivery. The Committee further urges the Ministry to institute measures to ensure adequate and sustainable funding of the Legal Aid Fund. This would help prevent future depletion and facilitate the timely payment of volunteers and private legal practitioners who support the Commission's work.

Insufficient Office Space

The Committee observed that the Commission lacks permanent office space for its Head Office. It was disclosed that although space has been allocated to the Commission within the Prosecutions Division of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice, the facility remains insufficient for its operational needs. The Commission further revealed that similar infrastructural challenges exist in offices in Koforidua, Cape Coast, Ho as well as in the Upper East, and Upper West Regions, where the current facilities are in a deplorable state and require urgent attention and renovation.

The Committee recommends Regional Coordinating Councils and district assemblies to aid in the provision of adequate office space to accommodate

staff of the Commission across the country. This would increase visibility and decentralize the work of the Commission in accordance with section 25 of the Legal Aid Commission Act, 2018 (Act 977). This provision requires that the Commission be supported to establish fully functional district offices. The Committee further recommends that funding be made available and released promptly by the Ministry of Finance for the renovation of existing regional office facilities to bring them up to acceptable standards for effective service delivery.

Staffing

The Committee was informed that the Commission received a total of 3,467 court-related cases during the period under review, of which only 826 were resolved. The Committee further noted that, despite the broad scope of the Commission's mandate, its operations are significantly constrained by inadequate human resources, which limit both its effectiveness and nationwide visibility. To address this gap, the Commission has requested financial clearance from the Ministry of Finance to recruit seventy (70) additional legal and administrative personnel to strengthen its staffing capacity.

The Committee recommends that the Ministry of Finance expedite the approval of the financial clearance and the release of funds to enable the timely recruitment of the requested personnel. The Committee further emphasizes the need for strategic human resource planning to reduce the high attrition and

retain the needed skills and experiences to augment Commission's work.

Operationalisation of 24-Hour Call Centre

The Commission informed the Committee of its plans to offer 24-hour legal services to improve access to legal aid and justice delivery particularly for vulnerable groups, in line with its constitutional mandate under Article 294 of the 1992 Constitution of Ghana and the Legal Aid Commission Act, 2018 (Act 977). This would be by the establishment of a 24-hour Legal Aid Call Centre.

The Committee noted that operationalising and implementing this initiative would enable the Commission to extend its services beyond conventional working hours. The Committee was of the view that this would help address existing service delivery gaps and align the Commission's operations with broader national policy objectives.

The Committee recommends that the Commission liaises with the Ministry of Justice and the Office of the Attorney-General to establish and implement the proposed 24-hour Legal Aid Call Centre. This in the Committee's view would improve accessibility and promote equity in justice delivery. The Committee further recommends that the requisite infrastructure including reliable telecommunications systems and trained personnel operating on rotational shifts be provided to ensure that the Centre functions efficiently.

Inadequate Training

The Commission informed the Committee that its staff require adequate training and capacity-building programmes to strengthen their skills, particularly in the management of complex issues that arise from legal disputes.

The Committee noted that sustained training interventions would significantly enhance the competence of staff and, by extension, improve the Commission's ability to meet the legal aid needs of the citizens.

In view of the above, the Committee recommends that the Commission continue to prioritise comprehensive training and capacity-building initiatives for its staff. The Committee further encourages the Commission to leverage both internal resources and external support to ensure that its staff remain adequately equipped to respond effectively to the changing legal landscape.

Lack of Office Logistics & Equipment

The Committee observed that the Commission continues to face significant logistical constraints, including inadequate office equipment. It was further observed that the absence of vehicles and motorcycles at the Head Office, as well as at its Regional and District Offices, impede effective service delivery and operational mobility.

Given the above, the Committee recommends that the Ministry of Finance

take the necessary actions to increase both the Goods and Services and Capital Expenditure (Capex) allocations of the Commission. The Committee was of the view that this would enable the Commission to procure the requisite office logistics, equipment, and vehicles needed to boost its operational efficiency and ensure accessible legal aid services to the citizenry.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee acknowledges the critical mandate of the Commission in ensuring access to justice for the poor and vulnerable, as well as its essential role in upholding the rule of law and promoting social equity. Despite these responsibilities, the Commission continues to face major challenges, particularly in the areas of human resources, logistics, and operational funding. The absence of a permanent office space, coupled with the lack of logistics and essential office equipment, continues to hinder the Commission's ability to deliver on its mandate. These constraints significantly undermine its capacity to provide timely, efficient, and quality legal services to vulnerable citizens across the country.

The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt this Report and approve the sum of Forty-Seven Million, Five Hundred and Fifteen Thousand, Five Hundred and One Ghana Cedis (GH¢47,515,501.00) for the activities of the Legal Aid Commission for the 2026 financial year.

Question proposed.

Mr Francis-Xavier Kojo Sosu (NDC — Madina): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion, which has been ably moved and seconded. Referring to the Committee's Report, you can see how the Legal Aid Commission is heavily under-resourced. Mr Speaker, I believe that as a nation, the vulnerable will always live with us. People will always need legal services they will not have money to be able to afford. That is why it is so critical that the Legal Aid Commission is properly resourced.

Mr Speaker, it is often said that the quality of a nation is determined by how they treat their most vulnerable people. So, all these people who are victims of crime who need support and do not get the adequate support as a result of the underfunding of the Commission calls for concern. When you read the entire Report: insufficient staff, insufficient funding, lack of training, lack of office spaces, it almost looks like everything as far as the legal aid is concerned is going to the negative.

I really pray that in the Mid-Year Budget, the Minister for Finance will consider to revise the budget of the Legal Aid Commission, properly resource it so that the most vulnerable people in our society will have access to justice. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity.

Mr Nana Agyei Baffour Awuah (NPP — Manhyia South): Mr Speaker, it is obvious that what has been given to the office is inadequate. Perhaps there is the need for a proper review of that office to ascertain the volume of work there so

that there can be commensurate allocation to the office. It is not called Aid for nothing. It is aid because it is support, it is help to the poor, and to the needy. It is important that we pay serious attention to the Legal Aid Commission. I know that when Mr Speaker was in private practice, He was not giving free legal services. People could not afford Mr Speaker's services — [**Mr Second Deputy Speaker:** Oh!]
— They could not have come to Mr Speaker. Very respectfully, we need to support the Legal Aid Commission so that people can have quality legal representation that Mr Speaker would have otherwise provided to people at a serious charge. Indeed, we need to take inspiration from Proverbs 19 vs 17, which says, "He that hath pity upon the poor lendeth unto the Lord, and that which he hath given, He will repay him again."

Mr Speaker, legal aid is kindness of the nation to the poor. So, we need to show mercy to the poor by supporting them. Mr Speaker, in your subsequent life when you are providing free legal services, consider the poor. Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Question put and motion agreed to.

Resolved:

That this honourable House approved the sum of GH¢47,515,501.00 for the services of the Office of the Legal Aid Commission for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we take the item numbered 28, then we take

item 17. The information is that my Chairperson for Foreign Affairs is in another meeting.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Member, if the Chairperson is not here, we can— Get in touch with the Chairperson.

Mr Rockson-Nelson Etse Kwami Dafeamkpor: Mr Speaker, with all due respect, the Hon Member sent word that I should stand this matter down, abiding his coming. He just came in. I just saw him walk in, so please he should not do that. I stood down the business to allow him to come. He sent an emissary to me.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Mr Speaker, this goes to personal integrity. I did not speak to the Majority Chief Whip. I do not have to speak to him. I spoke to the Minority Chief Whip. I was travelling to my Constituency today, and I can show you the tickets. I got indication from the Chairperson of the Committee that the Minister will be travelling tomorrow, and the Minister will be happy if we have a bipartisan support to the matters he is coming to put before Parliament. We spent a whole day with the Minister to deal with his Estimates, and important agreements. The Minister craved my indulgence and my Members to be here to give him bipartisan support because of the nature of the business we are going to conduct in this House. I cancelled my trip to be here. That is why I sent a message to the Minority Chief Whip that I am on my way. I have left the airport and come into the Chamber to support the Business of Government.

Mr Speaker, with the greatest respect to the Majority Chief Whip, I would please encourage him to withdraw what he said because, on the contrary, I am here to do national service, not that I was late to this House.

Thank you.

5:14 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: I did not say he was late, I said he sent word. This is because we had laid this Report and were ready to take it, then he sent word that he would be here so we should have it stood down. He is on his feet saying he has been here since 2:00 p.m. He should not do that.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Leader, please, let us move on.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we want to take the Motion numbered 28, and then we will take Motion numbered 17. My understanding is that it is agreed that the Vice Chairperson of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration will present their Report. That is fine. If it is acceptable to our Colleagues on the other Side, then we will do it. They do not like the deputies taking charge, but once they agree, the Vice-Chairperson will take it.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we should not raise the temperature unnecessarily. We have worked together since morning, so let us maintain the tempo. That is why I kept telling him that we all need to help. Since day one, I have given him my word that I will help him,

so he should give me the chronology. Mr Speaker, he is oscillating anyhow. After this Motion, we will come here. He told me that after that one we would do that of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs but now he has jumped to do another one. I do not mind; let us do whatever makes him happy. Mr Speaker, he says the Motion numbered 28. We will endure that so we can go ahead and do Motion numbered 28. So, it is the case that once we finish Motion numbered 28, we will do Motion numbered 17.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, please, let us remain on page 14, item listed 28, Motion by the Minister for Justice and Attorney-General.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Special Prosecutor's Report, firstly, is not on the console, and secondly, we do not have copies. That is a very sensitive office. In fact, if they can give us the Report, we will oblige and take it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leader, I am told it is on the console.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Well, I cannot find it. He should come and show us. If it is there, we can proceed. My Ranking Member does not have a copy. They should bring copies to us and we will abide by it.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Deputy Minister for Justice and Attorney-General, let us move on. I hope you are enjoying Parliament. It is part of the game.

Dr Justice Srem Sai: Mr Speaker, I am really enjoying the proceedings.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

OFFICE OF THE SPECIAL PROSECUTOR

Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Dr Justice Srem-Sai): Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢158,936,458.00 for the services of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Shaibu Mahama): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion for this honourable House to approve the sum of GH¢158,936,458 for the services of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the year ending 31st December 2026. Mr Speaker, in doing so, may I present a brief summary of your Committee's Report and I will urge the *Hansard* Department, to capture the entire Report as if it was read entirely.

Introduction

The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of Government for the 2026 Financial Year was presented on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, by the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, in accordance with Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution.

Pursuant to Orders 195(4) and 238 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker referred the Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the 2026 Financial Year to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs for consideration and Report.

Deliberations

The Committee met on Thursday, 27th November, 2025, and considered the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Special Prosecutor (OSP). Present at the meeting were the Special Prosecutor, Mr Kissi Agyabeng, the Director of Finance and other officials from the OSP as well as officials from the Ministry of Finance.

The Committee is grateful to the Special Prosecutor and his team and the officials from the Ministry of Finance for their assistance during the deliberations.

Reference Documents

In considering the Estimates, the Committee referred to the following documents:

- i. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
- ii. The Standing Orders of Parliament;
- iii. The Office of the Special Prosecutor Act, 2017 (Act 959);
- iv. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of the Republic of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year;

v. The Medium-Term Expenditure Framework for 2025-2028 of the Office of the Special Prosecutor; and

vi. The Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the 2025 Budget Estimates of the Office of the Special Prosecutor.

Mandate of the OSP

The OSP was established in 2018 as the gold standard and flagship specialised independent anti-corruption institution in Ghana with the object of investigating and prosecuting specific cases of alleged or suspected corruption and corruption-related offences in the public and private sectors.

Vision of the OSP

The vision of the Office is to render corruption costly and unattractive in all its forms in public and private sectors through sustained repression and suppression.

Mission of the OSP

The mission of the Office is to investigate and prosecute specific cases of alleged or suspected corruption and corruption-related offences; recover the proceeds of corruption and corruption-related offences; and take steps to prevent corruption.

Core Functions of the OSP

The core functions of the OSP include the following:

- i. Investigate and prosecute corruption cases under the Public Procurement Act, 2003 (Act 663), Criminal and Other Offences Act, 1960 (Act 29) and any other relevant law involving public officers, politically-exposed persons, and private individuals.
- ii. Receive, investigate, and act on complaints and referrals from individuals, Parliament, the Auditor-General, CHRAJ, EOCO, and other public bodies regarding alleged or suspected corruption and related offences.
- iii. Disseminate information obtained during investigations to appropriate law-enforcement authorities and relevant persons as needed.
- iv. Recover and manage proceeds of corruption arising from investigated or prosecuted cases.
- v. Co-operate and coordinate with local and international authorities and perform any other functions necessary to achieve the objectives of the Office.

2025 Performance Overview

Operational Performance

The OSP recorded the following achievements during the year under review:

Corruption Risk Analysis of Payroll Administration

In the first half of 2025, the OSP advanced its anti-corruption mandate by translating earlier investigations into concrete enforcement outcomes, including prosecutions and asset recoveries. In collaboration with the Controller and Accountant-General's Department, the OSP conducted a corruption risk assessment of payroll administration in the Northern Region. This assessment uncovered and disrupted a significant payroll fraud scheme involving the Ghana Education Service and the Tamale Teaching Hospital, resulting in savings of GH¢34 million in unearned salaries for the 2024 financial year. Consequently, six individuals were convicted through plea bargains on 30th April, 2025 and jointly refunded GH¢106,319.64 to the State, underscoring the OSP's commitment to accountability, deterrence, and protection of public funds.

Case Management and Investigation

From January to June 2025, the Office strengthened its core enforcement functions by concluding 10 investigations that resulted in prosecutions, plea bargains, and administrative actions, making notable progress in combating corruption and recovering public funds. The Office is also actively managing approximately 67 ongoing investigations at various stages from preliminary assessments to full-scale inquiries covering suspected corruption and related offences across multiple sectors.

Prosecution

During the reporting period, the OSP actively pursued seven prosecutions, four of which were initiated between January and June, 2025. These efforts yielded seven convictions and one acquittal, the latter currently under appeal. In addition to court-imposed fines, convicted persons made restitution through partial reparation payments to the State.

Financial Performance

In the 2025 financial year, the OSP was allocated an amount of One Hundred and Forty-Six Million, Seven Hundred and Fifty Thousand, Two Hundred and Eighty-Nine Ghana Cedis (GH¢146,750,289). Out of this, an amount of One Hundred and Seven Million, Three Hundred and Eight Thousand, and Fifty-Six Ghana Cedis, Eighty-Nine Pesewas (GH¢107,308,056.89), representing 73 per cent of the total budget, was released. The breakdown of the expenditure returns of the OSP is provided in Table 1 below.

Table 1: Financial Performance of the OSP as of September, 2025

Classification	Approved Budget (A)	Revised Budget (B)	Released Budget (C)	Actual Payments (D)	% Released (E)
Compensation of Employees	71,839,938	71,839,938	52,034,489.89	52,034,489.89	72
Goods and Services	54,910,351	54,910,351	43,273,567.00	3,273,567.00	79
Capex	20,000,000.00	20,000,000.00	12,000,000.00	6,637,036.00	33
TOTAL	146,750,289.00	146,750,289.00	107,308,056.89	101,945,092.89	73

Source: 2026 Programme-Based Budget Estimates of OSP

Outlook for 2026 Outlook and Planned Actions for 2026

The Office of the Special Prosecutor is currently pursuing 67 ongoing cases. In 2026, the Office aims to complete all pending investigations, advance the prosecution of existing cases, and initiate new ones, thereby strengthening accountability, enhancing deterrence, and reinforcing the national anti-corruption effort.

Budgetary Allocation for the 2026 Financial Year

To enable the Office execute its programmes and activities, an amount of

One Hundred and Fifty-Eight Million, Nine Hundred and Thirty-Six Thousand, Four Hundred and Fifty-Eight Ghana Cedis (GH¢158,936,458.00) has been allocated for the 2026 financial year. Out of the total figure, an amount of Seventy-Eight Million, Twenty-Six Thousand, One Hundred and Seven Ghana Cedis (GH¢78,026,107.00) has been allocated for Compensation; Sixty Million, Nine Hundred and Ten Thousand, Three Hundred and Fifty-One Ghana Cedis (GH¢60,910,351.00) for Goods and Services; and Twenty Million Ghana Cedis (GH¢20,000,000.00) for Capital Expenditure. The breakdown of the allocations is presented in Table 2.

Table 2: Budgetary Allocation by Economic Classifications for 2026

Economic Classification	Sources of Funding					
	GOG	ABFA	IGF	DONOR	TOTAL	%
Compensation	78,026,107	-	-	-	78,026,107	49.1
Goods and Services	60,910,351	-	-	-	60,910,351	38.3
Capex	20,000,000	-	-	-	20,000,000	12.6
Total	158,936,458	-	-	-	158,936,458	100

Observations

The Committee, after a careful scrutiny of the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Special Prosecutor, makes the following observations.

Budgetary Allocation and Resource Adequacy

For the 2025 financial year, the Office was allocated a total budget of GH¢146,750,289.00, of which 73 per cent was released to the Office. This shortfall in disbursement continued to constrain the OSP's ability to fully execute planned activities across its investigative, prosecutorial, and preventive functions.

For the 2026 financial year, the OSP's budgetary allocation increased by 8.3 per cent, amounting to GH¢158,938,458.00.

While the Committee acknowledged this 8.3 per cent increment, it expressed concern that the increase remains inadequate, relative to the OSP's broad and demanding mandate. The Office plays a central role in combating

corruption, strengthening institutional integrity, and recovering public funds, and has already demonstrated notable achievements in these areas. Given the scope of its responsibilities and the operational demands associated with high-level investigations and prosecutions, the Committee emphasised the critical need for enhanced resource allocation to ensure that the OSP can function effectively and sustainably.

Budget Proposal

The Special Prosecutor informed the Committee that the OSP requires an upward revision of its 2026 budget from GH¢158,936,458.00 to GH¢310,500,000.00 to operate effectively. The increased allocation would support the establishment of three zonal offices in Kumasi, Takoradi, and Tamale, as well as the recruitment of 50 additional staff to address their staffing gaps.

The Committee noted the importance of these proposals but emphasised that budget allocations must reflect the available fiscal space and broader economic considerations. It, therefore, viewed the requested increment as

overly high and advised the OSP to prioritise expenditures while pursuing expansion gradually.

The Committee commended the OSP for its achievements despite limited resources and expressed confidence in its continued progress in the next financial period.

Direct Recoveries and Savings

The Committee commended the OSP for recoveries and savings made to the State during the review period. It emphasised that the fight against corruption should lead not only to prosecutions, but also to savings and recoveries. A total of GHC6,506,198.89 and US\$2,000,000.00 were recovered respectively. This is made up of:

S/N	Details	Amount (GHS)	Amount (USD)
1	Plea bargain restitution and reparation by accused persons in the payroll audit case (The Republic v Tahidu Yakubu & Five Ors	106,319.64	-
2	Plea Bargain in (The Republic v Charles Bissie & Another and Andy)	206,000.00	-
3	Recovered in respect of diversions of petroleum products	6,193,879.25	-
4	Recoveries from Minerals Income Investment Fund (MIIF)	-	2,000,000.00
	Total	6,506,198.89	2,000,000.00

Notable among the savings is from the Revenue Assurance Audit Agreement between the Ghana Airport Company Limited and Evatex Logistics Limited where the State was saved from a potential loss of up to GHC687 million.

The Committee recommended that the OSP should initiate discussions with the Ministry of Finance for an increment in the retention of recoveries as this will augment the budget gaps of the Office. To give legal effect to the increment, the Committee recommended to the OSP to

make such provision in the proposed amendment to the existing law.

Public Allegations and Sensitisation

The Committee inquired into allegations directed at the OSP, particularly public perceptions of witch-hunting arising from actions taken against individuals who criticise the Office. The Committee emphasised that the OSP should refrain from directly handling such allegations to uphold the principles of natural justice and should,

instead, refer such allegations to the appropriate law enforcement or oversight bodies.

In response, the Special Prosecutor explained that the OSP's enabling Act provides for a National Disciplinary Committee, mandated to address such matters when they arise. The Special Prosecutor mentioned that the process was akin to what pertains in the Ghana Police Service and the Ghana Armed Forces where there is provision for internal investigations of any wrongdoings on the part of officers. The Committee encouraged the OSP to enhance its public communication and clearly articulate the criteria guiding its operations to dispel misconceptions and reinforce public confidence.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee, after a comprehensive review of the 2026 Programmes and Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Special Prosecutor concludes that the proposed initiatives are well aligned with the strategic priorities required to advance the national fight against corruption and related offences.

The Committee, accordingly, recommends to the House to adopt this Report and approve the sum of One Hundred and Fifty-Eight Million, Nine Hundred and Thirty-Six Thousand, Four Hundred and Fifty-Eight Ghana Cedis (GH¢158,936,458.00) to finance the implementation of programmes and activities of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the 2026 financial year.

I will just touch on two issues. The first has to do with the direct recoveries and savings that the Office of the Special Prosecutor has been able to save this nation. This year alone, the Office made recoveries of GH¢6.5 million and \$2 million. The second has to do with the prevention and the savings that it has done for this nation. Two clear institutions will come to mind. The famous Strategic Mobilisation Ghana Limited (SML) and Evatex Logistics Limited, where the state was saved of GH¢687 million through the efforts of the Special Prosecutor.

Indeed, it is an important office which, when given the needed resources – the Ministry of Finance is encouraged to give more allocation to the Office of the Special Prosecutor so that more revenue will be raked in.

In conclusion, Mr Speaker, the Committee, after a comprehensive review of the 2026 budget of the Office of the Special Prosecutor, concludes that the proposed initiatives are well designed and aligned to strategic priorities required to advance a national fight against corruption. The Committee accordingly recommends to the House to adopt this Report and approve the sum of GH¢158,936,458 to finance the implementation of programmes and activities of the Office of the Special Prosecutor.

Question proposed.

Mr Alhassan Tampuli Sulemana (NPP — Gushegu): Mr Speaker, I am grateful. Mr Speaker, I rise to contribute

to the Motion before this House for the consideration of the estimates for the Office of the Special Prosecutor in the amount of GH¢158,936,458.

The Office of the Special Prosecutor has recently come under public scrutiny, and it will be difficult for us to make commentary on its budget without making a referral to the raging discussion about the effectiveness and relevance of the Office. It has to be on record that about three petitions, as of today, have been referred to the President for the removal of the Special Prosecutor. This comes on the heels of the removal of the Chief Justice of the Republic of Ghana. Next on the agenda is the removal of the Electoral Commissioner. Something is happening in this country.

If we are minded to fight corruption, we should be hesitant in the way and manner that we are attacking offices of Accountability. These bodies were created to be fearless, independent and to prosecute their business without any “big brother” overlooking their shoulders. Mr Speaker, it is becoming very difficult for the Special Prosecutor to function. I am very sad that even the amount that the Special Prosecutor requested to be able to prosecute his business for 2026 has been reduced by almost 50 per cent.

I do not know what the plan is, but if we are to take out the Special Prosecutor, what is left with the Office? Are we going to appoint an NDC person to come and occupy the Office? What is the plan? We are approving estimates for the Office to function. The arrowhead of the Office has become a target. There has

been an attempt to remove some constitutional officers already. And now we are coming to this particular Office of the Special Prosecutor. What is his crime? Mr Speaker, I will give an example.

The Special Prosecutor has been investigating SML for close to 10 months, if not 12 months. I need to make this point —

5:24 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hold on.

At times, I become reluctant because I know you are executing Government business, and I just want things to flow. Therefore, I reluctantly decide not to attend to you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: The fluidity of Government business must not suffer when untruths are being placed in the *Hansard*. Mr Speaker, there is no way that the Government is pursuing anybody out of office. That cannot be a statement of fact on this Floor. Citizens have right to petition, and they must have done that. It does not constitute a removal, so do not make that suggestion.

Second, we are approving the estimates for next year’s operations for the Office of the Special Prosecutor, not the Special Prosecutor. So, this attempt to malign the Government at the slightest opportunity must not be countenanced. By all means, they should make their point. Within the terms of the Reports, they should look at the number of cases

they have not done. They must look at their activities and leave the tangential matters for their press conferences.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let us move on. Leader, I would urge you to ignore some of these things and let us move on.

Mr A. T. Sulemana: The Majority Chief Whip is doing everything. Instead of facilitating Government business, he is frustrating Government business. The point I am making is that this Office started the SML investigation about a year ago, and it is on record that the Hon Attorney-General and Minister for Justice said that the Office of the Attorney-General is also pursuing its own investigation in respect of that same matter.

Mr Speaker, it appears that another state agency is also investigating SML; SML *baako*, investigations *bebree*. What exactly is the issue? The corruption has started; they are overspending what has been appropriated to them. It is on record. The work that the Office of the Special Prosecutor is doing requires some amount of focus, but it appears that any time the Special Prosecutor makes a move, some other state agencies would come and pull their legs from different angles. So, we are not sure whether the Government is actually committed to the fight against corruption.

Mr Speaker, one must commend the Special Prosecutor, especially if you refer to other state agencies that are also involved in this business of fighting corruption. We must put on record that

they have a very flexible arrangement to consider people to come on self-recognisance bail. I think that is in keeping with best practices and the precedents set over the years. Nobody is running away from the jurisdiction. So, when you invite a minister, a former minister, or a Member of Parliament, by virtue of being a Member of Parliament, it requires that you give the person a self-recognisance bail and not necessarily go and put some very humorous bail conditions.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to signal that the House should approve the sum of GH¢158,936,458.00 for the Office of Special Prosecutor.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Francis-Xavier K. Sosu (NDC — Madina): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I rise to support the Motion that we approve the advertised sum for the Office of Special Prosecutor.

Mr Speaker, it is very important for us to make the case that fighting corruption is not only about prosecution. Let us get that very clear: that in investigating corruption and corruption-related matters, the amount of savings you make to the state is as critical as the people you prosecute. So, the case that people are always in a hurry for prosecution — I have seen cases where people have been investigated over several years, sometimes spanning 20 years, so that at the time prosecution is mounted, you have no defense of your situation. But what we have here in our

jurisdiction is that everybody is in a hurry to mount prosecution so quickly to determine the effectiveness or otherwise of institutions like the Office of the Special Prosecutor.

Mr Speaker, I think that is erroneous, and we must begin to address those perceptions in our society. I think that the Office of the Special Prosecutor, when they appeared before the Committee, demonstrated that by virtue of the savings they have made for the state, they are actually working in favour and in the interest of the state. Of course, we have not seen major prosecutions yet, but they have proven that they are doing their work well.

Mr Speaker, again, let me clarify the point that the fact that the Office of the Special Prosecutor is doing the best they can within their mandate does not mean that citizens and individuals who have issues about how the Special Prosecutor is operating cannot come out to speak against them. So, I was worried when a person like Martin Kpebu, for example, was invited by the Special Prosecutor because he was on television raising some allegations. I thought that as lawyers, we know the rules of justice. If the Special Prosecutor thinks that allegations may border on criminality, he can report to other agencies so that it does not look like he is investigating someone in his own cause. These are things I believe that the Special Prosecutor must work on to shape the public perception that is currently sweeping the Office of the Special Prosecutor away.

Having said that, Mr Speaker, every citizen who has an issue can petition. In this case, the petition was submitted to the President, and the President only referred the petition in accordance with the 1992 Constitution of Ghana. So, I pray that whatever the case may, let us approve the estimates. After approval of the estimates, let the process go through so that at the end of the day, whatever comes out would be within the remit of the law.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, it is very important that as a Committee, we do our work cognisant of context and circumstance. In the case of the Office of the Special Prosecutor, it is an office created by this House, so in interrogating their Budget, we need to pay attention to the circumstance of their creation and the object of the office.

Mr Speaker, it may well seem that the Committee must have done its work without cognisance of these facts. Why do I say so? Mr Speaker, when you take the *Hansard* of 2018, when the Office of the Special Prosecutor was being promulgated, when it was being discussed in this House, one thing, and only one thing, can be the sum of the role for which the office was created; protection of the public purse.

Mr Speaker, one would have anticipated that in considering the allocation to the Office, we would have paid attention to the very object of the Office. Mr Speaker, it appears to me that same was not done. Mr Speaker, indeed,

when you look at the role of the office, as I have already stated, which is to protect the public purse—What is the public purse?

5:34 p.m.

The public purse is what is being considered. The office has deviated its course of protecting the public purse, complete deviation. It is obvious to me that those screaming are not even aware of the role of the office. Under Article 187 (2) of the 1992 Constitution, when the public purse has been spent upon the approval of this House, the Auditor-General audits the public purse. Check what was brought before us if any of the findings of irregularities identified by the Auditor-General is being investigated by the Office of the Special Prosecutor, a complete deviation.

Mr Speaker, please indulge me.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: No, we cannot give you all the time.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Mr Speaker, if you may indulge me for five more minutes. It is a complete deviation of the office. What was their budget? We are giving them GH¢158 million when they are not doing what is required of them, which is the protection of the public purse. Indeed, recently, it took the intervention of the President—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Your assertion is subjective.

Mr Baffour Awuah: Well, Mr Speaker, very respectfully, you cannot

deny the fact that the public purse is what we are approving. You cannot deny the fact that the auditing of the public purse – The Office of the Special Prosecutor has deviated its course and must be abolished. We are chasing good money with bad money.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I will put the Question.

Question put and Motion agreed to Resolved:

That this honourable House has approved the sum of GH¢158,936,456.00 for the services of the Office of the Special Prosecutor for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I hope now we are going to—

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, as a matter of course, the Motion numbered 17. Mr Speaker, the Minister is here and fortuitously, the Vice Chairperson of the Committee is ready to present the Report.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, Hon First Deputy Minority Whip?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Mr Speaker, we do not have any difficulty; the Vice Chairperson is a nice person.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, let me invite you to page 12, the Motion numbered 17 by the Minister for Foreign Affairs.

Hon Minister, you have the floor now.

ANNUAL ESTIMATES, 2026

MINISTRY OF FOREIGN AFFAIRS

Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa) (MP): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

That this honourable House approves the sum of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the services of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much.

Yes, Vice-Chairperson of the Committee?

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

I rise to second the Motion numbered 17, urging the House to approve the sum of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the services of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for the year ending 31st December, 2026 and in so doing, present your Committee's Report. I urge the *Hansard* to capture the entire Report as having been read.

Introduction

Pursuant to Article 179 of the 1992 Constitution, the Hon Minister for Finance, Dr Cassiel Ato Baah Forson, on Thursday, 13th November, 2025, presented to the House the Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the

Government of Ghana for the 2026 Financial Year.

In accordance with Order 245 of the Standing Orders of Parliament, the Rt Hon Speaker accordingly referred the Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration to the Committee on Foreign Affairs for consideration and report.

Consequently, the Committee met on Monday, 1st December 2025, to examine the Ministry's Estimates. In attendance were the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, officials from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, and technical officers from the Ministry of Finance. Their submissions, clarifications and technical insights substantially enriched the Committee's deliberations, particularly in respect of expenditure performance for 2025, revenue projections for 2026, and the Ministry's operational priorities as captured in the presentation to the Committee.

The Committee expresses its profound appreciation to the Hon Minister and his team for their constructive engagement, candour, and cooperation, which facilitated a thorough and evidence-based consideration of the 2026 Budget Estimates of the Ministry.

Referenced Documents

In the course of its deliberations on the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, the Committee examined

and relied upon a number of authoritative documents that informed its analysis and conclusions. The key documents referenced include:

1. The 1992 Constitution of the Republic of Ghana;
2. The Standing Orders of the Parliament of Ghana;
3. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2025 Financial Year;
4. The Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration for the 2025 Financial Year;
5. The Medium-Term Expenditure Framework (MTEF) for the 2025–2026 Programme-Based Budget Estimates of the Ministry;
6. The Budget Statement and Economic Policy of the Government of Ghana for the 2026 Fiscal Year; and
7. The Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs on the 2025 Annual Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration.

These documents collectively provided the constitutional, policy, and budgetary context within which the Committee assessed the Ministry's performance for 2025 and its financial projections and programme priorities for 2026.

Vision and Core Functions of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs

Vision of the Ministry

The vision of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is to realise a transformed and globally competitive Foreign Service that is effective in promoting Ghana's economic integration with regional and sub-regional partners, and strategically positioned to contribute to sustained accelerated growth and poverty reduction. This vision reflects the Ministry's commitment to modern, proactive diplomacy that advances Ghana's political, economic and developmental interests within the international community.

Core Functions of the Ministry

In fulfilment of its statutory mandate, the Ministry performs the following core functions:

1. Initiate, formulate, coordinate and implement Ghana's Foreign Policy objectives;
2. Advance Ghana's economic interests by collaborating with Ministries, Departments and Agencies (MDAs) to promote the Made-in-Ghana brand and expand trade, tourism, and inward investment opportunities;
3. Coordinate Ghana's participation in regional integration efforts aimed at safeguarding and advancing the national interest;

4. Develop and articulate Ghana's positions at multilateral fora to ensure favourable diplomatic, economic, and political outcomes;
5. Foster and maintain cordial bilateral relations with friendly states across diverse sectors of cooperation;
6. Develop institutional frameworks, including Joint Commissions for Cooperation and bilateral consultation mechanisms, to support mutually beneficial diplomatic engagement;
7. Collaborate with the Attorney-General's Department towards establishing an integrated legal service within the Ministry to strengthen Ghana's representation and advocacy in international legal fora;
8. Improve the quality of Consular Services delivered by the Ministry and its Missions abroad, while deepening relations with Ghanaian communities and migrant groups worldwide; and
9. Promote public awareness of Ghana's international rights and obligations, thereby enhancing national understanding of foreign policy priorities.

Agencies Under the Ministry

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs exercises oversight responsibility over a

number of key agencies and subordinate institutions that collectively support the execution of Ghana's foreign policy mandate. These include:

1. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Headquarters);
2. The Passport Office;
3. The Accra International Conference Centre (AICC);
4. Seventy-One (71) Diplomatic Missions accredited across the world;
5. Six (6) Consulate-Generals;
6. Fifty-Eight (58) Honorary Consulates; and
7. Subvented Organisations, namely:
 - a. Legon Centre for International Affairs and Diplomacy (LECIAD);
 - b. National African Peer Review Mechanism Governing Council (NAPRM-GC); and
 - c. All-Africa Students Union (AASU).

These entities constitute the administrative and operational architecture through which the Ministry delivers diplomatic services, advances Ghana's external relations, and supports multilateral, regional, and consular functions.

Sector Policy Objectives of the Ministry for the Medium Term

In alignment with the Government's Medium-Term Development Framework and the overarching national development agenda, the Ministry has articulated the following sector policy objectives to guide its operations over the medium term:

1. Promote a globally competitive Foreign Service, capable of effectively representing Ghana's interests in an increasingly complex international system;
2. Enhance Ghana's international image and influence, reflecting the country's values, governance credentials, and diplomatic standing;
3. Leverage Ghana's governance and security strengths to advance the nation's political and economic interests abroad;
4. Promote international peace and sustainable development, in accordance with Ghana's longstanding commitment to multilateralism;
5. Integrate the Ghanaian diaspora into national development processes, recognising their strategic contribution to investment, remittances, and knowledge transfer; and
6. Accelerate economic and social integration with regional and sub-regional states to foster prosperity, stability, and coordinated development.

Performance Review for the 2025

For the 2026 Financial Year, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration has been allocated a total of GH¢1,696,321,803.00, sourced from the Government of Ghana (GoG) and Internally Generated Funds (IGF). No donor funding is projected for the period, thereby placing full reliance on domestic resource mobilisation.

GoG resources account for 77.08 per cent of the Ministry's overall allocation, with the bulk directed towards Compensation of Employees, while IGF constitutes 22.92 per cent, earmarked primarily for Goods and Services and Capital Expenditure (CAPEX). The Ministry's significant dependence on domestic financing underscores the need for prudent expenditure management and robust internal revenue performance.

Of the Ministry's total allocation, GH¢1,270,956,624.00—representing 74.92 per cent—is dedicated to Compensation, funded almost entirely by GoG. This substantial wage-related commitment continues to constrain the fiscal space available for operational and programme-related expenditure.

An allocation of GH¢285,257,343.00 (16.82 per cent) has been set aside for Goods and Services, with approximately 95.8 per cent of this amount expected from IGF. While this demonstrates an encouraging IGF mobilisation capacity, it also creates vulnerability should projected inflows fall short.

A further GH¢140,107,836.00 (8.26 per cent) is earmarked for Capital Expenditure, of which 81.9 per cent is expected from IGF. The successful implementation of capital projects—including infrastructure development,

digitalisation initiatives, and mission upgrades—will therefore depend heavily on the Ministry's ability to sustain and enhance IGF performance.

Table 1: Budgetary Allocations by Source of Funding for 2025

Item	Approved Budget (GH¢)	Release (Jan–Dec)	Actual Expenditure	Variance-1	Variance-2
COMPENSATION					
GoG	1,162,486,887.00	844,184,225.00	844,184,225.00	381,302,662.00	-
IGF	421,692.00	354,532.00	354,532.00	67,160.00	-
GOODS & SERVICES					
GoG	12,033,950.00	7,378,424.00	7,376,884.00	4,655,526.00	1,540.00
IGF	215,148,275.00	184,335,870.00	184,335,870.00	30,812,405.00	-
CAPEX					
GoG	10,334,128.00	6,200,477.00	6,200,477.00	4,133,651.00	-
IGF	85,774,844.00	60,586,965.00	60,586,965.00	25,187,879.00	-
TOTAL	1,486,199,776.00	1,103,040,492.00	1,103,038,952.00	383,159,284.00	1,540.00

A summary of the Ministry's allocation by source of funding and programme classification is presented in Table 2

Table 2: Allocation by Programme and Economic Classification

Programme	GoG (COE)	GoG (G&S)	GoG (CAPEX)	IGF (COE)	IGF (G&S)	IGF (CAPEX)	Total
Management & Administration	37,251,922.00	2,636,616.00	-	354,532.00	12,486,861.00	22,759,480.00	75,489,410.00
International Relations	806,932,303.00	153,632.00	6,200,477.00	-	121,670,220.00	22,080,604.00	957,037,236.00
Passport Administration	-	4,586,636.00	-	-	50,178,789.00	15,746,881.00	70,512,306.00
Total	844,184,225.00	7,376,884.00	6,200,477.00	354,532.00	184,335,870.00	60,586,965.00	1,103,038,952.00

The 2025 performance review demonstrates that while the Ministry recorded notable improvements in IGF mobilisation, expenditure performance was heavily constrained by the significant variance between approved and released funds, particularly under Compensation and GoG-funded Goods and Services. The reliance on IGF to sustain operational and capital activities highlights the need for continued revenue enhancement measures, efficiency in expenditure management, and reform of cost-recovery mechanisms. The Committee notes that the Ministry's ability to deliver on its diplomatic, consular, and administrative obligations in 2026 will depend largely on the stability of IGF inflows and the timely release of GoG provisions.

Key Achievement in 2025

During the period under review, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration undertook a range of strategic programmes and high-impact diplomatic initiatives aimed at strengthening Ghana's global presence,

enhancing service delivery, and advancing national interests.

Management and Administration Passport Administration

The Ministry implemented significant reforms to modernise passport issuance and improve service delivery nationwide. Key reforms included:

1. The rollout of chip-embedded passports, placing Ghana among the African countries issuing ICAO-compliant biometric travel documents; and
2. The introduction of a nationwide home-delivery service in partnership with two courier companies, enabling applicants to receive passports at their preferred locations at no additional cost.

These reforms have enhanced passport security, streamlined the application process, and improved administrative efficiency across all Passport Application Centres.

Labour Mobility Agreements

To promote employment creation and optimise the export of Ghana's human capital, the Ministry successfully concluded labour mobility agreements with the following countries:

1. Jordan
2. Barbados
3. Qatar
4. United Arab Emirates (UAE)
5. Grenada

These agreements reflect Ghana's proactive approach to labour diplomacy and skills exchange.

New Visa Waivers

The Ministry negotiated and concluded visa waiver agreements with several partner countries to enhance people-to-people exchanges, strengthen bilateral cooperation, and ease travel for Ghanaian passport holders. The agreements cover either Ordinary Passports or Diplomatic and Service Passports, depending on the terms with each country. They include:

1. Morocco (All Passports)
2. Algeria (Diplomatic & Service Passports)
3. Angola (Diplomatic & Service Passports)
4. Antigua and Barbuda (All Passports)

5. Commonwealth of Dominica (All Passports)

6. Mozambique (All Passports)

7. São Tomé and Príncipe (All Passports)

8. Colombia (Diplomatic & Service Passports)

9. Serbia (Diplomatic & Service Passports)

Ratification of Treaties and Agreements by Parliament

The Ministry facilitated Parliamentary consideration and ratification of several international agreements, strengthening Ghana's legal and institutional commitments within the international system. The ratified instruments include:

1. Treaty on the Prohibition of Nuclear Weapons;
2. Host Country Agreement between Ghana and the Alliance for a Green Revolution in Africa (AGRA);
3. Agreement on World Trade;
4. Host Country Agreement between the Republic of Ghana and AFROBAROMETER LBG;
5. Protocol amending Article 50(a) of the Convention on International Civil Aviation (1990);

6. WTO Fisheries Subsidies Agreement;
7. Constitution of the African Civil Aviation Commission (AFCAC);
8. 2012 Cape Town Agreement on the Safety of Fishing Vessels; and
9. Protocol amending Article 56 of the Convention on International Civil Aviation (1986).

Launch of ECOWAS 50th Anniversary Celebration in Accra

The Ministry successfully coordinated the 50th Anniversary Celebration of ECOWAS in Accra on 22 April 2025, officiated by His Excellency the President. At the event, the President reaffirmed Ghana's commitment to regional integration and education, announcing 1,000 university scholarships for students from ECOWAS Member States. He also highlighted the critical role of diplomacy in addressing regional insecurity, particularly in the Sahel.

United States Visa Restrictions and Reversal

Following changes to the United States' visa reciprocity schedule—which downgraded several countries, including Ghana, to single-entry visas valid for three months—the Ministry undertook intensive and sustained diplomatic engagement with the U.S. Government.

As a result, Ghana became the only one among the 36 affected countries to secure a restoration of the five-year multiple-entry visa, coupled with

enhanced consular privileges. This achievement reflects the Ministry's effective diplomacy and commitment to safeguarding Ghanaian mobility rights.

High-Level Visits to Ghana

The Ministry facilitated several high-level visits, including:

1. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's historic State Visit to Ghana; and
2. Working visits by leaders and senior officials from India, Czech Republic, São Tomé and Príncipe, Eswatini, the United Kingdom, and the ECOWAS Commission, among others.

These engagements resulted in the signing of memoranda of understanding (MoUs) in areas such as civil aviation, political consultations, cultural and educational exchange, standardisation, traditional medicine, joint cooperation frameworks, and economic development.

State Visit to Singapore by His Excellency the President

The Ministry coordinated the State Visit of President John Dramani Mahama to Singapore from 26–28 August 2025, at the invitation of President Tharman Shanmugaratnam.

The visit deepened cooperation in trade, investment, innovation, agribusiness, education, urban planning, and the digital economy, while positioning Ghana as a strategic gateway to the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA) for Singaporean firms.

Working Visits of the President to AES Countries

The Ministry facilitated the President's working visits to Mali, Burkina Faso, and Niger in March 2025. These engagements strengthened sub-regional cooperation, promoted regional stability, and advanced collective efforts to safeguard the sovereignty and development priorities of the region.

Key Performance Indicators for Ambassadors and High Commissioners

To strengthen accountability and improve mission performance, the Ministry established a Delivery Unit, which developed and launched a comprehensive 500-page Key Performance Indicator (KPI) Framework for all Ambassadors and High Commissioners. The framework provides a clear, measurable basis for assessing the effectiveness of Ghana's diplomatic missions.

Scholarships

The Ministry facilitated the award of approximately 1,500 educational scholarships to qualified Ghanaian citizens through partnerships with 15 countries. These scholarships were communicated to relevant institutions to support human capital development across various fields of study.

Outlook for 2026

For the 2026 Financial Year, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration articulated a forward-looking

programme aimed at strengthening Ghana's diplomatic infrastructure, enhancing service delivery, and consolidating the country's international presence. The Ministry's key priorities for the year are as follows:

1. Implement the Strategic Transition from Renting to Infrastructure Development (STRIDE) initiative, to reduce rental costs and improve the long-term asset base of Ghana's Missions abroad;
2. political, economic Establish new Diplomatic Missions to deepen Ghana's, and cultural engagements across strategic regions;
3. Introduce an e-visa system to modernise visa processing, enhance efficiency, and reduce fraud;
4. Construct a comprehensive IT platform and two Data Centres in Accra and Kumasi, to facilitate real-time digital connectivity between all Ghana Missions abroad and the Ministry's Headquarters;
5. Operationalise the Consular Fund to support distressed Ghanaians abroad and enhance the Ministry's humanitarian response capability;
6. Support Ghanaian candidatures for positions in international organisations to increase the country's representation and influence in global governance structures;
7. Develop a comprehensive Foreign Policy, providing a coherent and strategic framework to drive Ghana's external relations;

8. Participate actively in statutory meetings of organisations such as the African Union (AU), ECOWAS, United Nations (UN), and other relevant bodies;

9. Fully implement the Foreign Service Regulations and improve conditions of service to strengthen professionalism and efficiency within the Foreign Service;

10. Ratify international agreements, protocols, and conventions concluded by the Government;

11. Develop a modern document management system to support digital archiving, records integrity, and administrative efficiency;

12. Procure vehicles—including e-vehicles where applicable—for the Ministry and its Missions abroad, to enhance mobility and operational readiness;

13. Intensify focus on climate change, cultural diplomacy, peace and

security, and related thematic areas aligned with national development objectives;

14. Operationalise the Ministry's clinic, thereby improving staff welfare and occupational health standards; and

15. Construct 16 permanent Regional Passport Application Centres (PACs), aimed at expanding access to passport services and reducing processing backlogs nationwide.

2026 Financial Projection for the Ministry

The Ministry's financial projection for the 2026 Financial Year reflects a continued reliance on Government of Ghana (GoG) funding complemented by Internally Generated Funds (IGF), with no donor support anticipated. Details of the budgetary allocation are presented below.

Table 3: 2026 Budgetary Allocation for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs

Economic Classification	GOG (GHC)	IGF (GHC)	IGF (GHC)	Donor (GHC)	Total (GHC)	%
Compensation	1,270,170,692.00	785,932.00	785,932.00	—	1,270,956,624.00	74.92
Goods and Services	12,033,950.00	273,223,393.00	273,223,393.00	—	285,257,343.00	16.82
Capex	25,334,128.00	114,773,708.00	114,773,708.00	—	140,107,836.00	8.26
Total	1,307,538,770.00	388,783,033.00	388,783,033.00	—	1,696,321,803.00	100.00
%	77.08	22.92	22.92	0.00	100.00	—

Source: Budget Estimate 2026

This allocation structure shows a continued dominance of Compensation expenditure, which accounts for nearly three-quarters of the total budget. Goods and Services, heavily funded by IGF, remain essential to sustaining the

Ministry's operational activities, while Capital Expenditure represents a modest but strategic investment in infrastructure and technological systems.

Table 5: Budget Allocation by Programmes (GHC)

Programmes	Allocation (GHC)	%
Management and Administration	469,304,984	27.5
International Cooperation	1,109,955,886	65.43
Passport Administration	117,060,933	6.9
Total	1,696,321,803	100

Source: Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration's PBB Estimates for 2026

International Cooperation

The Committee observed that the largest share of the Ministry's 2026 allocation—65.43 per cent—is directed towards International Cooperation. This reflects the Ministry's expanded diplomatic engagements, peacekeeping obligations, participation in multilateral forums, and the operational requirements of Ghana's 71 Missions and six Consulate-Generals abroad. The allocation underscores the centrality of diplomacy in advancing Ghana's international standing and foreign policy objectives.

Management and Administration

The Committee noted that 27.5 per cent of the total budget is allocated to Management and Administration, highlighting the considerable resources required to support the Ministry's internal governance architecture, human resources, training, policy planning, and general administrative operations.

Passport Administration

Despite the growing national demand for passport services and continuing reforms in the passport delivery ecosystem, Passport Administration received the smallest share of the Ministry's budget—6.9 per cent. The Committee is concerned that this limited allocation may constrain planned service improvements, including:

- system upgrades,
- regional expansion of Passport Application Centres,
- processing efficiency reform, and
- backlog clearance efforts.

This signals a resource gap between the Ministry's service obligations and the financial provisions available to support them.

Observations and Recommendations

During its consideration of the 2026 Annual Budget Estimates of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, the Committee made the following key observations and corresponding recommendations:

2026 Budget Shortfalls

The Committee observed that while the Ministry proposed a total budget of GH¢3,367,854,277.00 for the 2026 Financial Year, the approved budget ceiling amounted to GH¢1,696,321,803.00, resulting in a substantial funding shortfall of GH¢1,671,532,474.00, representing approximately 49.63 per cent of the Ministry's projected requirement.

The most severe reduction occurred under the Internally Generated Funds (IGF) component, where only 21.79 per cent of the Ministry's submission was approved. The Committee expressed grave concern that such a pronounced shortfall is likely to adversely affect:

- critical capital and infrastructure projects,
- mission operations abroad,
- consular and passport services, and
- Ghana's ability to meet its international obligations.

The Committee is of the considered view that the cumulative effect of the

funding gaps poses a significant risk to the Ministry's operational sustainability in 2026. The Committee therefore urges Government to consider additional funding support, particularly during the Mid-Year Review.

Non-Tax Revenue Performance and Outstanding Submissions

The Committee noted the Ministry's projected IGF target of approximately GH¢398,704,713.00 for 2026. However, concerns were raised regarding the Ministry's full compliance with the Fees and Charges Act, particularly with respect to fees that may not yet have received formal Parliamentary approval. The Committee therefore:

- urges the Ministry to submit all outstanding fee schedules for Parliamentary approval to prevent unauthorised fee charging;
- acknowledges the Ministry's current retention structure—100 per cent retention of passport and visa fees, and 16 per cent retention of attestation fees; and
- encourages the Ministry to expedite fee regularisations to improve transparency, strengthen revenue governance, and ensure legal compliance.

Revenue Enhancement Measures

The Committee observed the Ministry's comprehensive strategy to improve its IGF mobilisation capacity and reduce dependence on the Consolidated Fund. Key initiatives include:

- Commercialisation of mobile passport enrolment equipment, enabling outreach to underserved areas while generating revenue;
- Establishment of premium passport service centres, including the rollout of a 24-hour expedited passport service priced at GHC2,000;
- A reduction in passport processing fees from GHC500 to GHC350, intended to increase the volume of applications and thereby enhance overall revenue;
- Implementation of a new e-visa system, expected to digitise visa processing, curb leakages, and improve revenue capture; and
- Plans to enhance revenue from the Accra International Conference Centre (AICC) by discontinuing the current low-yield arrangement with a private dome contractor and procuring new domes for both wings of the facility.

The Committee noted that the Ministry intends to submit new fee schedules to Parliament for the dome facilities, as they constitute new services. Collectively, these measures demonstrate a clear commitment to strengthening IGF performance, closing existing revenue gaps, and supporting the Ministry's operational sustainability in the face of significant budget constraints.

Structural Integrity of the Accra International Conference Centre

The Committee expressed deep concern upon being briefed on the outcome of a structural integrity assessment of the AICC, which revealed:

- exposed columns,
- rusted reinforcement bars,
- compromised foundations, and
- persistent water seepage.

These conditions pose a serious public safety risk.

The Ministry informed the Committee that, following engagements with the Presidency and National Security, emergency works—estimated at GHC5 million—were scheduled to commence immediately. The objective is to complete all corrective measures by the third week of December, ahead of high-profile events.

The Committee emphasised the urgent need to address both the structural defects and the malfunctioning chiller system, which currently undermines the operational usability of the facility.

Need for a Designated Diplomatic Enclave

The Committee noted the Ministry's concern regarding the lack of a designated diplomatic enclave in Accra. Traditional diplomatic zones—Cantonments, Labone, and Airport Residential—are fully built-up, leaving no available land to allocate to foreign governments seeking to establish missions in Ghana.

The Ministry also highlighted Ghana's reciprocity obligations to countries that have already donated land to Ghana abroad, including Pakistan, India, Turkey, and Equatorial Guinea.

The Committee further observed that the absence of land allocation threatens Ghana's ability to host major international institutions, such as ECOWAS' ERERA, which has signalled the possibility of relocating its headquarters project should land not be provided.

The Committee welcomed the Ministry's decision to submit a Cabinet Memorandum requesting that the Lands Commission identify and zone an appropriate area to serve as a new diplomatic enclave.

Operationalisation of the Consular Fund

The Committee expressed strong concern that the Consular Fund, though appearing in the national budget for over five consecutive years, has never received any actual releases from the Ministry of Finance.

The Fund is intended to support distressed Ghanaians abroad—including emergency medical assistance and repatriation of remains—but Missions currently rely on the personal resources of diplomats, which is unsustainable and inconsistent with Ghana's consular obligations under international law.

The Committee strongly urges that the Fund be capitalised in 2026 to ensure

that the Ministry can effectively fulfil its humanitarian and consular mandates.

STRIDE Initiative

The Committee recognised the persistent challenge of high rental expenditure incurred by Ghana's Missions abroad due to the absence of Government-owned properties. The Ministry's Strategic Transition from Renting to Infrastructure Development (STRIDE) initiative aims to address this long-term liability through the acquisition and construction of Government-owned mission infrastructure.

The Ministry informed the Committee that an estimated US\$300 million will be required to implement the STRIDE initiative.

The Committee supports the Ministry's efforts and recommends that all necessary financial and administrative approvals be expedited to ensure the smooth implementation of this initiative as a priority under the 2026 programme of work.

Establishment of New Missions

The Committee noted that the Ministry intends to establish five new Diplomatic Missions in:

- Lisbon (Portugal)
- Massachusetts (United States of America)
- Singapore

- Mexico
- Dublin (Ireland)

The Committee further highlighted that the establishment of a mission or consulate in Mexico is particularly strategic in view of the 2026 World Cup, as the Ministry is already engaged with host nations—the United States, Canada, and Mexico—to facilitate consular access and support to Ghanaian nationals.

The Committee commended the Ministry's proactive approach, noting that the expansion is likely to enhance Ghana's diplomatic reach, strengthen bilateral and multilateral partnerships, and bolster the country's capacity to support its citizens abroad.

Conclusion

The Committee, having duly considered the mandate, performance, and strategic priorities of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, recognises the critical role the Ministry continues to play in projecting Ghana's international image, advancing economic diplomacy, and deepening public understanding of Ghana's international rights and obligations. The Ministry's expanding diplomatic engagements, intensified consular responsibilities, and the operational demands of its Missions worldwide make it imperative that it be adequately resourced to deliver effectively in the 2026 Financial Year.

In view of the foregoing, the Committee respectfully recommends to the House to adopt its Report and to approve the sum of One Billion, Six Hundred Ninety-Six Million, Three Hundred Twenty-One Thousand, Eight Hundred and Three Ghana Cedis (GH¢1,696,321,803) for the implementation of the programmes and activities of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration for the financial year ending 31st December 2026.

I so submit.

Question proposed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Thank you very much. Hon Members, the Motion has been moved and seconded. It is now before the House for consideration.

Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP — Damongo): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I rise to support the Motion requesting the approval of the amount of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for the financial year ending 31st December, 2026. Mr Speaker, in so doing, I refer the House to page 15 of the Report before this House, Mr Speaker, specifically paragraph 7.0, where the key achievements of the Ministry have been copiously set out.

5:44 p.m.

Allow me to commend the Minister and the Ministry for rolling out some significant interventions in the pursuit of our foreign policy effort, particularly, the

matter relating to labour mobility agreements, where the Ministry has been successful at negotiating labour mobility agreements with Jordan, Barbados, Qatar, the United Arab Emirates, and Grenada.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry has also been successful at achieving some visa waivers with a host of countries, and all of these are quite commendable. The Ministry intends, for 2026, to pursue the policy which was first conceptualised and implemented by the Kufuor administration and by that I refer to economic diplomacy. The Ministry has launched a key performance indicator for Ambassadors and High Commissions, as well as set up a delivery unit, which means that for the pursuit of this Kufuor-led economic diplomacy, the Ministry is going to insist on monitoring and evaluation on how Embassies and Missions across the country perform as it relates to getting investment into our country.

Mr Speaker, further, the Minister and the Ministry intend to implement a policy we refer to as the STRIDE initiative, which is a Strategic Transition from rental to developing our own properties. As we are well aware, and as this House will take note, Ghana rents a lot of infrastructure across the world for our diplomatic work, and the Ministry intends to procure infrastructure which will be owned by the Republic of Ghana, and indeed, this is a lot of money the Ministry is asking from the Government of Ghana and the taxpayer. We indicated this at the committee level, and let us point out to the Minister again that this is

going to be substantial expenditure. The Minister is asking the Ghanaian taxpayer and the Ghanaian public exchequer to cough up huge sums of money to purchase buildings across the world for purposes of our diplomatic efforts.

Mr Speaker, value for money will be absolutely important. The Ministry is going to engage in huge procurement across the world, and it is important that value for money is adhered to. The Ministry intends to procure vehicles, including e-vehicles, where applicable, for the Ministry and its Missions. Again, the Ministry intends to spend colossal sums of money, and therefore, value for money, transparency and accountability will be very important. The Ministry and the Minister should be rest assured that Members of the Committee from this Side will exercise our oversight responsibility by keeping an eagle eye on how the Ministry spends these huge sums of money to buy buildings and infrastructure across the world for Ghana's diplomatic efforts, as well as these vehicles the Ministry intends to buy.

Mr Speaker, there is one particular intervention the Ministry intends to roll out, which we will encourage them to vigorously pursue, which is the welfare of foreign service officials, including but not limited to the importation of vehicles by foreign service officials. All of these are going to be exempted from tax.

If I may conclude on the observations and recommendations of the Committee, particularly as it relates to budget shortfalls, everywhere in the world,

foreign policy and foreign policy efforts directly affect economic and national development. That is why the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, which is the main interlocutor between our Republic and the world, should be funded fully so that it can pursue the foreign policy direction of the Government and, by that matter, the President.

Mr Speaker, we will see from page 28 that the Ministry requested a little over GH¢3 billion, and yet the Ministry has been given GH¢1.6 billion. This is a shortfall of GH¢1.6 billion, some 49 per cent reduction. We have seen the officials of the Ministry of Finance here; the Minister himself was here, and we will plead with them to look at resourcing the Ministry of Foreign Affairs because their work is so consequential. If I may, given that my good Friend, the Minister for Foreign Affairs and Member of Parliament for North Tongu, has been very vociferous on private and presidential jets, if the Minister can support me, and I made this case in this House, to call on the Ministry of Finance and the Government of Ghana to purchase one presidential jet instead of two, and to purchase, two helicopters instead of four.

If the Government were to do that, I want to believe that the Minister for Foreign Affairs, who is actually on record as having said that if his Government had purchased a presidential jet, he would resign. Mr Speaker, the Minister for Foreign Affairs should support me in calling on the Ministry of Finance to scale down these purchases that the Government intends

to engage in, and that will give us some fiscal space. That will loosen the Ministry of Finance up, and that will ensure that the Ministry of Finance will be able to fund the very important three billion budget requests the Minister for Foreign Affairs made.

Mr Speaker, I think it is important that I conclude on that note, and indeed, these are absolutely important matters. Prioritisation in Government expenditure and allocation is very important. They can decide to allocate money to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs to pursue their foreign policy initiatives, including the STRIDE initiative, the e-visa, and the passport initiatives they want to engage in. In the Minister's own words, he said that he has a big vision, but he does not have the money to carry out other visions. The Minister for Foreign Affairs has been very vociferous on private jets and presidential jets. The season has not changed. Let us stick to the principle. Come on, support me. Let us call on the Government to drop one presidential jet, drop two helicopters, and they will have money to fund you.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I support the request to this House to allocate the sum of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, headed by my good Friend, Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let me give the lady the opportunity; Ms Felicia Adjei.

Ms Felicia Adjei (NDC — Kintampo South): Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to add my voice to the approval of the budget for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

Mr Speaker, I am so happy today because, looking at the things that the Minister is doing and has already done, we cannot get this anywhere. First of all, we all know I come from Kintampo South, and all that we do a lot is to travel. Now, the passport is GH¢350. Before, when one wanted a passport, it took about three or four months, and people took our money. We do not even see them. Now, we can be at home, and the passport will be delivered to us. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, look at all the opportunities that our able Minister is doing for us. We want to travel. Now, we have Jordan, Barbados, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates. I would like to thank His Excellency John Dramani Mahama and our Hon Minister for all the good things that they are doing for us at the Ministry, too.

Because of that, I support the Motion for the House to approve GH¢1,696,321,803.00. Mr Speaker, I thank you for the opportunity.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I will go to Mr Asafo-Adjei, then I will come to the Leadership.

Nana Asafo-Adjei Ayeh (NPP — Bosome Freho): Mr Speaker, I want to urge the House to approve the sum of

GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. In so doing, I want to make reference to the Report and say that your Committee did a very good job.

5:54 p.m.

Mr Speaker, on page 22, if you look at the outlook for 2026, you will see a lot of initiatives and a lot of activities or programmes that your Committee, through the Ministry, would be embarking on. The introduction of e-visa system, the establishment of new diplomatic missions, the implementation of strategic transition for renting of infrastructure, and all that; it is about 15 different programmes that have been earmarked. I want to urge that these are very important programmes that need to be looked at, and we must, as a House, commend it.

Mr Speaker, when you go to paragraph 10.3, you would notice that it discussed an issue of revenue enhancement measure. Under the Revenue Enhancement Measure, we can see ‘commercialisation of mobile passport enrolment equipment’. The second one is, “...establishment of a premium passport service centre, including the rollout of a 24-hour expedited passport service, priced at GH¢2,000.”

The Committee feels like a student going to a state-assisted school, yet the teacher is teaching at a private school. They are rather placing more efficiency on a product that people will get at a higher price. Meanwhile, when they pay the other normal passport application

fees, they will not. We urge the Ministry to pay critical attention to this policy, or this premium pricing, where a person has to pay GHC2,000 to have an expedited passport application, which will take the person 24 hours. Yet, when we pay the GHC350, we go through the normal procedure. Then attention and efficiency will be given to the GHC2,000 rather than the GHC350. Just like I mentioned, it is like a teacher who is teaching at a government-assisted school, and yet doing extra classes at a private school. It is important we pay critical attention to it.

Now, we come to the same revenue enhancement measure, point 3, “reduction in passport processing fees from 500 to 350”. The intention is that it is going to increase the volume of application, thereby enhancing revenue. We beg to differ on this. I have the Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, 2023, where the Committee considered the price component and price input, or the price build-up for the cost of passport, which was why the passport was priced at GHC500. Mr Speaker, as of that time, it was not a chip-embedded passport. It does not even have the International Civil Aviation Organization (ICAO) advanced features that it has now. Even then, the price of the passport was GHC500. Now, the price has been reduced from GHC500 to GHC300.

The striking point is that when you go to paragraph 9.3, passport administration, you would see that despite the growing national demand for passport servicing and continual reform in passport delivery

ecosystem, passport administration received the smallest share of the Ministry’s budget, 6.9 per cent. The Committee is concerned that this limited allocation may constrain the planned services improvement, which include system upgrade, regional expansion of passport centres, processing efficiency reform, and backlog clearance.

Mr Speaker, it is clear that the money earmarked for the passport processing is even small. Again, the cost of the passport is not even met, and that is another issue. Now, I do not know what went into the discussion, because the announcement of the passport was done in February or March when the Minister appeared here. It is critical that we look at some of these things so that we do not put heavy burden on the Government purse and the Ministry, only to come back in statements like these to complain of the money not being enough for processing.

Mr Speaker, I want to conclude by commending the Minister for the initiative. It is a good thing. What I would beg is that we should not necessarily look at the wholesale or giving the entire missions that we have at a go. If we can do 10 Missions or 20 Missions effectively, then we can look at the timelines, plan, and look at it well than going all wholesale when we may not be able to even take care, looking at the releases and the disbursement issues that are going on.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to recommend and urge the approval of the sum requested by the

Ministry, GHC1,696,321,803.00 for the efficient performance of the Ministry.

Mr Speaker, I thank you.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Leadership?

Alhaji Habib Iddrisu: Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to comment on the approval of the Budget Estimate for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. As much as we support that the Ministry should be given enough resources, the Minister, when he was the Ranking Member for the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, there were a number of things that were captured in this Report that he was openly against. For example, the structural integrity of the “Pink Lady”. Openly, when the Minority Chief Whip was the Chair of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration, on structural issues, the Minister was not in support of it. Other new missions that we wanted to open, like in Mexico, when it was suggested, he thought that taxpayers’ money was not going to be put in the right direction. At the moment, he is the Minister for Foreign Affairs and he is caught up on the reality. Just as he is now silent on presidential jets, renting of the jets, when it is taking off, how much it costs, and other things.

Now, we think that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs needs to be resourced. The Ministry asked for over GHC3 billion, yet it was given less than 50 per cent of what they asked for. But majority of the money, over GHC13 billion is

going to be used to buy four helicopters and two luxury jets; one long range and one medium range. The Minister has said nothing about it. But he was rather very vocal that the President was flying first class. We think that this money should not be given—*[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, technically, the Chairperson of the Committee on Defence and Interior is distracting the Minister for Foreign Affairs so that he will not listen to the fact that the four helicopters and the two luxury jets that they will buy, should be cancelled and part of the money be given to the Minister for Foreign Affairs. However, the Minister has been very quiet on the luxury jets and the helicopters. Meanwhile, they have only allocated less than 50 per cent of what the Minister has requested for.

Mr Speaker, in moving forward, I just want to draw the attention of the Minister for Foreign Affairs that any time he ever finds himself here in 2029, he should know that in future, posterity will judge him, just like how he was against the renovation of the “Pink Lady”; just like how he was against the establishment of the Norway Embassy mission and that of Mexico. He is justifying Mexico mission for the World Cup, but who said that Ghana is going to be in Mexico? If you let Ghanaians hear and know that you are thinking that we are going to be in Mexico— Their plans are either in United States of America (USA) or Canada, not Mexico.

So, if the Minister’s thinking is that we are opening a Mission in Mexico so

that Ghana team will be in Mexico, Ghanaians will not forgive him, and I will join them. Mr Speaker, we want to go to Canada or USA to watch our players, but not Mexico. However, the Minister for Foreign Affairs is thinking that Ghanaians are going to be in Mexico, and for that matter, he wants to open a mission.

Mr Speaker, with that much, I support the approval of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and that they should cancel some of the presidential jets and give it to the Ministry. Also, the Minister should make a Statement on the buying of the jets. He should make a Statement on it.

These jets, how much, and how are they? He should say something about it.

6:04 p.m.

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you, Mr Speaker. I must say that I have really enjoyed the very lively debate. Really, this is one of the things I miss since becoming the Minister for Foreign Affairs. Because of the enormous international commitment, I am not able to be in the Chamber as frequently as I would really wish. But I must say that today I have enjoyed the debate.

Just to assure the First Deputy Minority Whip that he can be certain that if President John Dramani Mahama starts or even attempts to charter ultra-luxury jets, like his predecessor did, the Hon Member will certainly hear my voice. He is not hearing my voice now because what I used to complain about is

not happening; it is as simple as that. [*Hear! Hear!*] President Mahama is flying commercial.

Indeed, the amount of money, if we listened carefully to the analysis the Minister for Finance has done, the Hon Ato Forson contends that the expenditure item he has met at the Ministry of Finance for the former President Akufo-Addo's chartered jets could have bought us a brand-new jet. So, they should be commending me and actually apologising to the people of this country that we should have listened to the Ranking Member at the time. If President Akufo-Addo had listened to the Hon Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa, we would not have wasted resources as we have done.

President Mahama has now put us on a prudent path where instead of just chartering and wasting taxpayer resources, he is rather going to engage in an investment that will serve the Ghana Armed Forces well. So please, they should not score own goals. It is not in their interest.

Mr Speaker, on the matter of STRIDE, the Ranking Member has raised issues with value for money. I want to assure the House that STRIDE will ensure value for money; it will be done transparently; and there will be absolute consciousness on making sure that every penny of taxpayer resources is properly accounted for. As we speak, Mr Speaker, we have the unacceptable situation where we are spending US\$15 million every year on renting across the 72 countries where we have diplomatic presence. That is not prudent use of taxpayer resources.

That is why we are saying that instead of these rentals – it is just the same principle. Instead of chartering ultra-lightweight jets and not owning the jets, we are now buying to own. On that same principle, we are now going to own our own properties abroad so that we do not spend US\$15 million every year taking care of landlords.

Now, Mr Speaker, on the Accra International Conference Centre, again, the records are here; *Hansard* will bear me out. I was opposed to demolishing the Accra International Conference Centre, I was not opposed to renovation. What the 2026 budget promises to do is renovation. The structural integrity report, which was done by Architectural and Engineering Services Limited (AESL), says that we can salvage the building. So, we are going to renovate it; we are not going to demolish. So, they should check their records very well.

Again, they should be commending me. They did not do a structural integrity and yet they are proceeding to demolish. So, this Side of the House, again, has saved an important national asset for our country. That is how we protect the public purse; that is value for money.

Mr Speaker, on passport administration reforms, I want to assure the entire nation that our passport reforms are working. Ghanaians are testifying. Now, when we pay the 30 per cent reduced fee from GH¢500 to GH¢350 – and I agree with Hon Asafo-Adjei, we can see that he is confounded. How can we introduce modern International Civil Aviation Organization

(ICAO)-compliant, chip embedded passports, introduce e-tracking, courier service, delivery under 15 days, and yet we reduced it. When Ghanaians say, *aban papa aba*, this is what it means. So, we are delivering better quality, and yet it is more affordable than previously. So, we can trust the President Mahama administration.

Finally, Mr Speaker, on World Cup, this is very important. Mr Speaker, I know you will be happy to hear this. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs wishes to assure the nation that we are negotiating very good terms, where, as Members of Parliament, all of us should be excited about this, that our constituents will have good representation at the World Cup. We will make sure that all Ghanaian soccer fans, regardless of political polarisation, how they vote, which part of the country they come from, will have full representation.

We will make sure that Ghanaian soccer fans all over the country, irrespective of political persuasion will have some good presence at the World Cup. [*Hear! Hear!*] We are all looking forward to the draw on Friday, December 5th, and we hope that wherever Ghana is camped, we will put in place the needed consular arrangements to ensure that Ghanaian soccer fans are well protected.

I thank Hon Members for their support, and they can count on us to continue to enhance the image of our country and to pursue a foreign policy arrangement which is in the best interest of our country. We shall always make sure that national interest is at the centre

of every decision we take in our foreign policy. Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr S. Jinapor: Mr Speaker, as a Ranking Member of the Committee, and this House being a House of records, I thank you for the opportunity to set a few records straight in this Report.

The Minister has made reference to the Accra International Conference Centre. First of all, the point I made which was corroborated by the First Deputy Minority Whip, was that the Minister is on record to have said that if his Government were to make any attempt to purchase a presidential jet, he would resign; that is the principle. Secondly, the Minister is also on record to have said that if his Government chartered a presidential jet, he would resign. This House is a House of records.

The Vice President, Professor Jane Nana Opoku-Agyemang chartered a presidential jet from London to Accra. The Minister did not resign. Mr Speaker, in addition, let me point out once again that the point that the First Deputy Minority Whip made, was that when the then Minister for Foreign Affairs—

Question put and Motion agreed to Resolved:

That this honourable House approved the sum of GH¢1,696,321,803.00 for the services of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for the year ending 31st December 2026.

6:14 p.m. — *Sitting suspended.*

6:26 p.m. — *Sitting resumed.*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: We have available Leaders, so we can move on.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, may I seek your leave so that we go to the *Order Paper Addendum* and take the item numbered 2—Presentation of Papers and First Reading of Bills. I know my Eastern Brother would not have a problem with this.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I have two *Addendum* Papers. Is it the original *Addendum* Paper or *Addendum* Paper 2?

Mr Ampem: *Addendum* Paper 2. I have duly consulted the Minority Chief Whip on the other Side.

Mr Annoh-Domporeh: Mr Speaker, eventually, we would get there, so there is no problem with that. However, the original *Order Paper*, the Majority Chief Whip had earlier indicated that there are some Papers that the Attorney-General's Department has to lay. The Deputy Attorney-General has been sitting for some time, so I think we should rather lay those Papers. Then we can go ahead and take *Order Paper Addendum*.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, I do not have a problem. These are quick items. So, we can go to the main *Order Paper* for today and take the items numbered 9 (b), (c), (d) and (e).

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Which one? The item numbered 9(a) is for Minister for Education.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, those for the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice, that is the items numbered 9 (b), (c), (d), and (e). As was done earlier, the learned Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is not around, so we seek your leave to allow his Deputy to lay the Papers on his behalf. Thank you.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, we are not opposed to the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice laying the Businesses mentioned. However, I want to invoke Order 97(3) and demand that the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice gives an explanatory statement on each of the items he is billed to lay.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: It is not necessarily a statement, just a reason behind the Bill.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Order 97(3) is clear. If the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice has rightly been given the powers by the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, he must be clothed with the powers given.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I understand you, but when you say statement, it becomes a bit —

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He understands. He can do it; it is not beyond him.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, let me invite you to page 10, item listed 9—Presentation of Papers and First Reading. We would step down the (a), and move to (b), (c), (d), and (e). Attorney-General and Minister for Justice, what you do is just bow, then afterwards, you would give us the reason behind all these Bills. Is that okay for you?

Mr Srem-Sai: Yes.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minister, so you have to give us a brief reason behind the 24-Hour Economy Authority Bill, 2025, Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025, Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025, and Interstate Succession Bill, 2025.

Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Mr Justice Srem-Sai): Mr Speaker, in respect of the 24-Hour Economy Authority Bill, 2025, it is a Bill to establish a 24-Hour Economy Authority and related matters. In respect of the Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025, it is a Bill to regulate legal education in the country. Basically, the Bill would transfer the legal education programmes in the current Ghana School of Law to the universities based on accreditation.

Mr Speaker, on the Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025, it is intended to create the regulatory framework for the Governance Advisory Council. It would create membership and also the functions of the Council. Finally, in respect of the Interstate Succession Bill, 2025, it is intended to repeal the current Interstate Succession Law and related matters.

Mr Speaker, thank you very much.
[Hear! Hear!]

BILLS — FIRST READING

24-Hour Economy Authority Bill, 2025

AN ACT to establish the 24-Hour Economy Authority to implement the 24-Hour Economy and accelerated expo development programme and provide for related matters.

Presented by the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Mr Justice Srem-Sai) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs.

[REFER TO APPENDIX 1]

Legal Education Reform Bill, 2025

AN ACT to establish the Council for Legal Education and Training to regulate legal education in the country, provided for the curriculum and standards for the education, and provide for related matters.

Presented by the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Mr Justice Srem-Sai) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs and the Leadership for the Committee on Education.

[REFER TO APPENDIX 2]

Governance Advisory Council Bill, 2025

AN ACT to establish the Governance Advisory Council as a non-partisan Body to facilitate and enhance accountability and responsible governance by promoting collaboration among governance institutions, coordinating and strengthening multi-stakeholder engagement, providing advisory support and strategic oversight, making evidence-based policy recommendations, monitoring governance performance, and fostering open participation democracy, and to provide for related matters.

Presented by the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Mr Justice Srem-Sai) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs.

[REFER TO APPENDIX 3]

Interstate Succession Bill, 2025

AN ACT to provide for interstate succession and for related matters.

Presented by the Deputy Attorney-General and Deputy Minister for Justice (Mr Justice Srem-Sai) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs.

[REFER TO APPENDIX 4]

6:36 p.m.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, I humbly request that we move to the *Order Paper Addendum 2* and take the item numbered 2, Presentation and First Reading of Bills.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is it 1 or 2?

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, we can start from 1.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, the Deputy Minister has been impressive for the fleeting period he sat at the Frontbench. He should consider swapping serving in the Executive with Hon Acheampong. *[Laughter]* That is free advice. He is doing it well, and one would wonder if he has been in Leadership for a while. Move from the Ministry and come and join us here.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, so we go to Presentation of Papers. The Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs is here, so we can take those before we move to the item numbered 2.

PAPERS

By the Minister for Foreign Affairs—

- (i) Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the Republic of Angola on the Waiver of Visa Requirements for Holders of Diplomatic and Service Passports.

- (ii) Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the Republic of Serbia on the Abolition of Visa Requirements for Holders of Diplomatic and Official (Service) Passports.

- (iii) Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the People's Democratic Republic of Algeria on the Waiver of Visa Requirements for Holders of Diplomatic and Service Passports.

- (iv) Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar Concerning the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar.

- (v) Headquarters Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and Afrobarometer.

Referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: In this House, the practice has been that if it is the pleasure of the Member laying the Paper, that he bows once and then the long title

is read, an application must be made to the Chair. I have nothing against my Minister for Foreign Affairs, but he only bowed once. And I heard the Table reading the whole—They cannot do that. Either he bows for each of the Papers or the Leadership makes an application to the chair and then we can consider it. That is how it should be done.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. That is right, so long as it is not in respect of one Paper.

Mr Ampem: Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Foreign Affairs does not have any waist problem, so he does not mind getting up to bow at the mention of each Paper. *[Laughter]* So, he can do that.

Thank you.

Mr First Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister do you mind explaining what is meant by “headquarters agreement”? I do not understand it. Can you explain it to me first?

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, what “Headquarters Agreement” means is that we will be hosting the Secretariat. So, Ghana is going to host the Afrobarometer Secretariat.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Hon Members, the Papers have been laid hereby referred to the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration for consideration and report.

We now turn to item 1 (b) in the name of the Minister for Defence. So, the Deputy Minister for Defence will do as the honours. I have already taken the plea.

PAPERS

By the Deputy Minister for Defence (Mr Ernest Brogya Genfi) on behalf of the Minister for Defence—

- (i) Contract Agreement between Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Airbus Helicopter (SAS), France, for an amount of One Hundred and Twenty-Five Million, Nine Hundred and Sixty-Five Thousand, Nine Hundred and Seventy-Four Euros €125,965,974.00 for the supply of One (1) H160 and Three (3) H175 Helicopters for the Ghana Air Force.
- (ii) Sale and Purchase Contract Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Defence) and Dassault Aviation, France, for an amount of Sixty Million, Six Hundred and Eighty Thousand United States Dollars (US\$60,680,000.00) for the acquisition of One (1) Falcon 6X for the Ghana Air Force.

Referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior and the Finance Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Brogya Genfi, the Hon Minority Chief Whip says you did not bow well. Hon Dafeamekpor, you just came in. Take it easy.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Yes, Mr Speaker, I have taken it easy. I have been trying to find out from the Hon Minority Chief what the formula for bowing is. Because he has been insisting that we do not bow well. Even if you bow and your head touches the floor, he says you have not bowed well. *[Laughter]*

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Brogya Genfi, bow again for us. *[Laughter]*

Hon Members, may I be guided. Is the referral going to the Committee on Defence and Interior, and Finance Committee as a joint referral?

Mr Ampem: Yes, Mr Speaker.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. Hon Members, the contract agreements are referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior, and Finance Committee for consideration and report.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the leadership of Finance Committee should join the Committee on Defence and Interior for the consideration.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I think I am in support.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well. So, it is referred to the Committee on Defence and Interior, but the leadership, which is the Chairperson, the Vice-Chairperson, the Ranking Member, and the Deputy Ranking Member should join the Committee on Defence and Interior.

6:46 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I think that the contract agreement must go to the Committee on Defence, which is b(i). Then, the sale and purchase contract agreement must go to the Finance Committee.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, the first one, which is “i”, will go to the Finance Committee, and that will be assisted by the Leadership of the Committee on Defence and Interior.

The second one, which is “ii”, will go to the Committee on Defence, and they will be supported by the Leadership of the Finance Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, you got it right, but it is rather the other way round. The b(i) should go to Defence with the Leadership of the Finance Committee. And the b(ii) will go to the Finance Committee with the Leadership of the Committee on Defence.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, when we sit here, our principal advisors are the Clerks. And the advice from the Clerk is that all of them should go to the Committee on Defence and Interior, and will be supported by the Leadership of the Finance Committee. I so direct.

Now, let us go to the item numbered 1(c) by the Minister for Finance.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I have not seen the Minister for Finance ever since he presented the Budget Statement and Economy Policy.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we will clarify the issue of the referral in the item numbered “b”. So, we advise that it should all go to the Committee on Defence, with the Leadership of the Finance Committee joining them to consider the two of them and report.

Now, in respect of “c”, the Minister for Finance was here, but he has been called into another meeting with my Leader. That is why my Leader is not here. It is all about welfare matters. He has been very persistent about this matter, and the year is coming to an end. The Deputy has been here with us since morning, so I want to pray you so he takes this on behalf of his boss.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We have no objection. All we were seeking was for him to do the appropriate thing. Once he seeks the leave of the Chair, we will allow him. He is one of our own.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Very well, the application is granted. Deputy Minister, let us move on.

By the Minister for Finance —

Indicative Debt Treatment Menus between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Finance) and individual commercial lenders for the restructuring of the outstanding Commercial Debt of Two Billion, Seven Hundred Million United States Dollars (US\$2,700,000,000.00).

Referred to the Finance Committee and the Committee on Economy and Development.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Let us move on to the item numbered 1(d), by the Chairperson of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: He is not the Chairperson; he should make the appropriate submission.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, there is an existing protocol. He allowed the man on the existing protocol to present the Committee’s Report. It is weightier than having laid this Paper.

Mr Speaker, application repeated. In the absence of the Chairperson—

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Application granted.

By the Chairperson of the Committee

Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration on the Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I rely on the existing protocols to pray that the Deputy Minister for Finance takes this on behalf of the Minister for Finance.

BILL — FIRST READING

Petroleum Revenue Management (Amendment) (No. 2) Bill, 2025.

An Act to amend the Petroleum Revenue Management Act 2011, (Act 815) to expand the definition of qualifying instrument to include other qualifying instruments prescribed by the Minister by Executive Instruments.

Presented by the Deputy Minister for Finance (Mr Thomas Nyarko Ampem) on behalf of the Minister for Finance. Read the First time; referred to the Committee on Finance.

[REFER TO APPENDIX 5]

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, let me vary this and take you to the *Order Paper Addendum* to lay the items numbered 1(a) and (b) to lay those Papers.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: The Majority Chief Whip is leading Government

Business, and I have no issue. I thought that when we laid the Qatar agreement, we could proceed to take the procedural Motion and then take the substantive Motion. In this way, we will move forward. But if he wants to lay this, then we are not opposed.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, let us turn to the original *Order Paper Addendum*. The items numbered 1 (a) and (b), by the Chairperson of the Committee.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, for Independent Constitutional Bodies, it is by the Leader of the House. So I seek your leave to do this on his behalf. But a Member of the Committee will present the Reports on his behalf.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Report presentation will not come in. You are just laying a Paper.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, I am just giving an indication that he has instructions that in the event that we are ready to take the Report after laying. The Acting Chairperson, that is how he calls him, will present the Report.

6:56 p.m.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, he is seeking to lay the items numbered 1 (a) and (b). Alright. *[Laughter]*

PAPERS

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Independent Constitutional Bodies on the Annual Budget Estimates of the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE) for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

By the Majority Chief Whip on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee —

Report of the Committee on Constitutional and Legal Affairs on the Annual Budget Estimates of the Office of the Attorney-General and Ministry of Justice for the year ending 31st December, 2026.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, now let me meet the desires of my Friend and Brother, the Minority Chief Whip, and pray that we take the Motion numbered 3 on the *Order Paper Addendum 2*, standing in the name of the Chairperson of the Committee. However, invoking the existing protocols, I pray that the Vice Chairperson does this on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee. I thank you.

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee: Mr Speaker, we are presenting this report for this House to approve the mobility agreement. This mobility agreement is between Government of Ghana and the state of Qatar. Most often, our citizens go to Qatar to work under very bad conditions.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You should move the Procedural Motion first.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Move the Procedural Motion for the House to take a decision on it before you go to the substantive matter. That is why he is not the Chairperson.

Mr Speaker, it is not with any malice, so respectfully— But, I know one day he will be a Chairperson. So I withdraw the comment made, my good Friend.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: You should take some of these things lightly, please.

MOTION

Suspension of Order 104 (1)

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah) on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee: Mr Speaker, I beg to move:

That notwithstanding the provision of Order 104(1) of the Standing Orders which requires that a motion shall not be debated until at least two sitting days have elapsed after the notice to move the motion is given, the motion for the adoption of the Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration on the Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar may be moved today.

Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor): Mr Speaker, I rise to second the motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Now, let us take the substantive Motion.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we take the Motion numbered 4.

Bilateral Agreement between GoG and Qatar on Regulation of Manpower Employment

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah) *on behalf of the Chairperson of the Committee:* Mr Speaker, I beg *move*:

That this honourable House adopts Report of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration on the Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar.

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion and in doing so present the Report of your Committee. I urge *Hansard* to capture the report in its entirety.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

This Report presents the findings of the Committee on Foreign Affairs on the request for Parliamentary approval of the *Bilateral Labour Mobility Agreement between the Government of the Republic*

of Ghana and the Government of the State of Qatar, signed in November 2018. The Agreement establishes a legal and regulatory framework for the recruitment, employment, protection, and welfare of Ghanaian migrant workers in Qatar. It seeks to ensure ethical recruitment standards, protect Ghanaian workers from abuse, uphold their rights under Qatari law, and prevent labour exploitation and human trafficking.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs, during its presentation to the Committee, provided detailed explanations on the objectives, content, safeguards, and operational responsibilities of the Agreement. The Ministry emphasised that past abuses suffered by Ghanaian migrant workers particularly domestic workers in the Gulf resulted largely from unregulated private recruitment, a point strongly reinforced by Members during Committee deliberations.

The Agreement provides for:

- Licensed recruitment agencies in both countries;
- Fair labour standards, including regulated working hours and adequate accommodation;
- Mandatory written employment contracts in languages workers understand;
- Protection from forced labour and passport confiscation;
- Guaranteed repatriation rights;

- A Joint Technical Committee responsible for oversight, monitoring, and dispute resolution;
- Full alignment with international frameworks such as the ILO Fair Recruitment Guidelines and the Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration.

Members raised concerns about past abuses, the competence of Ghanaian agencies, and the need for strict regulation. The Ministry assured Members that the Agreement introduces robust safeguards, including strict licensing, monitoring mechanisms, and a structured return and reintegration framework.

After an exhaustive review, the Committee is convinced that the Agreement will significantly enhance worker protection, ethical recruitment, and bilateral cooperation. The Committee therefore recommends to the House to adopt this Report and to approve, by resolution, the ratification of the Agreement.

Deliberations

The Committee met with the Hon. Minister for Foreign Affairs, the Deputy Director of the Legal and Treaties Bureau, Directors of the Ministry, and other officials. The Ministry's presentation was based on the official Cabinet submission, the legal text of the Agreement, and the Ministry's comprehensive briefing to the Committee on Visa Waiver and Labour Mobility Agreements.

During the deliberations, the Ministry emphasised:

1. The Agreement was negotiated to curb unregulated labour migration and protect Ghanaian workers from abuse, exploitation, and trafficking.
2. The Agreement is anchored in the ILO Fair Recruitment Guidelines, the Global Compact on Migration, and Ghana's domestic labour laws.
3. Qatar has undertaken significant labour reforms, including abolishing the *kafala* (tied sponsorship) system, strengthening worker protections, and regulating recruitment agencies.
4. The Agreement establishes clear procedures for recruitment, employment conditions, dispute resolution, and repatriation.

Members raised concerns about:

- Past abuses of Ghanaian domestic workers in the Gulf;
- The need for stricter oversight of Ghanaian recruitment agencies;
- Enforcement of anti-passport seizure provisions;
- Ensuring the dignity, safety, and welfare of Ghanaian workers abroad.

The Minister assured Members that:

- Only licensed agencies will be permitted to recruit under this Agreement;
- Recruitment will no longer rely on online or informal middlemen, which have historically facilitated trafficking;
- Workers' passports cannot be seized, and employers will be subject to sanctions under Qatari law;
- A Joint Monitoring Committee will provide continuous oversight;
- Workers will have guaranteed repatriation rights, funded by employers unless otherwise agreed lawfully.

The Committee expressed strong support for the Agreement, noting its potential to protect Ghanaian workers and eliminate exploitation.

Reference Documents

The Committee consulted:

1. 1992 Constitution of Ghana, Article 75(1) & (2)(b)
2. Labour Act, 2003 (Act 651)
3. Bilateral Labour Mobility Agreement (2018)
4. ILO General Principles and Operational Guidelines for Fair Recruitment

5. Global Compact for Safe, Orderly and Regular Migration (2018)

6. Ministry of Foreign Affairs Presentation on Visa Waiver and Labour Agreements

7. Stakeholder correspondence, internal briefs, and legal opinions

Background

On Wednesday, 3rd December, 2025 the Hon. Minister for Foreign Affairs laid before Parliament the Bilateral Labour Mobility Agreement between Ghana and Qatar pursuant to Article 75(2)(b) of the 1992 Constitution. The Rt. Hon. Speaker referred the Agreement to the Committee on Foreign Affairs for detailed consideration and report.

Over the past decade, large numbers of Ghanaians have sought employment in the Gulf region. While the Gulf offers significant employment opportunities, the absence of a structured, government-to-government labour agreement exposed Ghanaian workers especially domestic workers to severe abuses, including:

- Passport confiscation;
- Withholding of wages;
- Overwork and unsafe conditions;
- Physical abuse;
- Human trafficking;
- Forced labour.

Members of the Committee acknowledged these concerns during deliberations and urged the Ministry to ensure the Agreement effectively protects Ghanaian workers.

The Ministry informed the Committee that previous abuses stemmed from unregulated recruitment, and that the Agreement seeks to:

- Eliminate unlicensed agents and middlemen,
- Promote ethical recruitment,
- Strengthen labour and human rights protection, and
- Establish a transparent and enforceable framework for recruitment and employment.

Qatar, on its part, has undertaken major labour reforms including:

- Abolition of the *kafala* system,
- Introduction of a minimum wage,
- Reinforcement of laws against passport confiscation,
- Mandatory written contracts,
- Stronger labour inspection mechanisms.

These reforms create an improved environment for regulated labour mobility.

Objectives of The Agreement

The Agreement seeks to:

1. Establish a regulated framework for ethical recruitment and employment of Ghanaian workers in Qatar.
2. Protect the rights, welfare,
3. dignity, and safety of Ghanaian workers.
4. Ensure that recruitment is undertaken only by licensed and authorised agencies.
5. Provide mechanisms for monitoring, inspection, dispute resolution, and termination of contracts.
6. Promote bilateral cooperation in labour, social protection, and migrant worker rights.
7. Facilitate safe return and reintegration of workers.

Key Provisions of the Agreement

The Agreement includes provisions on:

Recruitment Standards

- Recruitment must be conducted only by licensed agencies in both countries.
- Agencies must comply with Ghana's labour laws, ILO guidelines, and Qatar's recruitment regulations.

- No unregistered online or private middlemen may operate under this Agreement.

- Unresolved cases may be escalated to the Joint Technical Committee.

Employment Contracts

Contracts must:

- Be written in languages workers understand;
- Specify wages, duties, rest days, accommodation, meals, repatriation, and termination rules;
- Be signed before departure and lodged with authorities in both countries.

Repatriation

- Workers whose contracts expire or terminate lawfully must be returned home at the employer's expense, unless otherwise provided in their contract.
- This was emphasised by Members seeking reassurance during the Committee meeting.

Joint Technical Committee

A Joint Committee comprising:

- Ghana's Ministry of Employment
- Ministry of Foreign Affairs (Middle East Bureau & Consular Bureau)
- Qatar's Ministry of Labour

This body will:

- Monitor implementation;
- Address grievances;
- Recommend reforms;
- Ensure compliance with ethical recruitment standards.

Worker Protection

Workers will enjoy:

- Fair pay under Qatari labour law;
- Regulated working hours and rest periods;
- Safe and decent accommodation;
- Protection against forced labour, trafficking, and harassment;
- Protection from passport confiscation, which is illegal under Qatari law.

Dispute Resolution

- Employers and employees must resolve disputes through designated mechanisms under Qatari law.

Legal Implications

The Agreement:

- Satisfies Article 75(2)(b) of the Constitution;
- Does not require new legislation;
- Aligns with Ghana's Labour Act (Act 651);
- Is consistent with ILO conventions and the Global Compact on Migration;
- Offers no legal liabilities to the State.

Justification

The Ministry justified the Agreement on the following grounds:

Protection of Ghanaian Workers

The Ministry explained that one of the core motivations for entering into the Agreement is to provide comprehensive legal safeguards for Ghanaian workers deployed to Qatar. In the past, many Ghanaian migrants suffered abuse, exploitation, and confiscation of passports because their recruitment and employment were conducted through unregulated private intermediaries. The Agreement clearly establishes the rights and responsibilities of employers, workers, and both governments, thereby creating enforceable protections that were previously absent. It ensures that Ghanaian workers operate within a regulated framework that guarantees safety, respect, and accountability.

Elimination of Illegal Recruitment

A major justification advanced by the Ministry was the need to eliminate the influence of illegal online agents, fraudulent travel schemes, and human trafficking networks that have long targeted vulnerable young people desperate for opportunities abroad. Under the Agreement, only licensed recruitment agencies approved by the Ministry of Employment and Labour Relations may participate in the recruitment process. This significantly narrows the space for criminal intermediaries and ensures that all recruitment activities are transparent, traceable, and subject to governmental oversight.

Strengthened Bilateral Relations

The Ministry further indicated that Qatar remains one of the most significant labour destinations for skilled and unskilled workers across West Africa and beyond. The Agreement therefore presents a strategic opportunity for Ghana to deepen its economic and diplomatic ties with Qatar, building upon existing cooperation in trade, investment, and international affairs. Strengthening labour mobility is expected to facilitate improved collaboration, enhance people-to-people relations, and ensure Ghana's relevance in global labour market dynamics.

Alignment with International Standards

The Ministry emphasized that the Agreement is fully aligned with relevant International Labour Organization (ILO)

conventions, as well as broader international migrant protection standards. It incorporates modern principles of decent work, fair recruitment, human rights protection, and ethical employment. By embedding these international norms into the bilateral framework, the Agreement ensures that Ghana's engagements with Qatar reflect global best practices and uphold the dignity and welfare of Ghanaian workers.

Ethical and Safe Migration

The Ministry justified the Agreement as an essential tool for promoting ethical, orderly, and safe migration. The Agreement establishes structured processes for travel, employment, dispute resolution, and return, thereby preventing the chaotic and unsafe migration patterns that have historically endangered Ghanaian youth. It ensures that workers travel with clear contracts, documented rights, and guaranteed return arrangements. This enhances not only their safety and wellbeing but also the reputation of Ghana as a responsible partner in international labour mobility.

Options and Impact

Two options were considered:

Option 1: Ratify the Agreement

Ratification would:

- Activate a fully regulated labour mobility system;
- Protect Ghanaian workers from exploitation;

- Ensure transparent recruitment and employment processes;
- Build Ghana's reputation as a structured labour-exporting country;
- Encourage Qatar to prioritise Ghanaian workers;
- Prevent abuses associated with the previous unregulated system.

Option 2: Defer Ratification

Deferring ratification would:

- Leave Ghanaian workers vulnerable to unregulated recruitment;
- Signal hesitation in addressing known abuses;
- Prevent implementation before the President's official visit to Doha (as emphasised by the Minister);
- Delay needed protection mechanisms.

The Committee unanimously endorses Option 1: Ratification.

Financial Impact

The Committee notes that:

- The Agreement imposes no immediate cost on Government;
- Qatar covers workers' repatriation and some recruitment-related obligations;

- Implementation activities (oversight, awareness campaigns, stakeholder engagement) have been budgeted at GHS 100,000, including contract classification, public sensitisation, and media engagement.

Long-term benefits include:

- Increased remittances;
- Reduced exploitation and trafficking;
- Strengthened Ghana–Qatar cooperation.

Socio-Economic Impact

Ratification will:

- Enhance protection and welfare of Ghanaian migrant workers;
- Reduce human trafficking and exploitation;
- Increase foreign remittances;
- Improve access to decent employment opportunities abroad;
- Strengthen bilateral labour and economic cooperation;
- Promote public confidence in Ghana's labour migration governance.

Observations

Protection and Welfare of Ghanaian Migrant Workers

A major concern raised during deliberations related to the historical

experiences of exploitation and abuse suffered by Ghanaian domestic and low-skilled workers in parts of the Gulf region. The Committee acknowledged that such abuses have often occurred in environments where recruitment and employment activities were unregulated, dominated by private agents operating without the knowledge or approval of government authorities.

The Committee therefore observed with satisfaction that the Agreement introduces important safeguards to protect Ghanaian workers, including: regulated recruitment procedures; structured return and reintegration arrangements; and increased government oversight in both Ghana and Qatar. The Committee noted that regulated, government-to-government labour mobility essential for ensuring fair treatment, safety, and dignity for Ghanaian workers abroad.

Regulation of Recruitment Agencies

The Committee observed that effective implementation of the Agreement will depend significantly on the proper licensing and monitoring of recruitment agencies in Ghana. It was noted that many of the historical abuses experienced by Ghanaian migrant workers were facilitated by unlicensed private recruitment agencies that operated outside government regulation.

The Committee therefore emphasised the need for the Ministry of Employment and Labour Relations to maintain a publicly accessible list of licensed recruitment agencies and to intensify

public education so that potential migrants can distinguish legitimate agencies from illegal operators. The Committee also noted that Qatar has requested Ghana's official list of licensed agencies an indication that both countries recognize the need to eliminate the role of unregulated intermediaries.

Contract Expiry, Return, and Reintegration Arrangements

The Committee observed that the Agreement provides a clear framework for the return of migrant workers whose contracts expire and who do not enter into renewed employment. Under the Agreement, workers are expected to return to Ghana, and employers are generally responsible for providing return tickets unless otherwise agreed.

The Committee sought clarification on the phrase "unless otherwise stated," noting that desperate or uninformed migrant workers may be persuaded to waive employer-paid return tickets. The Committee therefore emphasized the need for Ghanaian authorities to ensure that such contractual waivers do not expose workers to financial vulnerability or abandonment.

The Committee also took note of Ghana's commitment to provide reintegration support for returning migrants. The Committee underscored the need for adequate institutional coordination among the Ministries responsible for Employment, Interior, Foreign Affairs, and Gender to ensure that returning workers are properly supported.

Implementation, Monitoring, and Review Mechanisms

The Committee observed the importance of the Joint Monitoring Committee provided under the Agreement. This mechanism will serve as the main platform for addressing emerging challenges, assessing the performance of recruitment agencies, ensuring worker protection, and recommending revisions where necessary.

The Committee noted that a well-functioning monitoring structure will ensure that the Agreement evolves to address new realities, protect migrant workers more effectively, and uphold Ghana's labour and human rights standards. The Committee encouraged the Ministry to ensure that all relevant stakeholders including Ghana's missions abroad are active participants in the monitoring process.

Conclusion and Recommendation

The Committee therefore recommends to the House to adopt this Report and to approve, by resolution, the ratification of the Bilateral Labour Mobility Agreement between the Government of Ghana and the Government of the State of Qatar, in accordance with Article 75(2)(b) of the 1992 Constitution.

Respectfully submitted.

Ranking Member of the Committee (Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor): Mr Speaker, I rise to support the Motion moved by the Vice Chairperson of the

Committee. I think the measures being put in place are long overdue, and we should welcome them. Indeed, the situation our compatriots get themselves in out there, particularly in countries like this, is one that we should all decry. I think it is useful that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is taking these measures to protect our compatriots who end up in such countries for greener pastures and for employment. A perusal of the Report will reveal that very specific and comprehensive measures are to be put in place to ensure that the safety, health and security of Ghanaian citizens who end up in Qatar are protected. Specifically, if we look at paragraph 5.0 on page 6, the objects of the agreement are spelled out and set out copiously.

7:06 p.m.

The intendment of this bilateral agreement is one which is noble and we should all support. Having said that, I think it is also important for all of us to admit and acknowledge that compatriots get out of their country for greener pastures, not because they do not wish to be in their homeland, but circumstances drive them out of their country.

Mr Speaker, migration is as old as Adam, and the driving forces of migration have always been principally due to lack of particularly, economic opportunities. This is why our compatriots travel through the desert, across oceans, and to faraway and dangerous places to seek economic opportunities. That is why this House has to be united to work together to ensure economic growth in our country, to

broaden the frontiers of economic opportunity and ensure that we create economic opportunity and employment for the teeming Ghanaian youth, so they will not see the need to travel out of our country to other countries for economic opportunities.

In this context, just welcoming that today we have, for example, laid the 24-Hour Economy Bill one year down the road. It is the hope of this Side of the House, that for the biggest issue in our country, which is unemployment, we will find a wherewithal to deal with it in our country and ensure that there is economic growth and that we have economic opportunities here in Ghana. This is so that Ghanaian youth will stay here and have the needed economic opportunity, and make their homeland truly their homeland.

Mr Speaker, with this, I support the Motion and I wish the Ministry of Foreign Affairs very well.

Mr Agbenyo: Mr Speaker, my Constituency is the republic of Guan, a republic within Ghana. Mr Speaker, thank you very much for the opportunity to support this particular Report by the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration to ratify the bilateral labour mobility agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana and the Government of the State of Qatar.

Mr Speaker, all of us have followed time without number, what happens to our people who travel across the world to seek greener pastures, especially those

who travel to the Gulf regions. The things that they go through – some of the videos and pictures that we have seen over the past years have been troubling. So when the Ministry brought this particular agreement that they want to streamline everything and make sure that before one moves to Qatar or anywhere in the Gulf region to work, they would go through licenced recruiting agencies, when they go there, all the labour laws will be respected, passports of persons who travel to these countries will no longer be confiscated, salaries paid to them will be agreed on, and when there are disputes, the appropriate laws will be deployed to resolve the issues.

Mr Speaker, I think it is welcoming that even as we train more young people, we give them skills and opportunities to the extent that our economy is not big enough to absorb all of them. So, it will be appropriate that as a nation, we streamline some of these things, so that even as they go out there to go and work, they would also be able to remit some money back into our country for our development. So, this is an agreement that I think is in a good stead.

I am sure we can look beyond just Qatar. There are several other countries that Ghanaians have travelled to seek greener pastures and there are challenges that they are going through in those countries. So, let all of us support this particular agreement between Ghana and Qatar. I believe that in the coming days, the Ministry will look at other nations and enter similar agreements with them, so that when we send our people over to work, at least, they will be treated with

the dignity and respect that they deserve as Ghanaians. Also, that they will work in an environment that they will be happy in, so that whenever they get money and remit back to this country, we can also use it to develop our country.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank you very much for the opportunity and thank the Minister and the Ministry for the good work they are doing for Mother Ghana.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, I want to commend the Minister for putting in motion such an important exercise, and the extent that the agreement has been brought to Parliament in line with the Constitution, is impressive. This House also owes us a duty to do the proper scrutiny.

Mr Speaker, the Report is a bit mute on criteria for recruiting agencies that are going to be involved. The numbers they are looking at is not clear and the skill sets they are looking at is not clear. I do know there are models across the world. What is this model fashioned along? I know we are not reinventing the wheel; it is not something that is new, it is done in the world. But I wish to know how we are fashioning ours so that this House can do a proper oversight. So, it is a welcomed news.

However, I hope that this will not become one of the vehicles that will become partisan. I said “I hope”. Let it be transparent, open, competitive, and all Ghanaians should have access. For me, that should be the ideal way we should go about recruitment, so that every

Ghanaian can have access. As long as a person has the skill set that is needed, then the person qualifies, regardless of their political affiliations. It may be early days, yes, but these are concerns that we have to bring up.

Hon Fred Agbenyo's concern about we extending it to other parts of the world is also a welcomed news. We should look at what we can do so that we are not concentrated only in the Middle East or just some section of the country. But it also depends on how this goes. This may be the first of its kind in the nature it looks, because we read news about health professionals being sent to other jurisdictions to work, but not in this form. So, we will support and urge the Minister to continue doing his good work, and Parliament, through the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration must follow up with an eagle eye.

I recall when I was the Chairperson of the Committee on Foreign Affairs and Regional Integration and the Minister was the Ranking Member, we got several reports of the inhumane treatment that were meted out to Ghanaians who, for various means, have found themselves outside the country. I am sure the Minister knows about this. So, it is a welcomed news and we encourage him to keep up. This House must also follow through to ensure our Ghanaian compatriots are treated with dignity.

In conclusion, I thought that this Report should have had as an appendix, a copy of the agreement as an exhibit. Because the Committee has dealt with it,

but has a responsibility to ferry same to Plenary. So, we have been denied access to the original copy of the agreement. That is when we can make a thorough deduction. Also, for the records, maybe the Table Office has copies, but we need copies of the original agreement, so that we can peruse it appropriately.

Having said that, I want to commend the Minister. Mr Speaker, if you may, direct that copies of the original agreement be made available to this House.

7:16 p.m.

Mr Dafeamekpor: It is an appendix to the mother Report, so that when *Hansard* captures it in its entirety, it would capture the Agreement itself, so that tomorrow it is easy to reference.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: So, my good Friend is trying to be my spokesperson, and he is collaborating with me. Mr Speaker, I think it is an important call, and also for the record, so that anybody who picks up the Report can have access to the original agreement.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Minister, kindly let the House get the original copy, so that we attached it to it. If you can say something, then we would conclude.

Mr Ablakwa: Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

I fully agree with the Majority Chief Whip that the Agreement should be made available, and indeed, the records should

reflect that the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has ferried a copy of the original Agreement to Parliament. So, Parliament has a copy of the Agreement. I am sure that our very dynamic and dedicated Clerks-at-the-Table would make copies available to all Members of Parliament. When Members of Parliament obtain copies of the original Agreement, they would be excited at the provisions. For example, article 9 of the original Agreement mandates that all employers in Qatar must sign contracts with every Ghanaian worker, so that their rights would be protected. And then article 10 of the mother Agreement also requires that all the workers from Ghana should be given accommodation. They should be given accommodation, medical and other allowances. It is all spelled out in this Agreement.

So, this is the first comprehensive, far-reaching, welfare-focused labour mobility Agreement that we are signing. Hitherto, we have been using Memoranda of Understanding (MoUs), which are not binding, and so employers take advantage of our compatriots. They violate their rights, and they do not even know how to assert their rights and where to go for remedy. All of that has been provided for in this Agreement.

Mr Speaker, I can confirm to the House that the Qatari Parliament has ratified theirs, so once we also ratify ours today under Article 75 of the 1992 Constitution, it comes into force, and it is binding. Only two weeks ago, I met with the Minister for Labour, Jobs and Employment in Qatar, and they gave us full assurances that once the Parliament

of Ghana ratifies this, it would come into force, and they are ready.

The Minority Chief Whip asked about some of the areas that this Agreement covers. I can confirm that the areas include health; that is, professional health workers, all the allied health workers, tourism, IT, transport, logistics, and engineering. All of these have been covered under the Agreement. And immediately, this is ratified tonight, we are moving into recruitment.

Let me assure the House that the recruitment would be done transparently. We are going to advertise, all young Ghanaians can apply, and it is going to be a very transparent and credible process. The nurses can confirm to you that the recruitments we have done for Grenada, Trinidad and Tobago, and Barbados, we created a portal, they applied openly, they went for interviews, and they were selected. So, I do not even know those who have been selected, who are going to these countries. All I do is negotiate, make sure that these Agreements meet basic tenets, that we are respecting the rights of Ghanaians, and that when they arrive in those countries, they would be protected. And the employers in those countries know that the government of Ghana is fully backing and really looking out for these workers. That is really my interest in this matter.

So, I can assure all Colleagues that please encourage your constituents to apply when this is ratified, and it is a very credible process. There are no fetters and angles of discrimination at all. Mr Speaker, let me thank Colleagues for

their bipartisan support, and I am looking forward to bringing to this House more of these labour mobility Agreements so that we can empower the young people of our country.

This is not brain drain at all; it is brain gain. They would be working under specific contracts. They would come back to help with our national growth and development, they would learn skills, they would have more resources, they would remit to our country, to our economy, and it is better than allowing an unregulated space where young people are forced to cross the Mediterranean, and lose their lives under very perilous and torturous circumstances. Let us regulate it and make it a win-win situation, as other countries have done.

Cuba has benefited a lot from this labour mobility arrangement. It is a major policy in the Philippines, and their citizens have benefited. So, we must also move towards that. That is a smart way of creating jobs and empowering the young people of our country.

I thank you very much, Mr Speaker.
[Hear! Hear!]

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, may you help us with Resolution 5.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: I know the Resolution is consequential.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Yes, consequential.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: But, Mr Speaker, look at the House. We are taking a Resolution. We do not want in the future anybody to initiate any process in court and challenge the numbers. Tomorrow morning, we can take the Resolution. Let us defer it. It is my humble submission. Let us turn it down. Tomorrow morning, we would get some good numbers and take it. It is not harmful.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: But the point is, we do not even get the numbers in the morning. So, the numbers we are having here, we may not even get it at the beginning of our Sitting tomorrow. So, we can take the Resolution and —

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, we are well constituted to take this. But if my Brothers on the other Side insist, we can take it tomorrow morning.

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: Mr Speaker, they can proceed. When I said he should proceed, he laughed. There are other things that he should be doing. He is not doing those things. My Backbench is not happy. His Backbench is equally not happy. There are empty seats here. The Majority Chief Whip is a hard-working Chief Whip. That one, we would not take it away from him. There are some basic things he must do. He should do those. But he can proceed and take the Resolution.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Minister, the green light is on, so you can take the Resolution.

RESOLUTION

Bilateral Agreement GoG and Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment

Minister for Foreign Affairs (Mr Samuel Okudzeto Ablakwa): Mr Speaker, I beg to *move*:

WHEREAS

By the provisions of Article 75 of the Constitution any treaty, agreement, or convention executed by or under the Authority of the President in the name of Ghana is made subject to ratification either by an Act of Parliament or by a resolution of Parliament supported by the votes of more than one-half of all the Members of Parliament.

In accordance with the said Article 75 of the Constitution, the President has caused to be laid before Parliament through the Minister responsible for Foreign Affairs, the Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar.

NOW THEREFORE, this honourable House hereby resolves to ratify the said Bilateral Agreement between the Government of the Republic of Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Foreign

Affairs) and the Government of the State of Qatar on the Regulation of Manpower Employment in the State of Qatar.

Vice Chairperson of the Committee (Mr Cletus Seidu Dapilah): Mr Speaker, I beg to second the Motion.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

Resolved accordingly.

7:26 p.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: I hope we have done enough for the day?

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, the reports of the Independent Constitutional Bodies are ready, that is the National Commission for Civic Education (NCCE), the Electoral Commission, the Media Commission, and I believe the Audit Service. Yes, the Motions are here, and the reports have been ready since yesterday. The Chairperson is my able Leader, and he is unavoidably absent.

So, first, we will take the Motion numbered —

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Whip, I have been here throughout the day, and it appears that tomorrow, I will be here alone.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, do not say more. We will call it a day. We have done nearly seven hours. So, we are entirely in your hands. Tomorrow will be

the last day of the week because Friday is Farmers' Day. We want to pray Members, so we start at 10:00 a.m., so that we can finish early for people to travel. If that is the indication of the House, we can do 10:00 a.m.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Is that the pleasure of the House, Leadership?

Mr Annoh-Dompreh: We will go by the 12 noon, but since the day we started taking the estimates, we have been exceedingly cooperative, and they will bear me out. Even when their Chairpersons were not there, we allowed them to lay Papers on their behalf. Mr Speaker, he must commend us for that. But tomorrow, it will not be like that. He should get his Chairpersons and Vice-Chairpersons to be here.

But I will commend the Majority Chief Whip because today, we have done more than five Motions. I think we have done about 10 Motions, which is impressive. In all, we have about 45 plus, inclusive of the Appropriation. That is about 45. The First day, we did five; today, we have done 10. Hopefully, tomorrow, based on the availability of reports, if we can do 10, then we are home and dry. So that we do not work deep into the night. It has its own health implications, but I will counsel that we get as many reports as possible, so that tomorrow, we can at least do 10 Motions and it will reduce the load of work at hand.

Mr Speaker, we engaged the Majority Chief Whip, he gave us a coded message, and we behaved accordingly. He has failed to meet us. I pray tomorrow, he

will not fail us. He must do the needful. His Backbenchers are not happy. He keeps them here since, and they are not happy. His people need him to empower them. The Majority Chief Whip should look into my eyes and let me talk to him. He should do something. They are not happy.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: Hon Members, I think the coded message is enough. The Majority Chief Whip understands the coded messages. So, you are in my hands, and I thank all of you.

Mr Dafeamekpor: Mr Speaker, just to thank you for the fortitude and my Brothers and Sisters on the other Side for the fortitude, and of course, my Backbench, my foot soldiers, for the support and the cooperation.

Mr Speaker, we know that during times like this, it is difficult to marshal the entire numbers because the Committees are sitting. So, we want to encourage Members to be here tomorrow. So that we can support them and close early. All we are saying is that we are grateful to them. But the "SOS" sent is well noted.

Mr Second Deputy Speaker: So, Hon Members. Let me also thank you for your cooperation.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was adjourned at 7:34 p.m. till 4th December, 2025 at 12 noon.

Editor's Note

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 16th December, 2025.